

# Running least common multiples: distinct heights and repeated sums

*Erdős Problem #269*

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## ABSTRACT

We study running least common multiples over fixed finite prime supports. For  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ , a five-map argument proves irrationality of the sum over distinct heights. Two-prime sums reduce to a transcendental Hecke–Mahler value. For the repeated three-prime sum we give an equivalent residue criterion, whose arithmetic condition remains open. Complete ordinary arguments for general distinct-height sums and prime-power subseries are retained as remarks awaiting formalisation.

## 1 Two sums from running least common multiples

Let  $P$  be a finite set of at least two primes, and let  $\mathcal{S}_P$  contain the positive integers supported on  $P$ , including 1. For  $x \geq 1$ , put

$$L(x) = \text{lcm}\{u \in \mathcal{S}_P : u \leq x\}, \quad H_P(x) = \prod_{p \in P} p^{\lfloor \log_p x \rfloor}.$$

Every supported integer below  $x$  divides  $H_P(x)$ , while each maximal pure power occurs in the prefix. Hence  $L(x) = H_P(x)$ , and the value changes only at a positive prime power. Counting each value once gives

$$\mathcal{D}_P = 1 + \sum_{\substack{t=p^n \\ p \in P, n \geq 1}} \frac{1}{H_P(t)}.$$

We begin with an irrationality result for three primes.

**Theorem 1.1** (the distinct-height sum at  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ ). *The sum  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$  is irrational.*

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The proof in Section 2 groups the jumps between consecutive powers of 2. A bound using the spacing of powers of 5 makes the five resulting affine images disjoint. We can then recover every later jump from one tail value. Rationality would leave only finitely many tail values and force a periodic word, contradicting the frequency of powers of 3.

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\**Authorship and AI use.* Will Cook built and directed the research infrastructure and reviewed the claims when he could. AI agents did most of the research and drafting. Cook did not independently verify every claim.

Erdős asserted the general conclusion for every finite  $P$  with  $|P| \geq 2$  in his letter of 1 January 1973, without printing a proof [3, p. 335]. The theorem above is a special case of that assertion. The general argument in Section 5.1 compares nearby tails and finds an isolated interchange of jumps on a torus. We retain it as an ordinary argument awaiting formalisation, with its intermediate claims stated as remarks. The specialised five-map proof is independent of that argument.

The question in Erdős Problem #269 retains multiplicities. If  $a_1 < a_2 < \dots$  enumerates  $\mathcal{S}_P$ , it asks about

$$\mathcal{R}_P = \sum_{n \geq 1} \frac{1}{[a_1, \dots, a_n]} = \sum_{u \in \mathcal{S}_P} \frac{1}{L(u)}$$

[1, p. 65][2, p. 106]; the numbering is Bloom's [4]. For  $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$ , the integers 5 and 6 both have running LCM 60. They contribute  $2/60$  to  $\mathcal{R}_P$  and  $1/60$  to  $\mathcal{D}_P$ . Thus Theorem 1.1 concerns a related, distinct target. The arguments in this record leave  $\mathcal{R}_P$  unresolved when  $P$  is finite and  $|P| \geq 3$ .

The finite-state extension in Section 5.3 allows the interval to depend on earlier blocks. Its saved exact calculations cover the three-prime sets at most 31 and 292 of the 330 four-prime sets in that range. The criterion and its applications also remain remarks awaiting formalisation. A collision between admissible automaton words prevents that decoder from treating  $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$  at any depth (Section 5.4); this is a limitation of the enlarged word language, not an identity between realised arithmetic tails.

For two primes the conclusion is stronger.

**Theorem 1.2** (two-prime transcendence). *Let  $p$  and  $q$  be distinct primes. Then  $\mathcal{R}_{\{p,q\}}$  and  $\mathcal{D}_{\{p,q\}}$  are transcendental.*

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The Lean proof assumes the transcendence theorem of Bugeaud and Laurent.

Fan's post of 26 June 2026 gave the finite-prime running-LCM identity, the factorisation of  $\mathcal{R}_{\{p,q\}}$ , and the Hecke–Mahler reduction with its transcendence conclusion [17]. We reproduce that calculation in Section 4. Both values are nonconstant polynomials over  $\mathbb{Q}$  in one boundary sum, whose transcendence follows from Loxton and van der Poorten [16, Theorem 8, p. 40], in the formulation of Bugeaud and Laurent [15, Theorem 1.1]. No priority is claimed for this deduction.

For the repeated three-prime sum, the normalised tails  $X_a$  at powers of two satisfy  $X_{a+1} = b_a X_a - m_a$ , with  $b_a \in \{2, 6, 10, 30\}$  and positive integer  $m_a$ . Both  $m_a$  and  $X_a$  grow quadratically. A hypothetical rational denominator splits into its  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  part and a factor  $B$  coprime to 30, and every sufficiently late  $BX_a$  is then integral. The window identity determines its residue at a later endpoint. A residue above the quadratic tail bound contradicts integrality. Irrationality is equivalent to finding such windows for every  $B$  and beyond every starting index. Neither these unbounded quantifiers nor an irrationality theorem for the repeated three-prime sum follows from the finite computations.

Section 2 contains the five-map proof and its exact interval calculations. The finite geometry and two-prime formulae follow in Sections 3 and 4. Section 5.1 gives the ordinary general argument, followed by the finite-state and prime-power subseries extensions. The independent-clock arguments in Section 6 are likewise recorded pending formalisation. Section 7 treats exact separation and uniform approximation of the kernel. The repeated-tail recurrence and residue criterion occupy Sections 8–10; the finite

calculations and open questions follow. Formal sources are collected in Section 12.5. The [short paper](#) concentrates on the five-map theorem and the [repeated-tail criterion](#).

We use  $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$  for exponents and braces for fractional parts. In the finite-geometry section and in the kernel calculation,  $P = \{p, q, r\}$  consists of three pairwise distinct primes,  $H = H_P$ , and

$$K(i, j, k) = H(p^i q^j r^k)^{-1}.$$

The other sections specify their prime sets separately. For  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ ,  $\mathcal{S}_P$  consists of the usual 5-smooth integers. This fixed support differs from a varying smoothness bound in  $\Psi(x, y)$  [11]. Tijdeman and Meijer [28, Sections 1–4] and the two-prime study of Languasco, Luca, Moree and Togbé [29] give the relevant lattice-counting context; the estimates below use no smooth-number density asymptotic or gap theorem. Kovač and Tao [13] study other unit-fraction series by elementary methods, without providing an input to these proofs.

**Keywords.** irrationality; transcendence; least common multiple; smooth numbers; Cantor series; separated rank. **MSC 2020.** 11J72 (primary); 11A05, 11N25, 68V20 (secondary).

## 2 Recovering the prime-power jumps

Throughout this section  $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$ . The argument uses only the height formula and the spacing of powers of 3 and 5; its definitions and prefix-integrality calculation are given here in full.

We group the prime-power jumps into the right-closed intervals  $(2^a, 2^{a+1}]$ . Each contains its terminal power of 2, at most one power of 3 and at most one power of 5. We write  $\tau_a$  for the sequence of interior prime labels, so that  $\tau_a \in \{\emptyset, 3, 5, 35, 53\}$ . Both orders occur: the block  $(16, 32]$  contains  $25 < 27$ , whereas  $(64, 128]$  contains  $81 < 125$ . We omit the terminal 2 from  $\tau_a$ .

*Proof of Theorem 1.1.* To remove the denominators of an initial segment, put  $P_a = H_{\{2,3,5\}}(2^a)$  and define

$$Y_a = P_a \sum_{\substack{t > 2^a \\ t = 2^n, 3^n \text{ or } 5^n, n \geq 1}} \frac{1}{H_{\{2,3,5\}}(t)}. \quad (1)$$

Every subsequent jump multiplies the height by at least 2, and a jump by 3 eventually occurs. Comparison with  $\sum_{j \geq 1} 2^{-j}$  therefore gives  $0 < Y_a < 1$ . Splitting off one block gives

$$Y_a = G_{\tau_a}(Y_{a+1}), \quad G_{\tau}(y) = \frac{\mu_{\tau} + y}{b_{\tau}}, \quad \begin{array}{c|ccccc} \tau & \emptyset & 3 & 5 & 35 & 53 \\ \hline b_{\tau} & 2 & 6 & 10 & 30 & 30 \\ \mu_{\tau} & 1 & 3 & 3 & 13 & 9 \end{array} \quad (2)$$

For example, a block of type 35 contributes  $1/3 + 1/15 + 1/30 = 13/30$  to the normalised tail. The same calculation for type 53 gives  $1/5 + 1/15 + 1/30 = 9/30$ . Thus the order of the two interior jumps changes the constant term of the map.

We need a narrower interval than  $(0, 1)$  to recover that order from a tail value. The table gives  $Y_a \geq 3/10$ . A power  $5^f$  belongs to block  $\lfloor f \log_2 5 \rfloor$ ; these block indices start at 2, and their successive differences are 2 or 3. Every three consecutive blocks therefore include a power of 5. At such a block, the bound  $Y_{a+1} < 1$  gives  $Y_a \leq G_{35}(1) = 7/15$ , which also bounds  $G_5(1)$  and  $G_{53}(1)$ . Before the next such block there are at most two maps, each equal to  $G_\emptyset$  or  $G_3$ . Since  $G_3(y) \leq G_\emptyset(y) = (1+y)/2$  for  $y \geq 0$ , we obtain

$$Y_a \in I = \left[ \frac{3}{10}, \frac{13}{15} \right], \quad G_\emptyset(G_\emptyset(7/15)) = \frac{13}{15}. \quad (3)$$

The spacing condition was needed to bound the arithmetic tails. The interval  $I$  is not invariant under arbitrary compositions of the five maps, since  $G_\emptyset(13/15) = 14/15$ .

On  $I$  the five images are disjoint. Their endpoints, listed in increasing order, are

| $\tau$      | $G_\tau(I)$          |
|-------------|----------------------|
| 53          | $[31/100, 74/225]$   |
| 5           | $[33/100, 29/75]$    |
| 35          | $[133/300, 104/225]$ |
| 3           | $[11/20, 29/45]$     |
| $\emptyset$ | $[13/20, 14/15]$     |

The consecutive gaps are  $1/900, 17/300, 79/900, 1/180$ . The two smallest gaps depend on  $3(3/10) - 13/15 = 1/30 > 0$ , so the preliminary upper bound 1 would not suffice. Since  $Y_{a+1} \in I$ , the value  $Y_a$  identifies  $\tau_a$  uniquely. We can then calculate  $Y_{a+1} = b_{\tau_a} Y_a - \mu_{\tau_a}$  and repeat the argument to recover every later block.

Suppose that  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}} = N/K$ , with integers  $N$  and  $K \geq 1$ . Every height at or before  $2^a$  divides  $P_a$ . Consequently

$$KY_a = P_a N - K \left( P_a + \sum_{\substack{t \leq 2^a \\ t=2^n, 3^n \text{ or } 5^n, n \geq 1}} \frac{P_a}{H_{\{2,3,5\}}(t)} \right) \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

There are only finitely many integers in  $[3K/10, 13K/15]$ , so two tail values agree. Recovery of all subsequent blocks then makes  $(\tau_a)$  eventually periodic.

To exclude this possibility, let  $\alpha = \log 2 / \log 3$ . The number of powers of 3 in block  $a$  is  $\lfloor (a+1)\alpha \rfloor - \lfloor a\alpha \rfloor$ , and is determined by  $\tau_a$ . If the block word has eventual period  $\ell \geq 1$ , let  $c$  be the number of 3-powers in one period. For every sufficiently large fixed  $a$  and every  $n \geq 1$  we then have

$$\lfloor (a+n\ell)\alpha \rfloor = \lfloor a\alpha \rfloor + nc.$$

Dividing by  $n$  and taking the limit gives  $\ell\alpha = c$ , contrary to unique factorisation, since it would imply  $2^\ell = 3^c$ .  $\square$

The Lean proof follows this route. It identifies  $H(t)$  with the running least common multiple, shows that the sum counts each distinct value once, identifies the contribution

of each dyadic block with one of the five pairs  $(b_\tau, \mu_\tau)$ , and proves that every three consecutive blocks contain a power of 5 and that the blocks containing a power of 3 are not eventually periodic. It then applies an irrationality criterion for block series with these five pairs, whose proof contains the bounds, the separation and the return above.

The first twelve block types are  $\emptyset, 3, 5, 3, 53, \emptyset, 35, 3, \emptyset, 53, \emptyset, 35$ . The saved numerical calculation over the first 3000 blocks reports tails in  $[0.3186, 0.7799]$ . These approximations are separate from the rational bounds used in the proof.

Grouping the jumps into dyadic blocks matters. One jump at a time, the tails  $x_k = (q_1 \cdots q_k) \sum_{j>k} (q_1 \cdots q_j)^{-1}$  satisfy  $x_k = (1 + x_{k+1})/q_{k+1}$  and  $1/4 \leq x_k \leq 1$ , and the images of  $[1/4, 1]$  under  $x \mapsto (1+x)/2$  and  $x \mapsto (1+x)/3$  overlap on  $[5/8, 2/3]$ . A tail before a jump by 2 cannot be told from a tail before a jump by 3 from these bounds alone.

Listing the jumps one at a time writes  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$  as a Cantor series with every digit equal to 1 and every base in  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ . The criteria of Erdős–Straus [18, Theorem 2.1] and Hančl–Tijdeman [19, Theorem 3.1], recalled in Section 9, assume that each digit divided by the product of the last two bases in its denominator tends to 0. Here that quotient is at least  $1/25$ , so neither criterion applies.

### 3 The finite geometry of the running value

We first describe which smooth integers contribute the same running value. The LCM is determined by the largest exponent of each prime in the prefix. For the unrestricted prefix this gives  $\text{lcm}(1, \dots, N) = \prod_{t \leq N} t^{\lfloor \log_t N \rfloor}$ , with  $t$  running over primes, and hence  $\log \text{lcm}(1, \dots, N) = \psi(N)$ ; see Apostol [10] and Montgomery and Vaughan [12]. We apply the same exponent rule to a fixed prime support, keeping track of the intervals on which the height is constant.

The smooth numbers up to  $x$  are indexed by the exponent triples  $(i, j, k)$  with  $i \leq \lfloor \log_p x \rfloor$ ,  $j \leq \lfloor \log_q x \rfloor$ ,  $k \leq \lfloor \log_r x \rfloor$  and  $p^i q^j r^k \leq x$ . The coordinate bounds alone need not describe the prefix: each prime-power factor may be at most  $x$  while their product exceeds  $x$ . For instance, at  $x = 6$  the factors 4, 3 and 5 satisfy their coordinate bounds, but the corresponding smooth number is 60.

**Theorem 3.1** (the running least common multiple). *Let  $p, q, r$  be pairwise distinct primes and  $x \geq 1$ . Then  $L(x) = H(x)$ .*

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*Proof.* Every smooth  $n \leq x$  has exponents bounded by the corresponding integer logarithms, so  $n \mid H(x)$  and hence  $L(x) \mid H(x)$ . Conversely the three pure powers  $p^{\lfloor \log_p x \rfloor}$ ,  $q^{\lfloor \log_q x \rfloor}$  and  $r^{\lfloor \log_r x \rfloor}$  are themselves smooth numbers not exceeding  $x$ , so each divides  $L(x)$ , and distinct primes have coprime powers, so their product divides  $L(x)$  as well.  $\square$

At  $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$  the first ten values are

| $x$    | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4  | 5  | 6  | 7  | 8   | 9   | 10  |
|--------|---|---|---|----|----|----|----|-----|-----|-----|
| $L(x)$ | 1 | 2 | 6 | 12 | 60 | 60 | 60 | 120 | 360 | 360 |

So  $L(6) = 4 \cdot 3 \cdot 5 = 60$ , which exceeds 6: the running value at a smooth cutoff already contains powers of the other two primes that the cutoff itself does not. The kernel must

therefore account for all three maximal powers, not just the factorisation of the cutoff. Also  $H(x) \leq x^3$ , since each factor is at most  $x$ . The exponent is the number of generating primes.

Say that  $x$  and  $y$  lie in the same *logarithmic cell* when  $\lfloor \log_b x \rfloor = \lfloor \log_b y \rfloor$  for each of  $b = p, q, r$ . By Theorem 3.1 the running value depends on  $x$  only through the three integer logarithms, so it is constant on cells and moves only where one logarithm moves.

**Proposition 3.2** (constancy and jump ratios). *If  $x, y \geq 1$  lie in the same logarithmic cell then  $L(x) = L(y)$ , and the same holds for the kernel at two smooth points of one cell. If  $\lfloor \log_p y \rfloor = \lfloor \log_p x \rfloor + 1$  while the other two logarithms agree, then  $L(y) = p L(x)$ , and similarly with  $q$  or  $r$  in place of  $p$ .*

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*Proof.* Both parts are immediate from Theorem 3.1: the height depends on  $x$  only through the three integer logarithms, and advancing one of them multiplies exactly one factor by its base.  $\square$

**Proposition 3.3** (jump count). *Let  $n \geq 0$ . The set of the first  $n$  positive powers of  $p$ , of  $q$  and of  $r$  has exactly  $3n$  elements, and adjoining the common origin 1 gives exactly  $3n + 1$ .*

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*Proof.* For a fixed prime  $b$ , the powers  $b, b^2, \dots, b^n$  are distinct. A common value for two different primes would contradict unique factorisation. Finally 1 is not a positive power of any prime.  $\square$

The later tail estimates use two elementary counting facts. Write  $\mathcal{B}(h_p, h_q, h_r)$  for the exponent triples with  $i \leq h_p, j \leq h_q$  and  $k \leq h_r$ , and  $F(H)$  for the points of this box whose height equals  $H$ .

**Proposition 3.4** (grouping equal heights). *For every box  $\mathcal{B}$ ,*

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$$\sum_{(i,j,k) \in \mathcal{B}} K(i,j,k) = \sum_H \#F(H)/H,$$

*the outer sum ranging over the heights attained on  $\mathcal{B}$ .*

*Proof.* Partition  $\mathcal{B}$  into the fibres of the height map. On  $F(H)$  every summand is  $1/H$ , so the fibre contributes  $\#F(H)/H$ .  $\square$

Now fix an interval  $[\lambda, \eta)$  with  $0 \leq \lambda < \eta$  and write  $\mathcal{S}$  for the exponent triples of  $\mathcal{B}(h_p, h_q, h_r)$  whose value  $p^i q^j r^k$  lies in it. In the next lemma, the exponents  $a, a'$  are nonnegative integers, and  $w \geq 0$  is the product of the fixed factors.

**Lemma 3.5** (uniqueness in a short interval). *Let  $b \geq 1$  and  $\eta \leq b\lambda$ . If  $b^a w$  and  $b^{a'} w$  both lie in  $[\lambda, \eta)$  then  $a = a'$ .*

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*Proof.* If  $a < a'$  then  $\eta \leq b\lambda \leq b^{a+1}w \leq b^{a'}w < \eta$ , which is impossible; the case  $a > a'$  is symmetric.  $\square$

The short-interval condition says that multiplying by the omitted base moves a point beyond the interval. It holds for  $[L, 2L)$  when that base is at least two. A wider interval need not have this property: 1 and 2 both lie in  $[1, 3)$  and have the same odd part. Thus the ratio bound, not just finiteness of the interval, permits the injective projection.

**Proposition 3.6** (counting a shell by two coordinates). *If  $\eta \leq r\lambda$  then  $\#\mathcal{S} \leq (h_p + 1)(h_q + 1)$ , and if  $\eta \leq p\lambda$  then  $\#\mathcal{S} \leq (h_q + 1)(h_r + 1)$ . If moreover  $\eta \leq r\lambda$  and  $h_p \leq h_q \leq h_r$  with  $h_p + h_q + h_r = j$ , then  $9\#\mathcal{S} \leq (j + 3)^2$ .*

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*Proof.* Suppose  $\eta \leq r\lambda$ . If two triples of  $\mathcal{S}$  agree in their first two coordinates, Lemma 3.5 with  $b = r$  and  $w = p^i q^j$  forces their third coordinates to agree, so the projection forgetting the third coordinate is injective on  $\mathcal{S}$  and its image lies in a rectangle with  $(h_p + 1)(h_q + 1)$  points. The other case is the same with the first coordinate projected away. Under the sorting hypothesis the two surviving coordinates are the two smallest, so it suffices that  $a \leq b \leq c$  with  $a + b + c = j$  gives  $9(a + 1)(b + 1) \leq (j + 3)^2$ . From  $a \leq b \leq c$  we get  $a + 2b \leq j$ , so it is enough that  $9(a + 1)(b + 1) \leq (a + 2b + 3)^2$ ; writing  $b = a + d$  with  $d \geq 0$ , the difference of the two sides is  $d(3a + 4d + 3) \geq 0$ .  $\square$

## 4 The two-prime Hecke–Mahler reduction

Let  $P = \{p, q\}$  with  $p < q$ , and put  $L_{p,q}(t) = p^{\lfloor \log_p t \rfloor} q^{\lfloor \log_q t \rfloor}$ . The proof of Theorem 3.1, with one coordinate omitted, identifies this with the running LCM. The two sums are therefore

$$\mathcal{D}_{\{p,q\}} = 1 + \sum_{t \in \{p, p^2, \dots\} \cup \{q, q^2, \dots\}} \frac{1}{L_{p,q}(t)}, \quad \mathcal{R}_{\{p,q\}} = \sum_{i,j \geq 0} \frac{1}{L_{p,q}(p^i q^j)}.$$

We shall express both in terms of the sum over powers of  $p$ . This gives the factorisation credited to Fan in the introduction and reduces the transcendence assertion to the cited Hecke–Mahler theorem.

*Proof of Theorem 1.2.* Set

$$\theta = \frac{\log p}{\log q}, \quad x = \frac{1}{p}, \quad y = \frac{1}{q}, \quad m_n = \lfloor n\theta \rfloor, \quad \delta_n = m_{n+1} - m_n.$$

Here  $0 < \theta < 1$ , and  $\theta$  is irrational, since a rational value would give  $p^b = q^a$  for positive integers  $a, b$ . Consequently  $\delta_n \in \{0, 1\}$ . Put

$$A = \sum_{n \geq 0} x^n y^{m_n}, \quad B_* = \sum_{n \geq 0} \delta_n x^n y^{m_n+1}.$$

The initial value and the positive powers of  $p$  contribute  $A$ , since  $L_{p,q}(p^n) = p^n q^{m_n}$ . A power of  $q$  lies strictly between  $p^n$  and  $p^{n+1}$  exactly when  $\delta_n = 1$ , it is then  $q^{m_n+1}$ , and its post-jump reciprocal is  $x^n y^{m_n+1}$ ; so the positive powers of  $q$  contribute  $B_*$  and  $\mathcal{D}_{\{p,q\}} = A + B_*$ . All these series converge absolutely.

Since  $y^{m_{n+1}} - y^{m_n} = \delta_n y^{m_n} (y - 1)$ , an index shift gives  $A - 1 - xA = x(y - 1)B_*/y$ , so  $B_* = ((p - 1)A - p)/(1 - q)$  and

$$\mathcal{D}_{\{p,q\}} = \frac{(q - p)A + p}{q - 1}. \quad (4)$$

At a smooth point,  $\log_p(p^i q^j) = i + j/\theta$  and  $\log_q(p^i q^j) = j + i\theta$ , so  $L_{p,q}(p^i q^j) = p^{i + \lfloor j/\theta \rfloor} q^{j + m_i}$  and absolute convergence permits the factorisation

$$\mathcal{R}_{\{p,q\}} = A \sum_{j \geq 0} y^j x^{\lfloor j/\theta \rfloor}.$$

For  $j \geq 1$ , the index  $n = \lfloor j/\theta \rfloor$  is precisely the one for which  $p^n < q^j < p^{n+1}$ ; the inequalities are strict because distinct primes have no common positive power. This interval contains at most one power of  $q$ , since  $p < q$ . Thus  $\delta_n = 1$  and  $j = m_n + 1$ . Conversely, every  $n$  with  $\delta_n = 1$  contains that unique power of  $q$ . The second factor is therefore  $1 + B_*$ , giving

$$\mathcal{R}_{\{p,q\}} = \frac{(p + q - 1)A - (p - 1)A^2}{q - 1}. \quad (5)$$

It remains to prove that  $A$  is transcendental. For the Hecke–Mahler series

$$F_\theta(x, y) = \sum_{n \geq 1} \sum_{k=1}^{\lfloor n\theta \rfloor} x^n y^k$$

a finite geometric sum gives  $((1 - y)/y)F_\theta(x, y) = x/(1 - x) - (A - 1)$ , that is

$$A = \frac{1}{1 - x} - \frac{1 - y}{y} F_\theta(x, y). \quad (6)$$

Bugeaud and Laurent’s Theorem 1.1 states, in particular, that  $F_\theta(\beta, \alpha)$  is transcendental when  $\theta \in (0, 1)$  is irrational,  $\alpha$  and  $\beta$  are nonzero algebraic numbers,  $|\beta| < 1$  and  $|\beta \alpha^\theta| < 1$  [15, Theorem 1.1]; the  $\rho = 0$  case used here goes back to Loxton and van der Poorten [16, Theorem 8, p. 40]. Take  $(\beta, \alpha) = (x, y)$ : then  $|\beta| = 1/p < 1$  and

$$|xy^\theta| = \frac{1}{p} \left( \frac{1}{q} \right)^{\log p / \log q} = \frac{1}{p^2} < 1.$$

So  $F_\theta(x, y)$  is transcendental, and (6) makes  $A$  transcendental. The coefficient of  $A$  in (4) is  $(q - p)/(q - 1) \neq 0$  and the coefficient of  $A^2$  in (5) is  $-(p - 1)/(q - 1) \neq 0$ , both rational. If either value were algebraic, its identity would exhibit  $A$  as a root of a nonzero polynomial over the algebraic numbers.  $\square$

A product of two transcendental numbers need not be transcendental. What proves the repeated sum transcendental is its nonconstant quadratic expression in the single value  $A$ , not the factorisation by itself. The value theorem adds no unverified hypothesis in this two-prime case: distinct primes give an irrational slope and the displayed reciprocal arguments satisfy its size conditions. Primality is stronger than the calculation needs.

For coprime integers  $1 < p < q$ , enumerate the monoid  $\{p^i q^j : i, j \geq 0\}$ , not all integers supported on the prime factors of  $pq$ . Unique exponent pairs, the running-LCM product and the irrationality of  $\log p / \log q$  still hold, so both identities and transcendence conclusions remain valid. For example, this applies to generators 4, 9. By contrast, the monoid generated by 4, 8 has running LCM 8 at the cutoff 8, not  $4^{\lfloor \log_4 8 \rfloor} 8^{\lfloor \log_8 8 \rfloor} = 32$ ; its slope is rational as well. The coprime extension was already noted in the forum discussion (Section 13.1).

A third prime introduces an additional floor term that cannot be separated in this way; Section 7 makes that obstruction precise. For the distinct-height sums, the next section proves irrationality for every finite set of primes by an elementary argument that uses no value theorem.

## 5 The distinct-height sums

We record the ordinary arguments for general finite prime supports. Their assertions, including the block and finite-state criteria below, are presented as remarks because this part has not been formalised. The complete proofs are retained. The five-map theorem in Section 2 has a separate formal proof. No argument here gives transcendence for more than two primes.

Let  $P$  be a finite set of at least two primes, with least element  $p$ , and put  $H_P(t) = \prod_{r \in P} r^{\lfloor \log_r t \rfloor}$ . The proofs of Theorem 3.1 and Propositions 3.2 and 3.3 apply unchanged to any finite set of primes: the running least common multiple of the  $P$ -smooth integers up to  $t$  is  $H_P(t)$ , it changes only at the prime powers  $r^n$  ( $r \in P$ ,  $n \geq 1$ ), where it is multiplied by  $r$ , and distinct prime powers are distinct numbers. List the prime powers as  $t_1 < t_2 < \dots$  and let  $q_k$  be the prime of  $t_k$ . The distinct running values are then 1 and  $H_P(t_k) = q_1 \cdots q_k$ , so

$$\mathcal{D}_P = 1 + \sum_{k \geq 1} \frac{1}{H_P(t_k)} = \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{1}{q_1 \cdots q_k}. \quad (7)$$

This is the sum  $\Sigma'$  of Erdős's letter [3], which counts each distinct value of  $[a_1, \dots, a_n]$  once. For  $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$  the prime powers 2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 16, 25, 27, 32 give the following terms, including the initial 1

$$1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{6}, \frac{1}{12}, \frac{1}{60}, \frac{1}{120}, \frac{1}{360}, \frac{1}{720}, \frac{1}{3600}, \frac{1}{10800}, \frac{1}{21600}, \dots$$

Numerically,  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}} = 1.77961698329474905045919064931698327 \dots$ . Put  $Q_k = q_1 \cdots q_k = H_P(t_k)$ .

### 5.1 Proof for an arbitrary finite prime set

*Remark 5.1* (the distinct-height sums). For every finite set  $P$  of primes with  $|P| \geq 2$ , the sum  $\mathcal{D}_P$  is irrational.

We begin with the lattice of normalised tails. A long common prefix makes two such tails equal under rationality; the rest of the proof constructs a later pair of jumps whose reversal is incompatible with that equality.

**Words and tails.** For an infinite word  $u = u_1 u_2 \dots$  over  $P$ , define  $V(u) = \sum_{j \geq 1} (u_1 \dots u_j)^{-1}$ . For a nonempty finite word  $\sigma = \sigma_1 \dots \sigma_n$ , put

$$\Pi(\sigma) = \sigma_1 \dots \sigma_n, \quad f(\sigma) = \sum_{j=1}^n \sigma_{j+1} \dots \sigma_n.$$

The final term in  $f$  is 1. Removing a prefix gives

$$V(\sigma u) = \frac{f(\sigma) + V(u)}{\Pi(\sigma)}. \quad (8)$$

We apply this identity to  $x_k = V(q_{k+1} q_{k+2} \dots) = \sum_{j > k} Q_k / Q_j$ . Every suffix contains every prime of  $P$ , so  $0 < x_k < 1/(\min P - 1) \leq 1$ .

*Remark 5.2* (integral tails). If  $\mathcal{D}_P = N/K$  with integers  $N$  and  $K \geq 1$ , then  $Kx_k$  is an integer for every  $k \geq 1$ .

*Proof.* Each  $Q_i$  with  $i \leq k$  divides  $Q_k$ . Multiplication of the defining series by  $Q_k$  therefore gives

$$Kx_k = Q_k N - K \left( Q_k + \sum_{i \leq k} \frac{Q_k}{Q_i} \right) \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

□

Two words with a long common prefix have close values. When the words differ only by rearrangements, equality of their values imposes a stronger condition on every rearranged block.

*Remark 5.3* (rearranged blocks). Let  $u = \sigma_1 \sigma_2 \dots$  and  $u' = \sigma'_1 \sigma'_2 \dots$  be infinite words, where each  $\sigma_i$  is a nonempty finite word and  $\sigma'_i$  is a rearrangement of it, and suppose that every suffix of  $u$  or  $u'$  starting at a block boundary has value in  $(0, 1)$ .

- (i) If  $V(u) = V(u')$ , then  $f(\sigma_i) = f(\sigma'_i)$  for every  $i$ .
- (ii) If  $\sigma_i = \sigma'_i$  for every  $i < i_0$ , then  $|V(u) - V(u')| < 1/\Pi(\sigma_1 \dots \sigma_{i_0-1})$ .

*Proof.* Let  $U_i$  and  $U'_i$  be the values starting at block  $i$ . Since the two blocks have the same product, (8) yields

$$\Pi(\sigma_i)(U_i - U'_i) = f(\sigma_i) - f(\sigma'_i) + U_{i+1} - U'_{i+1}.$$

If  $U_i = U'_i$ , the integer on the right equals a number in  $(-1, 1)$ , and hence both differences vanish. Induction proves (i). If the preceding blocks agree, repeated removal of their common prefix gives

$$V(u) - V(u') = \frac{U_{i_0} - U'_{i_0}}{\Pi(\sigma_1 \dots \sigma_{i_0-1})},$$

which proves (ii). □

*Remark 5.4* (short rearrangements). The map  $f$  is injective on the orderings of any set of at most three distinct primes.

*Proof.* For two letters,  $f(ab) = 1 + b$ . For three,  $f(abc) = 1 + c(1 + b)$ . Suppose two orderings of  $\{a, b, c\}$  have the same value. If their last letters agree, their middle letters agree too. Otherwise we may write  $a(1 + s) = b(1 + t)$ , with  $s \in \{b, c\}$  and  $t \in \{a, c\}$ . The choices  $(s, t) = (b, a)$  and  $(c, c)$  imply  $a = b$ ; the other two imply  $b \mid a$  or  $a \mid b$ . Each is impossible for distinct primes.  $\square$

There is a collision on four letters:  $f(5, 7, 3, 2) = f(7, 2, 3, 5) = 51$ . Consequently, a change in order alone will not suffice for larger  $P$ . We shall arrange an isolated interchange of two letters, for which  $f(ab) - f(ba) = b - a \neq 0$ .

**The logarithmic flow.** Consider

$$\mathbb{T} = \prod_{q \in P} \mathbb{R} / (\log q) \mathbb{Z}, \quad \Theta(s) = (s \bmod \log q)_{q \in P}.$$

For  $\theta \in \mathbb{T}$ , a  $q$ -crossing is a time  $t$  at which  $\theta_q + t \in (\log q) \mathbb{Z}$ . At  $\theta_k = \Theta(\log t_k)$  the positive crossings occur at  $\log(q^j / t_k)$  with  $q^j > t_k$ , so their labels, read in time order, are  $q_{k+1} q_{k+2} \dots$ . Crossings at this phase never coincide.

Let  $T_0$  be the closure of  $\Theta(\mathbb{R})$ . Every forward orbit in  $T_0$  is dense there. Indeed, the pigeonhole principle gives arbitrarily large  $d > 0$  with  $\Theta(d)$  arbitrarily close to 0, so negative times are limits of positive ones. Translation then proves the same assertion for every starting point and every later starting time.

In the normalised coordinates  $\varphi_q = \theta_q / \log q$ , Kronecker's theorem identifies  $T_0$  with the image of the smallest rational subspace  $L \subseteq \mathbb{R}^P$  containing  $\omega = (1 / \log q)_{q \in P}$ . Any two coordinate forms  $\varphi_a, \varphi_b$  are linearly independent on  $L$ . To see this, their dependence would put a nonzero vector supported on  $\{a, b\}$  in the rational annihilator of  $L$ . That intersection is rational, so it would contain a nonzero integer vector. Its pairing with  $\omega$  would force  $\log a / \log b \in \mathbb{Q}$ , contrary to unique factorisation. In particular,  $(\log b) \varphi_b - (\log a) \varphi_a$  is a nonzero form on  $L$ . We write it as  $\theta_b - \theta_a$  when using real representatives.

*Remark 5.5 (two walls).* If  $|P| \geq 4$ , there is  $x \in T_0$  with  $\theta_q(x) = 0$  for exactly two primes  $q \in P$ .

*Proof.* Choose a rational plane in  $L$  on which every pair of coordinate forms remains independent. Such a plane exists: for each pair, the determinant on  $L \times L$  is a nonzero polynomial, and finitely many of these polynomials cannot vanish on all rational pairs. An integer basis of the plane identifies its image with a two-dimensional subtorus of  $T_0$ . On this subtorus each wall  $\theta_q = 0$  has the equation  $\langle \gamma_q, s \rangle \in \mathbb{Z}$ , where  $\gamma_q \in \mathbb{Z}^2 \setminus \{0\}$ , and the vectors  $\gamma_q$  are pairwise nonparallel. A wall may have several components if  $\gamma_q$  is not primitive.

The walls form a finite arrangement of closed geodesics. Let  $k_v$  count the wall families through a vertex  $v$ . Each such family contributes two incident half-edges, so  $E = \sum_v k_v$ . Two families alone divide the torus into open parallelograms: their two integer linear forms give a finite covering of the standard torus. Adding the remaining straight lines subdivides these parallelograms into convex polygons, each with at least three sides. Thus  $2E \geq 3F$ , while Euler's formula gives  $V - E + F = 0$ . Together these imply

$$\sum_v (k_v - 3) = E - 3V \leq 0.$$

The origin belongs to all  $|P| \geq 4$  families. If every other vertex also belonged to at least three, the last sum would be positive. Hence some vertex belongs to exactly two families, as required.  $\square$

### Comparison of two tails.

*Proof of Remark 5.1.* Suppose that  $\mathcal{D}_P = N/K$ , with  $K \geq 1$ . Fix  $p \in P$  and a jump  $t_k$  which is a power of  $p$ . We shall compare the tails after  $t_k$  and  $t_m = t_k p^n$ , choosing  $n$  so that multiplication by  $p^n$  moves all logarithmic phases very little.

Choose  $T > 0$  so that the number  $\nu$  of crossings in  $(0, T]$  satisfies  $2^\nu \geq K$ , and let  $g > 0$  be the minimum gap between distinct crossings in  $[0, T + 1]$ . Put  $\beta = \min_{q \neq p} \text{dist}(\theta_{k,q}, 0) > 0$ . When  $|P| \geq 4$ , also choose the point  $x$  and primes  $a, b$  from Remark 5.5, and set

$$\eta = \min \left( \frac{1}{10}, \min_{c \neq a, b} \text{dist}(\theta_c(x), 0) \right) > 0.$$

Take  $\varepsilon < \min(\beta, g/2, \log 2/(2|P|))$ , and in this latter case require also  $\varepsilon < \eta/8$ . Dirichlet's simultaneous approximation theorem gives arbitrarily large  $n$  and integers  $m_q \geq 1$  for  $q \neq p$  such that

$$\delta_p = 0, \quad \delta_q = n \log p - m_q \log q, \quad \max_q |\delta_q| < \varepsilon.$$

The numbers  $\delta_q$  are pairwise distinct, since an equality would identify positive powers of distinct primes.

At  $\theta_m = \theta_k + \Theta(n \log p)$  a  $q$ -crossing moves by  $-\delta_q$ . For  $q \neq p$  every crossing of  $\theta_k$  is at distance at least  $\beta$  from 0, so signs are preserved; the  $p$ -crossings do not move. We therefore obtain a bijection between the positive crossings of the two phases.

Cut the crossings of  $\theta_k$  whenever successive times are more than  $2\varepsilon$  apart, and call each resulting block a chain. Different chains keep their order after the shift. A chain contains at most  $|P|$  crossings, all of different primes: otherwise its first  $|P| + 1$  crossings would span less than  $2\varepsilon|P| < \log 2$ , although some prime would have to occur twice. The same argument excludes a repeated prime in a shorter chain. Thus the two tail words are concatenations of the same chains, with the letters possibly rearranged inside each chain.

Every chain meeting  $(0, T]$  is a singleton, by the choice of  $g$  and  $\varepsilon$ . The first  $\nu$  letters consequently agree, and Remark 5.3(ii) gives  $|x_k - x_m| < 2^{-\nu} \leq 1/K$ . The integral-tail lemma forces  $x_k = x_m$ . By Remark 5.3(i), every chain  $C$  and its rearrangement  $C'$  now satisfy  $f(C) = f(C')$ .

When  $|P| \leq 3$ , choose  $q \neq p$ . If  $\delta_q > 0$ , density of  $j \log p - i \log q + \log t_k$  for large positive  $i, j$  supplies crossings  $s_p, s_q > 0$  with  $s_q - \delta_q < s_p < s_q$ . Their order reverses. The case  $\delta_q < 0$  is the same with the inequalities reversed. The two crossings belong to one chain, which has at most three distinct primes and changes its order. This contradicts Remark 5.4.

For  $|P| \geq 4$ , put  $D = \delta_a - \delta_b \neq 0$ . Since the form  $\theta_b - \theta_a$  is nonzero on  $L$ , choose a small  $y \in L$  with  $|\theta_q(y)| < \eta/8$  for all  $q$  and  $\theta_b(y) - \theta_a(y)$  strictly between 0 and  $D$ . At the phase

$$z = x + y + \Theta(-\eta/2)$$

there is one  $a$ -crossing and one  $b$ -crossing in  $[-\eta/4, 5\eta/4]$ . Their times  $\tau_a, \tau_b$  lie in  $(\eta/4, 3\eta/4)$ , and  $\tau_a - \tau_b$  is strictly between 0 and  $D$ . There are no other crossings in that interval: for  $c \neq a, b$  the nearest one is at distance at least  $7\eta/8$  from  $\eta/2$ .

These properties persist in a neighbourhood  $U$  of  $z$  in  $T_0$ ; all crossing positions and the difference condition have strict margins. Density gives  $t^* > T + 2$  with  $\theta_k + \Theta(t^*) \in U$ . The two corresponding crossings of  $\theta_k$  are less than  $|D| < 2\varepsilon$  apart, whereas every other crossing is more than  $\eta/2 > 4\varepsilon$  away. They form a chain of length two. After shifting, their time difference becomes  $(\tau_a - \tau_b) - D$ , which has the opposite sign. Thus  $C = ab, C' = ba$  or conversely, contradicting  $f(ab) - f(ba) = b - a \neq 0$ .  $\square$

**Reversals near the origin.** A shorter route would take, at a return of the orbit near the origin of  $T_0$ , the chain of crossings there. That shortcut need not work when  $\dim T_0 = 2$ , which happens exactly when the numbers  $1/\log q$  span a two-dimensional space over  $\mathbb{Q}$ ; the proof makes no assumption excluding this case. Linear-form estimates for logarithms do not supply the required independence of their reciprocals. In that case every small vector of  $L$ , in the coordinates  $\theta_q$ , has the form  $\alpha(1, \dots, 1) + \beta w$  for one fixed  $w$ , so near the origin all the forms  $\theta_b - \theta_a$  are proportional. The chain at such a return contains every prime of  $P$ , and the only rearrangement it can undergo is the full reversal. Full reversals can collide:

$$f(43, 13, 3, 53) = f(53, 3, 13, 43) = 2280,$$

and among the sets of four primes below 100 there are five such collisions. Remark 5.5 avoids the question by producing a point on exactly two walls for every  $P$  with  $|P| \geq 4$ ; a point on three walls would also serve, by Remark 5.4. Swapping one adjacent pair always changes  $f$ , since  $f(\sigma) - f(\sigma') = (\sigma_{i+1} - \sigma_i)\sigma_{i+2} \cdots \sigma_n$  when  $\sigma'$  swaps  $\sigma_i$  and  $\sigma_{i+1}$ ; a rearranged chain of four or more primes can differ from its image by more than one swap. Nor can the argument stop at the first rearranged chain: for four primes that chain can collide, as  $f(5, 7, 3, 2) = f(7, 2, 3, 5) = 51$  shows, which is why Remark 5.3(i) is applied to every chain.

**Exact illustrations.** The program `two_tail.py` of the [distinct-height programs](#) checks the finite facts above in exact arithmetic; the proof uses none of them. Among the sets of two or three primes below 200,  $f$  has no collision; among the 2380 sets of four primes below 60 it has 30. For  $P = \{2, 3, 5, 7\}$ ,  $t_k = 2^{60}$  and the return  $n = 283526$ , with  $\varepsilon \approx 0.0117$ , the first 4000 crossings correspond exactly, every chain stays in place, and of the 39 rearranged chains 35 are transpositions; none has equal  $f$ -values. For the closer return  $n = 2547450$ , with  $\varepsilon \approx 0.0034$ , the difference  $x_k - x_m$  computed exactly has  $\log_{10} |x_k - x_m| = -501.1234$ , the value predicted by its first rearranged chain,  $(5, 2)$  against  $(2, 5)$  after 1005 letters. On 400 random arrangements of four to six line families on  $\mathbb{R}^2/\mathbb{Z}^2$ , some with non-primitive normal vectors,  $\sum_v (k_v - 3) \leq -4$ ; the square with both diagonals attains 0 and still has a vertex on exactly two lines.

## 5.2 Dyadic blocks and affine maps

We now extend the calculation of Section 2 to an arbitrary finite prime set.

To obtain a second description of the distinct-height sum, group its jumps into  $(p^a, p^{a+1}]$ , where  $p$  is the least prime of  $P$ , and define

$$P_a = H_P(p^a), \quad Y_a = P_a \sum_{t_k > p^a} \frac{1}{H_P(t_k)}.$$

Write  $\tau_a = (r_1, \dots, r_v)$  for the labels of the jumps strictly inside block  $a$ , in increasing order of their powers. This is the block's *type*; write  $\emptyset$  when there is no interior jump. The final jump at  $p^{a+1}$  always has label  $p$ .

*Remark 5.6* (blocks, tails and integrality). Let  $P$  be a finite set of at least two primes with least element  $p$ .

- (i) Block  $a$  ends with the jump at  $p^{a+1}$  and contains at most one power of each prime  $q \in P \setminus \{p\}$ , lying strictly inside it. The power  $q^f$  with  $f \geq 1$  lies in block  $\lfloor f \log_p q \rfloor$ .
- (ii) If block  $a$  has type  $\tau = (r_1, \dots, r_v)$ , then  $Y_a = G_\tau(Y_{a+1})$ , where

$$G_\tau(y) = \frac{\mu_\tau + y}{b_\tau}, \quad b_\tau = pr_1 \cdots r_v, \quad \mu_\tau = 1 + b_\tau \sum_{j=1}^v \frac{1}{r_1 \cdots r_j}.$$

Each  $G_\tau$  is increasing with slope  $1/b_\tau \leq 1/p$  and maps  $[0, 1/(p-1)]$  into itself, and  $0 < Y_a \leq 1/(p-1)$ .

- (iii) If  $\mathcal{D}_P = N/K$  with integers  $N$  and  $K \geq 1$ , then  $KY_a$  is an integer for every  $a \geq 0$ .

*Proof.* (i) The endpoint  $p^{a+1}$  is a jump. Consecutive powers of  $q$  have ratio  $q > p$ , so the block contains at most one of them, and no power of  $q$  equals a power of  $p$ . The power  $q^f$  lies in  $(p^a, p^{a+1})$  exactly when  $a < f \log_p q < a+1$ .

(ii) The jumps of block  $a$  are the interior powers, with heights  $P_a r_1, P_a r_1 r_2, \dots, P_a r_1 \cdots r_v$ , followed by the jump at  $p^{a+1}$ , whose height is  $P_{a+1} = b_\tau P_a$ . Splitting off the block,

$$Y_a = \sum_{j=1}^v \frac{1}{r_1 \cdots r_j} + \frac{1}{b_\tau} + \frac{P_a}{P_{a+1}} Y_{a+1} = \frac{\mu_\tau + Y_{a+1}}{b_\tau}.$$

Each jump multiplies the height by at least  $p$ , so  $0 < Y_a \leq \sum_{k \geq 1} p^{-k} = 1/(p-1)$ . Since every  $r_j > p$ ,  $G_\tau(1/(p-1)) \leq \sum_{j=1}^v p^{-j} + p^{-v}/(p-1) = 1/(p-1)$ , and  $G_\tau(0) > 0$ .

(iii) If  $t \leq p^a$ , each exponent in  $H_P(t)$  is at most the corresponding exponent in  $P_a$ , so  $H_P(t) \mid P_a$ . Hence  $P_a \mathcal{D}_P - Y_a = P_a(1 + \sum_{t_k \leq p^a} H_P(t_k)^{-1})$  is an integer, and so is  $KY_a = P_a N - K(P_a \mathcal{D}_P - Y_a)$ .  $\square$

### 5.3 A decoding criterion for every finite set of primes

For other prime sets, a useful tail interval may depend on the recent occurrence of each prime. Put  $Q = P \setminus \{p\}$  and choose the integer  $g_q$  by  $p^{g_q} < q < p^{g_q+1}$ . Successive blocks containing a  $q$ -power have indices  $\lfloor f \log_p q \rfloor$  and  $\lfloor (f+1) \log_p q \rfloor$ , by Remark 5.6(i). Their difference is  $g_q$  or  $g_q + 1$ . These gap constraints provide finite memory for a state-dependent interval construction.

These constraints define a finite automaton. Its states are the tuples  $s = (s_q)_{q \in Q}$  with  $1 \leq s_q \leq g_q + 1$ ; the entry  $s_q$  counts the blocks since the last block containing a power of  $q$ . A *transition* from  $s$  is a pair  $(\tau, s')$  in which  $\tau$  is an ordering of a set  $T \subseteq Q$  with

$$\{q : s_q = g_q + 1\} \subseteq T \subseteq \{q : s_q \geq g_q\},$$

and  $s'_q = 1$  for  $q \in T$ ,  $s'_q = s_q + 1$  for  $q \notin T$ . A path from  $s$  is a sequence of transitions  $(u_1, s_1), (u_2, s_2), \dots$  with  $(u_1, s_1)$  a transition from  $s$  and each  $(u_{i+1}, s_{i+1})$  a transition from  $s_i$ . The *value* of an infinite path is the limit of  $G_{u_1} \circ \dots \circ G_{u_n}(y)$  as  $n \rightarrow \infty$ ; by Remark 5.6(ii) these numbers lie, for  $y \in [0, 1/(p-1)]$ , in nested intervals of length at most  $p^{-n}/(p-1)$ , so the limit exists and does not depend on  $y$ .

Every prime  $q \in Q$  lies in block  $g_q$ . For  $a > \max_q g_q$  let  $s_a$  record, for each  $q$ , the number  $a - \ell$ , where  $\ell < a$  is the index of the last block before  $a$  containing a power of  $q$ . The next such block has index  $\ell + g_q$  or  $\ell + g_q + 1$ , and it is at least  $a$ . Hence  $s_a$  is a state, block  $a$  contains a power of  $q$  when  $(s_a)_q = g_q + 1$  and does not when  $(s_a)_q < g_q$ , and  $(\tau_a, s_{a+1})$  is a transition from  $s_a$ . Since  $Y_a = G_{\tau_a} \circ \dots \circ G_{\tau_{a+n-1}}(Y_{a+n})$  with  $Y_{a+n} \in [0, 1/(p-1)]$ , the tail  $Y_a$  is the value of the actual path  $(\tau_a, s_{a+1}), (\tau_{a+1}, s_{a+2}), \dots$  from  $s_a$ .

*Remark 5.7* (a decoding criterion). Let  $P$  be a finite set of at least two primes, and for every state  $s$  let  $J(s)$  be a closed interval containing the values of all infinite paths from  $s$ . For  $k \geq 1$  and each type  $\tau$ , let  $U_\tau$  be the union of the intervals  $G_{u_1} \circ \dots \circ G_{u_k}(J(s_k))$  over all states  $s$  and all paths  $(u_1, s_1), \dots, (u_k, s_k)$  from  $s$  with  $u_1 = \tau$ . If the sets  $U_\tau$  are pairwise disjoint, then  $\mathcal{D}_P$  is irrational.

*Proof.* Let  $a > \max_q g_q$ . The first  $k$  transitions of the actual path from  $s_a$  form a path of length  $k$  with first type  $\tau_a$ , and  $Y_a = G_{\tau_a} \circ \dots \circ G_{\tau_{a+k-1}}(Y_{a+k})$ , where  $Y_{a+k} \in J(s_{a+k})$  because it is the value of an infinite path from  $s_{a+k}$ . Thus  $Y_a \in U_{\tau_a}$ , and by disjointness  $\tau_a$  is the only type with this property. So  $Y_a$  determines  $\tau_a$ , then  $Y_{a+1} = b_{\tau_a} Y_a - \mu_{\tau_a}$ , and by induction the word  $\tau_a \tau_{a+1} \dots$ .

Suppose  $\mathcal{D}_P = N/K$ . By Remark 5.6(ii) and (iii), the numbers  $KY_a$  are integers in  $[0, K/(p-1)]$ , so  $Y_a = Y_{a'}$  for some  $\max_q g_q < a < a'$ , and the word  $(\tau_a)$  is eventually periodic. Fix  $q \in Q$  and put  $\beta = \log p / \log q$ , which lies in  $(0, 1)$  and is irrational because no power of  $p$  equals a power of  $q$ . By Remark 5.6(i), block  $a$  contains  $\lfloor (a+1)\beta \rfloor - \lfloor a\beta \rfloor$  powers of  $q$ , a number recorded by  $\tau_a$ . As in the proof of Theorem 1.1, eventual periodicity with period  $\ell$  forces  $\ell\beta \in \mathbb{Z}$ , a contradiction.  $\square$

Intervals  $J(s)$  with the required property are easy to produce. The constant interval  $[0, 1/(p-1)]$  qualifies by Remark 5.6(ii). If a family  $J$  qualifies, so does any family  $J'$  with

$$J'(s) \supseteq G_\tau(J(s')) \quad \text{for every transition } (\tau, s') \text{ from } s,$$

because an infinite path from  $s$  is a transition  $(\tau, s')$  followed by an infinite path from  $s'$ . Starting from the constant family and repeatedly taking the smallest interval containing these images, with endpoints rounded outwards, therefore gives valid intervals after any number of rounds. The tightest choice is  $J(s) = [L(s), U(s)]$ , where  $L(s)$  and  $U(s)$  are the least and greatest values of the infinite paths from  $s$ . They satisfy  $L(s) = \min G_\tau(L(s'))$  and  $U(s) = \max G_\tau(U(s'))$  over the transitions from  $s$ , and these equations have unique solutions because each  $G_\tau$  contracts by at least the factor  $1/p$ .

For  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  the constant interval  $I = [3/10, 13/15]$  has the required property: every path takes a transition with  $5 \in T$  within any three steps, which is the only fact the bounds used. With  $k = 1$  the criterion is then the proof given above.

## 5.4 Certificates for three and four primes

The saved computations apply the interval criterion in exact rational arithmetic to the following finite family. They accompany the ordinary proof of Remark 5.7 and have not been formalised. The exclusions in part (ii) concern these interval calculations; the ordinary torus argument also treats those sets.

*Remark 5.8* (three and four primes up to 31). Let  $P$  be a set of primes, each at most 31.

- (i) If  $|P| = 3$ , then  $\mathcal{D}_P$  is irrational.
- (ii) If  $|P| = 4$  and  $P$  is not one of the 38 sets listed below, then  $\mathcal{D}_P$  is irrational.

*Proof.* For each set, the program `certificate.py` of the [distinct-height programs](#) builds the automaton, computes intervals  $J(s)$  by 80 rounds of the operation above from  $[0, 1/(p-1)]$ , with endpoints rounded outwards to multiples of  $2^{-96}$ , and tests the disjointness of the sets  $U_\tau$  for  $k = 1, 2, \dots$ . Every comparison is made in exact rational arithmetic, and each  $U_\tau$  is computed as a union of intervals merged where they meet. The test passes for each of the 165 sets of three primes with some  $k \leq 4$ , and for each set of four primes outside the list with some  $k \leq 5$ . Remark 5.7 then gives irrationality.  $\square$

For three primes the least passing depth is  $k = 1$  for 141 sets and  $k = 2$  for the 17 sets  $\{2, 3, 11\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 13\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 17\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 23\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 31\}$ ,  $\{2, 5, 7\}$ ,  $\{2, 11, 17\}$ ,  $\{2, 13, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 17, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 19, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 19, 31\}$ ,  $\{3, 13, 17\}$ ,  $\{3, 17, 23\}$ ,  $\{3, 23, 31\}$  and  $\{3, 29, 31\}$ . It is  $k = 3$  for  $\{2, 3, 7\}$ ,  $\{2, 11, 13\}$ ,  $\{2, 17, 29\}$  and  $\{2, 19, 23\}$ , and  $k = 4$  for  $\{2, 17, 31\}$ ,  $\{2, 23, 29\}$  and  $\{2, 29, 31\}$ . The smallest gap between sets  $U_\tau$  of different types, among all passing triples, is about  $9.4 \cdot 10^{-6}$ , for  $\{2, 17, 31\}$ ; for  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  it is  $27983/963915 \approx 0.029$  at depth 1, much larger than the gap  $1/900$  of the single interval used above. For four primes the least passing depth is 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 for 184, 34, 28, 42 and 4 sets respectively, and the smallest gap is about  $1.8 \cdot 10^{-8}$ , for  $\{3, 7, 17, 19\}$ . All these gaps are far above the rounding scale  $2^{-96}$ . The 38 four-prime sets with no passing depth  $k \leq 5$  are  $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 5, 11\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 5, 13\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 5, 17\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 5, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 5, 23\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 7, 11\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 7, 13\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 7, 17\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 7, 23\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 11, 13\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 11, 17\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 11, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 11, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 11, 31\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 13, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 13, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 17, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 17, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 3, 29, 31\}$ ,  $\{2, 5, 7, 11\}$ ,  $\{2, 5, 17, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 5, 23, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 5, 23, 31\}$ ,  $\{2, 11, 13, 19\}$ ,  $\{2, 11, 17, 23\}$ ,  $\{2, 11, 17, 29\}$ ,  $\{2, 11, 23, 31\}$ ,  $\{2, 13, 19, 31\}$ ,  $\{2, 19, 23, 31\}$ ,  $\{3, 5, 13, 17\}$ ,  $\{3, 5, 17, 19\}$ ,  $\{3, 5, 23, 31\}$ ,  $\{3, 7, 11, 13\}$ ,  $\{3, 19, 23, 29\}$ ,  $\{3, 19, 23, 31\}$ ,  $\{3, 19, 29, 31\}$  and  $\{7, 13, 29, 31\}$ . Twenty of them contain both 2 and 3.

A second computation replaces the rounded intervals by the exact extremes  $[L(s), U(s)]$ , found by policy iteration and checked by substitution into their defining equations. It returns the same least depth for all 495 sets. A third check compares the automaton with the first 400 actual blocks of every set: every actual word is a path, and every exact enclosure of an actual tail lies in the interval of its state. This comparison is a consistency check only. The whole triple computation takes about three seconds, and

the four-prime computation about seventy seconds, on one laptop; the receipts record every depth and gap.

For  $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$  the automaton has 18 states and 16 types, and the test fails through depth 7. Its tail intervals range from about 0.188 to 0.785, so the largest exceeds three times the smallest, and the images of the empty block and of the block with one power of 3 overlap. The largest overlap between two first types is always of this pair. For each depth  $k$  the table gives the number of merged intervals in the sets  $U_\tau$  and the length of that largest overlap.

| $k$ | intervals | largest overlap     |
|-----|-----------|---------------------|
| 1   | 16        | $2.4 \cdot 10^{-2}$ |
| 2   | 58        | $1.8 \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| 3   | 386       | $1.0 \cdot 10^{-4}$ |
| 4   | 1413      | $4.6 \cdot 10^{-5}$ |
| 5   | 8395      | $7.6 \cdot 10^{-7}$ |
| 6   | 38494     | $2.4 \cdot 10^{-7}$ |
| 7   | 193905    | $1.8 \cdot 10^{-8}$ |

At depth 7 two further pairs of types still overlap,  $(5, 7, 3)$  with  $(7)$  by about  $1.5 \cdot 10^{-9}$  and  $(3, 5, 7)$  with  $(3, 7)$  by about  $5.8 \cdot 10^{-10}$ .

The second pair explains why no depth succeeds. The two-block words  $(5, 7, 3), \emptyset$  and  $(7), (3, 5)$  have the same map,

$$G_{(5,7,3)} \circ G_\emptyset(y) = G_{(7)} \circ G_{(3,5)}(y) = \frac{103 + y}{420},$$

which is the collision  $f(5, 7, 3, 2) = f(7, 2, 3, 5) = 51$  of Section 5.1 read in blocks: the letters are 5, 7, 3, 2, 2 and 7, 2, 3, 5, 2, and  $f = 103$  for both. From the states  $(1, 2, 2)$  and  $(1, 2, 3)$ , written as  $(s_3, s_5, s_7)$ , both words continue by the blocks  $(3), (5, 7)$  and end in the state  $(2, 1, 1)$ , so the four-block words have the same map and the same end state. Hence the sets  $U_{(5,7,3)}$  and  $U_{(7)}$  of Remark 5.7 meet at every depth, for any valid choice of intervals, and the criterion cannot decide  $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$  with this automaton. Both four-block words occur in the actual block sequence, 12 and 40 times among the first 20000 blocks. Within this automaton, a tail value therefore need not determine its first block. The identity does not exhibit equal tails at two positions of the actual prime-power sequence: those tails have different later phases. It proves failure of this interval decoder. The proof of Remark 5.1 uses the isolated reversal of two actual jumps instead.

## 5.5 Repeated tails and prime-power subseries

We compare the two normalisations before considering the sums over pure prime powers. The subseries assertions in this subsection have ordinary proofs and remain unformalised. For  $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$  the two tail recurrences have the same bases,  $b_{\tau_a} = P_{a+1}/P_a = b_a$ , but their coefficients behave differently:

$$Y_{a+1} = b_a Y_a - \mu_{\tau_a}, \quad X_{a+1} = b_a X_a - m_a.$$

The first identity is Remark 5.6(ii); the second is Theorem 8.2, with the notation of Section 8. The five types give only the coefficients 1, 3, 9, 13, whereas the weighted shell counts satisfy  $m_a = \Theta((a+1)^2)$  by Lemma 8.3. Consequently  $X_a > m_a/30$  is unbounded. Under rationality the integral states  $BX_a$  need not repeat, and the maps  $y \mapsto (m_a + y)/b_a$  form an infinite family depending on  $a$ . Even equality of two states would not identify their later coefficients. The residue criterion in Section 10 compares an endpoint residue with a quadratic bound instead. The example after Proposition 13.2 shows the limit of an argument using just bases and growth: the same bases admit quadratic numerators  $\widehat{m}_a$  with  $\sum_a \widehat{m}_a/P_{a+1} = 9$ .

The two-tail proof of Remark 5.1 stops at the same place. Over the prime powers the repeated sum is  $\mathcal{R}_P = \sum_{k \geq 0} c_k/Q_k$ , where  $c_k$  counts the smooth integers in  $[t_k, t_{k+1})$ , with  $t_0 = 1$ . The two tails after  $t_k$  and after  $t_k p^n$  still have words that differ by rearranging chains, and a rational value still makes the scaled tails integers of one denominator. But the scaled tails are unbounded, as the  $X_a$  are, and Remark 5.3 needs every tail in  $(0, 1)$ : the integer  $f(\sigma_i) - f(\sigma'_i)$  is shown to vanish because it equals a difference of two tails. With unbounded tails that step fails, the digits  $c_k$  move with the rearrangement as well, and equality of two tails no longer forces agreement on each rearranged run. The irrationality of  $\mathcal{R}_P$  for  $|P| \geq 3$  remains open.

**Prime-power subseries.** The comparison of two tails applies to each prime-power subseries. For  $p \in P$  put

$$E_p = \sum_{\alpha \geq 0} \frac{1}{L(p^\alpha)} = \sum_{\alpha \geq 0} \frac{1}{H_P(p^\alpha)},$$

the sub-sum of  $\mathcal{R}_P$  over the terms at which the smooth integer is a power of  $p$ . For  $P = \{p, q\}$  with  $p < q$  these are the numbers  $A = E_p$  and  $1 + B_* = E_q$  of the proof of Theorem 1.2.

*Remark 5.9* (sub-sums and the catalogue sum). Let  $P$  be a finite set of primes with  $|P| \geq 2$ .

- (i)  $\mathcal{D}_P = \sum_{q \in P} E_q - (|P| - 1)$ .
- (ii) If  $P = \{p, q\}$ , then  $H_P(p^i q^j) = H_P(p^i) H_P(q^j)$  for all  $i, j \geq 0$ , and  $\mathcal{R}_P = E_p E_q$ .
- (iii) If  $P = \{p, q, r\}$ , then  $H_P(p^i q^j r^k) = H_P(p^i) H_P(q^j) H_P(r^k) p^{\kappa_p(j,k)} q^{\kappa_q(i,k)} r^{\kappa_r(i,j)}$ , where  $\kappa_p(j, k) = \lfloor j \log_p q + k \log_p r \rfloor - \lfloor j \log_p q \rfloor - \lfloor k \log_p r \rfloor \in \{0, 1\}$  and  $\kappa_q, \kappa_r$  are defined in the same way. For a general finite  $P$  the corresponding exponents lie in  $\{0, \dots, |P| - 2\}$ .

*Proof.* (i) Each term  $1/Q_k$  of  $\mathcal{D}_P$  with  $k \geq 1$  is a term of  $E_{q_k}$  and of no other  $E_q$ , and each  $E_q$  also contains the term 1. (ii) and (iii) The exponent of  $p$  in  $H_P(\prod_{q \in P} q^{e_q})$  is  $e_p + \lfloor \sum_{q \neq p} e_q \log_p q \rfloor$ , and its exponent in  $\prod_{q \in P} H_P(q^{e_q})$  is  $e_p + \sum_{q \neq p} \lfloor e_q \log_p q \rfloor$ . For  $m$  nonnegative reals the floor of the sum exceeds the sum of the floors by an integer in  $\{0, \dots, m - 1\}$ . With two primes  $m = 1$ , so the heights factor, and summing  $H_P(p^i)^{-1} H_P(q^j)^{-1}$  over  $i, j \geq 0$  gives  $E_p E_q$ .  $\square$

With three primes  $\mathcal{R}_P$  is therefore the product of the three single-prime sums twisted by the carries  $\kappa$ , and the plain product  $E_p E_q E_r$  differs from it.

*Remark 5.10* (the single-prime sub-sums). Let  $P$  be a finite set of primes with  $|P| \geq 2$  and let  $p \in P$ . Then  $E_p$  is irrational.

For  $P = \{p, q\}$ ,  $E_p$  is  $A$  or  $1 + B_*$  in the proof of Theorem 1.2, an affine function of the Hecke–Mahler value  $F_\theta(1/p, 1/q)$  with nonzero slope; for  $p < q$ ,  $E_p = p/(p-1) - (q-1)F_\theta(1/p, 1/q)$  by (6). It is transcendental by the theorem of Bugeaud and Laurent [15, Theorem 1.1], in the case due to Loxton and van der Poorten [16, Theorem 8, p. 40]. We cite these sources for this case and have not re-verified its earlier attribution history.

*Proof.* We modify the word argument so that it counts only occurrences of  $p$ . For an infinite word  $u$  and a finite word  $\sigma = \sigma_1 \cdots \sigma_n$ , put

$$V_p(u) = \sum_{i: u_i=p} \frac{1}{u_1 \cdots u_i}, \quad f_p(\sigma) = \sum_{j: \sigma_j=p} \sigma_{j+1} \cdots \sigma_n.$$

Then  $V_p(\sigma u) = (f_p(\sigma) + V_p(u))/\Pi(\sigma)$ . Writing  $y_k = V_p(q_{k+1}q_{k+2} \cdots)$ , we have

$$E_p = 1 + \sum_{k: q_k=p} \frac{1}{Q_k}, \quad Q_k E_p = Q_k + \sum_{j \leq k, q_j=p} \frac{Q_k}{Q_j} + y_k.$$

In an actual suffix, the prefix product at the  $j$ th occurrence of  $p$  is at least  $p^j$ , with strict inequality after another prime has occurred. Hence  $0 < V_p(u) < 1/(p-1) \leq 1$ , and rationality  $E_p = N/K$  would imply  $Ky_k \in \mathbb{Z}$ . The proof of Remark 5.3 therefore applies to  $V_p, f_p$  as well. On a chain of distinct primes containing  $p$ , the integer  $f_p$  is the product of the primes following  $p$ . By unique factorisation, it detects a change in that set of followers.

For each  $q \neq p$ , the form  $\theta_p - \theta_q$  is nonzero on the rational subspace  $L$  used in Section 5.1. We may therefore choose  $v \in L$  with  $|v_q| \leq 1$  for every  $q$  and  $v_q \neq v_p$  for  $q \neq p$ , where  $v_q = \theta_q(v)$ , and put  $\mu = \min_{q \neq p} |v_p - v_q| > 0$ . Suppose  $E_p = N/K$ . Choose a jump  $t_k$  labelled  $p$ , and choose  $T, \nu, g, \beta$  as in the general irrationality proof, with  $2^\nu \geq K$ . Set  $\eta = 1/10$  and first fix

$$0 < \varepsilon < \min\{\beta, g/2, \log 2/(2|P|), \eta/4, \eta\mu/4\}.$$

Dirichlet's theorem then supplies arbitrarily large  $n$  and integers  $m_q \geq 1$  such that  $\delta_p = 0$  and  $0 < |\delta_q| = |n \log p - m_q \log q| < \varepsilon$  for  $q \neq p$ . We compare  $t_k$  with  $t_m = t_k p^n$  and cut crossings at gaps greater than  $2\varepsilon$ . As before, each chain consists of distinct primes and is merely rearranged by the phase shift. The common prefix of  $\nu$  letters and the integral-tail argument give  $y_k = y_m$ , and hence  $f_p(C) = f_p(C')$  for every chain and its rearrangement.

We shall contradict this equality near the origin of  $T_0$ . Put

$$b_0 = \min_{q \neq p} \frac{|\delta_q|}{|v_p - v_q|}, \quad B = \{q \neq p : \delta_q < 0\},$$

$$A_+ = \{q \neq p : v_q < v_p\}, \quad A_- = \{q \neq p : v_q > v_p\}.$$

Since  $0 < b_0 \leq \varepsilon/\mu < \eta/4$  and  $A_+, A_-$  partition the nonempty set  $P \setminus \{p\}$ , one of these two sets, say  $A_s$  with  $s \in \{+1, -1\}$ , differs from  $B$ . Take  $b = sb_0/2$  and consider  $z = bv + \Theta(-\eta/2)$ . For each  $q$ , its crossing nearest  $\eta/2$  occurs at

$$\tau_q = \eta/2 - bv_q \in (3\eta/8, 5\eta/8), \quad \tau_q - \tau_p = b(v_p - v_q).$$

Every other  $q$ -crossing lies outside  $(-\eta/4, 5\eta/4)$ , and for  $q \neq p$  the displayed difference is nonzero with absolute value at most  $|\delta_q|/2$ . We choose a neighbourhood  $U$  of  $z$  in  $T_0$  on which there are no crossings in  $[-\eta/4, \eta/4] \cup [3\eta/4, 5\eta/4]$ , each prime has a crossing in  $(\eta/4, 3\eta/4)$ , and every difference  $\tau_q - \tau_p$  retains its sign and has absolute value less than  $|\delta_q|$ . These conditions are open and hold strictly at  $z$ .

By density,  $\theta_k + \Theta(t^*) \in U$  for some  $t^* > T + 2$ . The resulting crossings near  $t^*$  form one chain: each is within  $\varepsilon$  of the  $p$ -crossing and every other crossing is more than  $\eta/2 > 2\varepsilon$  away. In this chain the followers of  $p$  form  $A_s$ . After the shift,  $q$  follows  $p$  precisely when  $\tau_q - \tau_p > \delta_q$ , which, by the bound  $|\tau_q - \tau_p| < |\delta_q|$ , is equivalent to  $\delta_q < 0$ . Its followers now form  $B \neq A_s$ , contradicting  $f_p(C) = f_p(C')$ .  $\square$

This argument uses a change of followers and so needs no two-wall lemma. Either of  $A_+, A_-$  may be empty, but they are distinct when  $|P| \geq 2$ . For  $P = \{p\}$  the sum is  $p/(p-1)$ , and this is precisely where the choice of two distinct follower sets fails. The strict conditions defining  $U$  are needed to carry the construction to an actual orbit.

For  $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$ ,  $p = 2$ ,  $t_k = 2^{20}$  and  $n = 65$ , the first rearranged chain is  $(2, 3)$  against  $(3, 2)$  after 131 letters, with  $f_2$  equal to 3 and 1, and the difference of the two tails, computed exactly to 300 letters, has  $\log_{10} |y_k - y_m| = -58.098$ .

For the repeated sum  $\mathcal{R}_p$ , changing the scale from  $t_k$  to  $t_k p^n$  brings in early terms from the rays  $p^\alpha w$ , with  $w$  supported on  $P \setminus \{p\}$ . The comparison above accounts only for the ray  $w = 1$ , so it gives no corresponding estimate for the difference of the full repeated tails. In the case  $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$  those normalised tails are unbounded, as the lower bounds below show.

## 6 Integer-radix words ordered by independent clocks

We next apply the interchange argument to words formed by several clocks. The results of this section are ordinary arguments awaiting formalisation. The clock rates are parameters subject to an explicit rational-independence hypothesis, which we do not assume for reciprocal prime logarithms. Under that hypothesis, interchanging two late crossings determines the rational relations among the component sums without recovering every letter of an admissible word.

Let  $A$  be a finite alphabet. Give  $a \in A$  an integer radix  $b_a \geq 2$  and a rational digit  $c_a$ . For  $w = w_1 w_2 \dots$ , define

$$Q_0 = 1, \quad Q_n = \prod_{j=1}^n b_{w_j}, \quad V_c(w) = \sum_{n \geq 1} \frac{c_{w_n}}{Q_n}, \quad T_a(x) = \frac{c_a + x}{b_a}.$$

Write  $\sigma w = w_2 w_3 \dots$  and  $X_w = \{\sigma^n w : n \geq 0\}$  in the one-sided product topology. The first letter acts by the outermost map: if  $u = u_1 \dots u_m$ , then  $V_c(uz) = T_{u_1} \circ \dots \circ T_{u_m}(V_c(z))$ . Put  $B(u) = \prod_{j \leq m} b_{u_j}$ , with  $B(\emptyset) = 1$ .

*Remark 6.1* (the suffix lattice and a late interchange). Suppose  $V_c(w)$  is rational. If for distinct letters  $a, b$  and arbitrarily long words  $u$  there is a common infinite suffix  $z$  such that both  $uabz$  and  $ubaz$  belong to  $X_w$ , then

$$c_a(b_b - 1) = c_b(b_a - 1).$$

If such interchanges join every pair of letters along a connected graph,  $V_c(w)$  is rational precisely when there is  $\lambda \in \mathbb{Q}$  with  $c_a = \lambda(b_a - 1)$  for all  $a$ ; in that case  $V_c(w) = \lambda$ .

*Proof.* First clear the common denominator of the digits, so that all  $c_a$  are integers. The recurrence  $V_c(\sigma w) = b_{w_1} V_c(w) - c_{w_1}$  shows that, if  $V_c(w) = p/K$ , then every shifted value belongs to  $K^{-1}\mathbb{Z}$ . For  $\lambda_a = c_a/(b_a - 1)$ , the positive weights

$$\frac{b_{w_n} - 1}{Q_n} = \frac{1}{Q_{n-1}} - \frac{1}{Q_n}$$

sum to one. Hence  $V_c(v)$  lies between  $\min_a \lambda_a$  and  $\max_a \lambda_a$  for every word  $v$ . Sharing  $m$  initial letters changes a value by at most the width of this interval divided by  $B(u)$ . Thus  $V_c$  is continuous, and  $V_c(X_w) \subseteq K^{-1}\mathbb{Z}$ .

The order of the maps matters. A direct calculation gives, for every  $x$ ,

$$T_a(T_b(x)) - T_b(T_a(x)) = \frac{c_a(b_b - 1) - c_b(b_a - 1)}{b_a b_b}.$$

The values of  $uabz$  and  $ubaz$  therefore differ by this number divided by  $B(u)$ . Their difference belongs to  $K^{-1}\mathbb{Z}$ . If its numerator were nonzero, its absolute value would be positive but smaller than  $1/K$  for a sufficiently long  $u$ , a contradiction. On a connected interchange graph all  $\lambda_a$  agree. Conversely, for  $c_a = \lambda(b_a - 1)$  the displayed positive weights telescope and give  $V_c(v) = \lambda$  for every  $v$ . Dividing by the earlier common digit denominator restores the rational-digit statement.  $\square$

The common suffix is essential: distinct words can have the same affine map. For example, the blocks  $(5, 7, 3, 2)$  and  $(7, 2, 3, 5)$  have the same map  $(51 + x)/210$ . Choosing the second block at block indices  $1, 2, 4, 8, \dots$  produces a non-eventually-periodic word with rational value  $51/209$ . Aperiodicity, compact tails and an integer alphabet alone therefore cannot replace the interchange hypothesis. Nor does the lemma assert sufficiency when its graph is disconnected.

Now let  $r_1, \dots, r_d > 0$ ,  $d \geq 2$ , be linearly independent over  $\mathbb{Q}$ . Clock  $i$  crosses at positive times  $t$  for which  $r_i t + \theta_i \in \mathbb{Z}$ , where  $\theta_i \in [0, 1)$ , and assume no two clocks cross simultaneously at positive time. Ordering the crossings gives an infinite word  $w$  on  $\{1, \dots, d\}$ .

*Remark 6.2* (isolated interchanges in a clock word). Every pair of distinct clock labels satisfies the late-interchange hypothesis of Remark 6.1 for  $X_w$ .

*Proof.* Fix a label  $a$ . Immediately after its sufficiently late crossings, the phases of the other clocks are

$$\theta_i - \frac{r_i}{r_a} \theta_a + k \frac{r_i}{r_a} \pmod{1} \quad (i \neq a),$$

where  $k$  runs through all sufficiently large integers. These points are dense in the  $(d-1)$ -torus. Indeed, 1 and the  $r_i/r_a$  for  $i \neq a$  are rationally independent. For every nonzero integral character of the torus, its average along this orbit is a geometric sum divided by its length and tends to zero. Trigonometric approximation of continuous functions then shows that every nonempty open set is visited infinitely often. This also proves density after any finite initial segment is discarded.

Fix  $b \neq a$  and an arbitrarily large integer  $L$ , and work on the section just after an  $a$ -crossing. Set  $T = L/r_a$  and choose the phase of  $b$  so that its clock crosses at  $T$ . This phase is nonzero, since  $Lr_b/r_a \notin \mathbb{Z}$ . Choose the remaining phases outside the countable sets that cause a crossing at zero, a third crossing at  $T$ , or any other positive simultaneous crossing. The resulting singular configuration has exactly the one double crossing of  $a, b$  at  $T$ : a second meeting of these two clocks would make  $r_b/r_a$  rational.

Perturb the  $b$  phase on opposite sides. On any bounded time interval containing finitely many crossings, a sufficiently small perturbation preserves every order except that of this pair. Taking one-sided limits of the whole event words gives  $uabz$  and  $ubaz$  with the *same* infinite suffix  $z$ . Their common prefix has at least  $L-1$  letters, from the earlier  $a$ -crossings. For each finite prefix of either limit, a small open set of nonsingular section phases realises that prefix. The dense actual  $a$ -section orbit meets that set, so the prefix occurs at the beginning of an actual shifted word. Consequently both limiting words belong to  $X_w$ . Letting  $L$  grow proves the assertion.  $\square$

*Remark 6.3* (rational relations among independent-clock channels). Under the preceding clock hypotheses, choose integers  $b_i \geq 2$ , put  $Q_n = \prod_{k \leq n} b_{w_k}$  and

$$S_i = \sum_{n: w_n=i} \frac{1}{Q_n} \quad (1 \leq i \leq d).$$

For every  $c_i \in \mathbb{Q}$ ,

$$\sum_{i=1}^d c_i S_i \in \mathbb{Q} \iff c_i = \lambda(b_i - 1) \text{ for all } i \text{ and some } \lambda \in \mathbb{Q}.$$

The rational value is  $\lambda$ . Equivalently, all rational relations  $a_0 + \sum_i a_i S_i = 0$  are multiples of  $(-1, b_1 - 1, \dots, b_d - 1)$ . Thus the span of  $1, S_1, \dots, S_d$  has dimension  $d$ ; each channel and each nonempty proper unweighted sub-sum is irrational. The full unweighted sum is irrational exactly when the radices are not all equal.

The following argument proves the assertion of the remark in ordinary mathematics; formalisation and external peer review remain outstanding.

*Proof.* Absolute convergence gives  $\sum_i c_i S_i = V_c(w)$ . The previous two remarks make the interchange graph complete, so they give both directions and the stated value. The relation space follows by moving the rational value to the constant coordinate. An indicator vector of a nonempty proper set has both zero and one entries and cannot be a multiple of the strictly positive vector  $(b_i - 1)_i$ . The all-ones vector is such a multiple precisely when all the  $b_i$  agree.  $\square$

For a concrete four-clock instance take

$$(r_1, r_2, r_3, r_4) = (1, \sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3}, \sqrt{6}), \quad (b_1, b_2, b_3, b_4) = (2, 3, 5, 7), \quad \theta_i = 0.$$

The four rates form the standard basis of the biquadratic field  $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{2}, \sqrt{3})$  over  $\mathbb{Q}$ ; the ratio of any two distinct rates is irrational, so positive crossings never coincide. Write  $(d_1, d_2, d_3, d_4) = (1, 2, 3, 6)$ . Counting crossings up to the  $n$ th crossing of clock  $i$  gives the explicit series

$$S_i = \sum_{n \geq 1} \left( \prod_{j=1}^4 b_j^{\lfloor n \sqrt{d_j/d_i} \rfloor} \right)^{-1}. \quad (9)$$

The only rational relation among  $1, S_1, S_2, S_3, S_4$  is generated by  $S_1 + 2S_2 + 4S_3 + 6S_4 = 1$ . In particular their rational span has dimension four and  $\sum_i S_i$  is irrational. This does not provide an irrationality measure or transcendence result. In the related two-letter Hecke–Mahler setting, stronger transcendence results exist [15]; the example’s four independent rates do not satisfy that two-letter hypothesis. The ordinary two-wall argument for the distinct running-LCM sum avoids this assumption on reciprocal prime logarithms. The repeated running-LCM question remains open.

## 7 Separation of the three-prime kernel

We ask whether the factorisation of the two-prime kernel extends to a finite sum of products for three primes. A diagonal rescaling turns this question into one about threshold columns. We select their jumps using two independent one-dimensional density arguments, then evaluate a staircase determinant. The initial two-generator identity is valid for real generators; distinct primes enter the later density argument.

**Proposition 7.1** (two generators separate). *For real  $p, q > 1$ , with  $L_{p,q}(t) = p^{\lfloor \log_p t \rfloor} q^{\lfloor \log_q t \rfloor}$  as above, and all integers  $i, j \geq 0$ , the two-prime kernel  $K_2(i, j) = 1/L_{p,q}(p^i q^j)$  is the outer product*

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$$K_2(i, j) = (p^i q^{\lfloor \log_q p^i \rfloor})^{-1} (p^{\lfloor \log_p q^j \rfloor} q^j)^{-1},$$

so every two-by-two minor of  $K_2$  vanishes.

*Proof.* Since  $i$  and  $j$  are integers,  $\lfloor \log_p(p^i q^j) \rfloor = i + \lfloor \log_p q^j \rfloor$  and  $\lfloor \log_q(p^i q^j) \rfloor = j + \lfloor \log_q p^i \rfloor$ . Hence  $L_{p,q}(p^i q^j)$  is the product of  $p^i q^{\lfloor \log_q p^i \rfloor}$ , which depends on  $i$  alone, and  $p^{\lfloor \log_p q^j \rfloor} q^j$ , which depends on  $j$  alone. A matrix whose entries are a product of a row function and a column function has vanishing two-by-two minors. For distinct primes  $p, q$  the product  $L_{p,q}$  is the running least common multiple by the argument of Theorem 3.1.  $\square$

At three generators the smallest rectangle already fails to factor. A factorisation  $f(i)g(j)h(k)$  would force  $K(0, 0, 0) K(1, 1, 0) = K(1, 0, 0) K(0, 1, 0)$ .

**Proposition 7.2** (non-separability at  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ ). *With  $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$ ,*

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$$\det \begin{pmatrix} K(0, 0, 0) & K(0, 1, 0) \\ K(1, 0, 0) & K(1, 1, 0) \end{pmatrix} = \det \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1/6 \\ 1/2 & 1/60 \end{pmatrix} = -\frac{1}{15} \neq 0.$$

*Proof.* The four values are computed from  $H(1) = 1$ ,  $H(2) = 2$ ,  $H(3) = 2 \cdot 3 = 6$  and  $H(6) = 4 \cdot 3 \cdot 5 = 60$ , so the determinant is  $1/60 - 1/12 = -1/15$ .  $\square$

**Theorem 7.3** (no finite separation of the kernel). *Let  $p, q, r$  be primes with  $p \neq q$ ,  $p \neq r$  and  $q \neq r$ . For every  $n \geq 1$  there are injective maps  $I, J : \{0, \dots, n-1\} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$  such that, for every  $k \geq 0$ ,*

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$$\det(K(I(a), J(b), k))_{0 \leq a, b < n} \neq 0.$$

Consequently, for no finite  $d$  do there exist rational-valued functions  $f_\ell : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}$  and  $G_\ell : \mathbb{N}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}$ ,  $0 \leq \ell < d$ , satisfying  $K(i, j, k) = \sum_{\ell < d} f_\ell(i) G_\ell(j, k)$  for all  $i, j, k$ .

*Proof.* Put  $\alpha = \log_r p$ ,  $\beta = \log_r q$ ,  $x_i = \{i\alpha\}$  and  $y_j = \{j\beta\}$ . Write  $v_p(N)$  for the exponent of the prime  $p$  in the positive integer  $N$ . The three height exponents are

$$\begin{aligned} v_p(H(p^i q^j r^k)) &= i + \lfloor j \log_p q + k \log_p r \rfloor, \\ v_q(H(p^i q^j r^k)) &= j + \lfloor i \log_q p + k \log_q r \rfloor, \\ v_r(H(p^i q^j r^k)) &= k + \lfloor i\alpha \rfloor + \lfloor j\beta \rfloor + \lfloor x_i + y_j \rfloor. \end{aligned}$$

Every term except the last floor depends on  $i$  and  $k$  alone or on  $j$  and  $k$  alone, so with positive rational  $R_i(k)$  and  $C_j(k)$ ,

$$K(i, j, k) = R_i(k) C_j(k) t^{\lfloor x_i + y_j \rfloor}, \quad t = r^{-1}. \quad (10)$$

The remaining matrix is independent of  $k$ , and  $x_i + y_j \in [0, 2)$ , so its entries are 1 and  $t$ .

Each of  $\alpha$  and  $\beta$  is irrational, since a rational value would give an equality of positive powers of distinct primes, so each fractional-part orbit is dense in  $[0, 1]$  and each is injective. The row and column indices are chosen independently, so no density theorem for a single orbit of pairs is required. First choose indices with  $0 < x_{I(0)} < \dots < x_{I(n-1)} < 1$ . We want the columns to cross their thresholds at successive selected rows, so that consecutive row differences will leave a triangular matrix. Write  $s_b = 1 - y_{J(b)}$ , and use density of the second orbit to choose

$$s_0 \in (0, x_{I(0)}), \quad s_b \in (x_{I(b-1)}, x_{I(b)}) \quad (1 \leq b < n).$$

The intervals are disjoint, so the  $J(b)$  are distinct. Their strict endpoints ensure that no selected entry lies on a threshold, and  $x_{I(a)} + y_{J(b)} \geq 1$  holds exactly when  $b \leq a$ . Dividing row  $a$  by  $R_{I(a)}(k)$  and column  $b$  by  $C_{J(b)}(k)$  therefore leaves

$$C_n(t) = \begin{pmatrix} t & 1 & 1 & \dots & 1 \\ t & t & 1 & \dots & 1 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & \vdots \\ t & t & \dots & t & 1 \\ t & t & \dots & t & t \end{pmatrix}, \quad \det C_n(t) = t(t-1)^{n-1} \neq 0,$$

the determinant following by subtracting from each row its predecessor, working upwards from the last. Before the division, the determinant equals

$$\det C_n(t) \prod_{a < n} R_{I(a)}(k) \prod_{b < n} C_{J(b)}(k),$$

which is nonzero for every  $k$ ; this also explains why the same indices work in every layer.

For the last assertion, suppose that a representation with  $d$  summands exists and fix  $k$ . On the selected rows  $I(0), \dots, I(d)$  and columns  $J(0), \dots, J(d)$  the resulting matrix factors as

$$(f_\ell(I(a)))_{0 \leq a \leq d, \ell < d} (G_\ell(J(b), k))_{\ell < d, 0 \leq b \leq d}.$$

It has rank at most  $d$  and hence zero determinant, contradicting the nonzero minor of order  $d + 1$ .  $\square$

Index selection is essential. In the  $k = 0$  layer of the  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  kernel, the leading  $4 \times 4$  minor is singular because  $K(3, j, 0) = K(0, j, 0)/120$  for  $0 \leq j \leq 3$ . This is not a proportionality of the full rows: at the next column,

$$K(3, 4, 0) - \frac{K(0, 4, 0)}{120} = -\frac{1}{19440000}.$$

A singular leading minor therefore does not settle the rank.

In each fixed layer  $k$ , the same threshold description determines every finite sampled rank, rather than only producing one nonsingular minor.

**Proposition 7.4** (rank of threshold columns). *Let  $m \geq 1$  and let  $c$  lie in a field with  $c \neq 0, 1$ . For  $0 \leq h \leq m$ , let  $v_h$  be the length- $m$  column whose first  $h$  entries are 1 and whose remaining entries are  $c$ . If the distinct columns of a matrix are the  $v_h$  with  $h$  in a nonempty set  $E \subseteq \{0, \dots, m\}$ , then its rank is*

$$|E| - \mathbf{1}_{\{0, m\} \subseteq E}.$$

*Proof.* Write  $E = \{h_1 < \dots < h_s\}$ . The  $s - 1$  consecutive differences are

$$v_{h_{a+1}} - v_{h_a} = (1 - c)\mathbf{1}_{\{h_a, \dots, h_{a+1}-1\}},$$

so they are linearly independent because their nonempty supports are disjoint. If  $h_1 > 0$  or  $h_s < m$ , those supports miss a coordinate on which  $v_{h_1}$  is nonzero, and adjoining  $v_{h_1}$  gives rank  $s$ . If  $h_1 = 0$  and  $h_s = m$ , the differences sum to  $(1 - c)\mathbf{1}$  while  $v_0 = c\mathbf{1}$ , so  $v_0$  is already in their span and the rank is  $s - 1$ .  $\square$

The restrictions  $c \neq 0, 1$  exclude the zero column at  $c = 0$  and the collapse of all columns at  $c = 1$ . They hold automatically at  $c = 1/r$  over  $\mathbb{Q}$ . To apply the proposition, fix  $k$  and sort the chosen row phases  $x_i$ . Each normalised column is a threshold column  $v_h$ , where  $h$  is the number of sampled phases strictly below  $1 - y_j$ . Repeated threshold positions give proportional columns before column normalisation. The row and column factors in (10) are nonzero, so the formula gives the exact rank of every nonempty rectangular sample within this layer, independently of  $k$ . Repeated rows or columns do not change rank.

This also gives an exact algorithm. Order the sampled rows by the rational numbers  $p^i / r^{\lfloor \log_r p^i \rfloor}$ . For column  $j$ , count those strictly below  $r^{\lfloor \log_r q^j \rfloor + 1} / q^j$ , then apply the end-point correction to the set of resulting counts. Indeed, raising  $x_i < 1 - y_j$  to base  $r$  gives exactly this rational comparison, and  $x_i + y_j = 1$  belongs to the  $c$  side of the threshold. The integer logarithms are found by comparing powers, so the whole calculation uses integer arithmetic rather than numerical logarithms.

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The fixed-layer restriction is essential. With  $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$ , rows  $i = 0, 1$  and columns indexed by  $(j, k) = (0, 0), (0, 1)$  give

$$\begin{pmatrix} K(0, 0, 0) & K(0, 0, 1) \\ K(1, 0, 0) & K(1, 0, 1) \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1/60 \\ 1/2 & 1/360 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \det = -\frac{1}{180}.$$

Both columns have the same phase  $y_0 = 0$ , yet their rank is 2, not 1. When  $k$  varies with the column, the row factor also varies with that column and cannot be removed by one common diagonal rescaling. The threshold formula is not a rank formula for such mixed-layer samples.

**Scope of the rank theorem.** Fan's comment of 26 June 2026 [17] notes that the two-prime argument does not seem to generalise immediately to  $|P| \geq 3$ . The theorem above gives a precise obstruction: no finite exact separation of the stated form exists. The same finite-dimensional proof works for real or complex factors, without continuity or boundedness assumptions. This does not exclude approximation or imply irrationality or transcendence of the sum. The threshold construction needs  $\log_r p$  and  $\log_r q$  irrational, but not  $p \neq q$ . The latter condition is needed for the three-prime running-LCM interpretation, not for the two independent dense orbits.

### 7.1 Smith factors of the selected staircase

To examine what the selected minors say about integer denominators, we clear their diagonal factors and compute the resulting Smith form. For integers  $N \geq 1, r \geq 2$ , let  $A_N(r)$  have entry 1 on and below the diagonal and  $r$  above it. This is the staircase used in Theorem 7.3. Its Smith factors determine the lattice index. They supply no bound on the height of a small integral linear form, which is a separate requirement in an irrationality argument.

*Remark 7.5* (Smith factors of the selected staircase). The Smith factors of  $A_N(r)$  are  $1, r - 1, \dots, r - 1$ , and  $\det A_N(r) = (1 - r)^{N-1}$ .

The Smith calculation and its height consequence are ordinary arguments here; the existing Lean result proves nonvanishing of the selected minors, not these arithmetic statements.

*Proof.* Working from bottom to top, subtract row  $i - 1$  from row  $i$  for every  $i > 1$ . Row  $i$  then has just  $1 - r$  in column  $i$ . The first row is  $(1, r, \dots, r)$ ; subtract  $r$  times its first column from each later column. The resulting diagonal is  $(1, 1 - r, \dots, 1 - r)$ . These are unimodular integral operations, and 1 divides  $r - 1$ , so this is its Smith form up to signs. Its determinant has the displayed sign.  $\square$

In the source-selected  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  minor, the positive integers  $U_i, V_j$  give

$$K = \text{diag}(U_i)^{-1} A_N(5) \text{diag}(5V_j)^{-1}.$$

Consequently

$$\det K = \frac{(-4)^{N-1}}{W}, \quad W = 5^N \prod_i U_i \prod_j V_j.$$

More generally, an entrywise-integral diagonal clearing  $\text{diag}(s)K\text{diag}(t)$  has diagonal entries  $z_i = s_i t_i / (5U_i V_i) \in \mathbb{Z} \setminus \{0\}$  and determinant  $(-4)^{N-1} \prod_i z_i$ . Its absolute determinant is therefore at least  $4^{N-1}$ , attained by  $s_i = 5U_i, t_j = V_j$ . This optimality is restricted to diagonal entrywise clearings.

For the selected carry pattern, the source's injective nonnegative index families  $I, J$  satisfy  $v_2(W) \geq \sum_i I(i) + \sum_j J(j) \geq N(N-1) \geq 2(N-1)$ . Thus  $4^{N-1}$  divides  $W$ , and the *reduced* determinant is  $\pm 1/D$ , where  $D = W/4^{N-1} \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ . The Smith index explains the numerator before reduction, while the reduced scalar has no numerator left to spend on a one-value denominator clearing. A bordered determinant with one target  $X$  illustrates the same limit: for  $K \in \text{GL}_N(\mathbb{Q})$  and rational  $u, v$ , the Schur complement gives

$$\det \begin{pmatrix} K & u \\ v^T & X \end{pmatrix} = \det K(X - v^T K^{-1} u).$$

If  $v^T K^{-1} u = s/t$  in lowest terms, an integral scalar multiple of  $\det K(X - s/t)$  must have its linear coefficient divisible by  $t$ . Its primitive integral coefficient polynomial is therefore  $\pm(tX - s)$ , regardless of the smallness of  $\det K$  or a compatible rational change of basis. This is a one-target, diagonal-clearing boundary, not a prohibition on new recurrences, multiple target values, or stronger approximation data; it does not settle the repeated running-LCM problem. Smith form is used here in its standard sense [14].

## 7.2 Uniform approximation of the rescaled kernel

For the rescaled kernel, distinct columns stay a fixed positive distance apart. This gives an obstruction to uniform finite-rank approximation. Write

$$C(i, j) = t^{\lfloor x_i + y_j \rfloor}, \quad x_i = \{i \log_r p\}, \quad y_j = \{j \log_r q\}, \quad t = r^{-1}. \quad (11)$$

This is the remaining factor in (10) after removing the row and column factors. A matrix has *finite separated rank* if  $A(i, j) = \sum_{\ell < d} f_\ell(i) g_\ell(j)$  for some finite  $d$ . Equivalently, its columns span a finite-dimensional space of real sequences. No continuity or boundedness of  $f_\ell, g_\ell$  is assumed.

**Theorem 7.6** (distance from matrices of finite separated rank). *Let  $p, q, r$  be pairwise distinct primes and let  $C$  be as in (11). Then*

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$$\inf_A \sup_{i, j \geq 0} |C(i, j) - A(i, j)| = \frac{1-t}{2} = \frac{r-1}{2r},$$

*the infimum being over all matrices  $A$  of finite separated rank, and it is attained by the constant matrix of value  $(1+t)/2$ .*

*Proof.* We first show that any two distinct columns of  $C$  have supremum distance  $1-t$ . Every entry belongs to  $\{1, t\}$ , with  $C(i, j) = t$  precisely when  $x_i + y_j \geq 1$ . Given  $j \neq k$ , irrationality of  $\log_r q$  makes  $y_j \neq y_k$ , so suppose  $y_j < y_k$ . By density of  $(x_i)$  we can choose  $i$  with  $1 - y_k < x_i < 1 - y_j$ ; the two entries in this row are  $t$  and  $1$ .

Suppose a finite-rank matrix  $A$  approximated  $C$  with error  $\varepsilon = \sup_{i, j} |C(i, j) - A(i, j)| < (1-t)/2$ . Its columns  $A_j$  would be bounded sequences with  $\|A_j\|_\infty \leq 1 + \varepsilon$ , and

their span  $V$  would be finite-dimensional. Although no boundedness was assumed for the separated factors, the supremum norm is defined on this span because each column is bounded. For distinct columns the triangle inequality gives

$$\|A_j - A_k\|_\infty \geq \|C_j - C_k\|_\infty - 2\varepsilon = 1 - t - 2\varepsilon > 0.$$

Thus a bounded subset of  $V$  would contain infinitely many points at a fixed positive distance from one another, contrary to total boundedness in finite dimension. This proves the lower bound.

For equality, take the constant matrix  $A(i, j) = (1 + t)/2$ . It has rank one, and its distance from every entry of  $C$  is  $(1 - t)/2$ .  $\square$

The lower bound concerns the entire normalised matrix, not each finite restriction. For example, at  $t = 1/5$  the matrices

$$T = \begin{pmatrix} 1/5 & 1 \\ 1/5 & 1/5 \end{pmatrix}, \quad A = \begin{pmatrix} 3/10 & 9/10 \\ 1/10 & 3/10 \end{pmatrix}$$

satisfy  $\det A = 0$  and  $\|T - A\|_{\max} = 1/10 < 2/5$ . Here  $\|\cdot\|_{\max}$  is the largest absolute entry. This finite example has no bearing on the infinite family of separated columns used in the proof.

For the original kernel, the decaying row and column factors instead allow approximation in the summation norm. Let  $K^{(N)}(i, j, k) = K(i, j, k)$  for  $i < N$  and  $K^{(N)}(i, j, k) = 0$  otherwise. This is a sum of at most  $N$  terms separated between  $i$  and  $(j, k)$ . Since  $H(x) > x^3/(pqr)$  for  $x \geq 1$ , geometric summation gives

$$\sum_{i,j,k \geq 0} |K(i, j, k) - K^{(N)}(i, j, k)| \leq \frac{pqr p^{-3N}}{(1 - p^{-3})(1 - q^{-3})(1 - r^{-3})}. \quad (12)$$

The same bound controls the supremum of the entrywise errors, so these finite separated-rank approximants converge both in  $\ell^1$  and uniformly to the original kernel. The positive uniform lower bound in Theorem 7.6 belongs to the rescaled matrix. Diagonal rescaling preserves exact rank, but the rescaling factors here are unbounded and do not preserve uniform error estimates. Neither the rank obstruction nor these approximation bounds decide whether the scalar sum is rational.

## 8 The recurrence for tails between powers of two

We now return to the repeated sum  $S = \mathcal{R}_{\{2,3,5\}}$  and set  $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$ . Its dyadic blocks are the half-open intervals  $[2^a, 2^{a+1})$ . At their endpoints we put  $P_a = H(2^a)$  and  $h_a = P_a/2$ , so that multiplication by  $h_a$  clears the heights strictly before  $2^a$ . Here  $h_0 = 1/2$ , and  $h_a$  is an integer for  $a \geq 1$ . The powers of 3 and 5 selected at  $2^a$  exceed  $2^a/3$  and  $2^a/5$ , respectively, while the power of 2 is  $2^a$  itself. Thus

$$\frac{8^a}{15} < P_a \leq 8^a \quad (a \geq 0).$$

We group the repeated terms in half-open shells and define

$$s_a = \sum_{\substack{i,j,k \geq 0 \\ 2^a \leq 2^i 3^j 5^k < 2^{a+1}}} \frac{1}{H(2^i 3^j 5^k)}, \quad T_a = \sum_{j \geq a} s_j, \quad X_a = h_a T_a. \quad (13)$$

The strict cutoff explains the factor  $1/2$ . For  $a \geq 1$ , every height  $H(x)$  with  $x < 2^a$  divides  $P_a/2$ : the exponent of 2 is at most  $a - 1$ , and the other exponents are at most their boundary values. We will use this to clear the finite prefix in Lemma 9.2.

The jumps after  $2^a$  and up to  $2^{a+1}$  consist of any powers of 3 or 5 strictly inside that interval, followed by the factor 2 at its right endpoint. There is at most one power of each odd prime: successive powers have ratio greater than two. Let  $I_a$  list the pairs  $(p, e)$  with  $p \in \{3, 5\}$  and  $2^a < p^e < 2^{a+1}$ , ordered by the value  $p^e$ .

**Proposition 8.1** (four possible bases). *For every  $a$ ,*

$$b_a = \frac{P_{a+1}}{P_a} = 2 \prod_{(p,e) \in I_a} p \in \{2, 6, 10, 30\}, \quad \text{so} \quad 2 \leq b_a \leq 30. \quad (14)$$

*Proof.* A power of 3 may occur and a power of 5 may occur, each at most once. The resulting factor is  $2, 2 \cdot 3, 2 \cdot 5$  or  $2 \cdot 3 \cdot 5$ .  $\square$

The coefficient subtracted at step  $a$  is the shell mass with its denominators cleared:

$$m_a = h_{a+1} s_a = \sum_{\substack{x \text{ smooth} \\ 2^a \leq x < 2^{a+1}}} \frac{P_{a+1}}{2H(x)}.$$

Each summand is an integer, by the same strict-cutoff argument. For example,  $[2, 4)$  contains just 2 and 3, so  $m_1 = 6(1/2 + 1/6) = 4$  and  $X_2 = 6X_1 - 4$ . The first four pairs  $(b_a, m_a)$ , starting at  $a = 1$ , are  $(6, 4)$ ,  $(10, 7)$ ,  $(6, 7)$  and  $(30, 65)$ . In particular  $m_3 > b_3$ : these coefficients are not positional digits.

The shell  $[16, 32)$  shows why the order of the jumps matters. Its internal jumps are 25 and 27, in that order. The four smooth numbers 16, 18, 20, 24 precede both jumps and have weight 15; 25 precedes only the jump at 27 and has weight 3; and 27, 30 have weight 1. Thus

$$m_4 = 4 \cdot 15 + 1 \cdot 3 + 2 \cdot 1 = 7 + (5 - 1) \cdot 4 \cdot 3 + (3 - 1) \cdot 5 = 65.$$

The second expression starts with the seven points and adds the corrections before 25 and 27. It is this form that extends to every shell.

To compute  $m_a$  in general, count the smooth numbers before each prime-power jump. Let  $\mathcal{N}(t)$  be the number of positive  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ -smooth integers strictly below  $t$ . First give every point in  $[2^a, 2^{a+1})$  weight one. At an internal jump  $p^e$ , the points before that jump need an additional weight  $p - 1$ , multiplied by the prime factors at all later internal jumps. Thus, for  $a \geq 1$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} m_a &= \mathcal{N}(2^{a+1}) - \mathcal{N}(2^a) \\ &\quad + \sum_{(p,e) \in I_a} (p - 1)(\mathcal{N}(p^e) - \mathcal{N}(2^a)) \prod_{\substack{(q,f) \in I_a \\ p^e < q^f}} q, \end{aligned} \quad (15)$$

$$m_0 = 1.$$

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The first difference counts the whole shell; each later difference counts its points strictly before the indicated jump. The proof below justifies these weights, establishes convergence and derives the tail identities.

**Theorem 8.2** (the tail recurrence). *The shell masses are summable and  $S = \sum_{a \geq 0} s_a$ . For every  $a \geq 0$ ,*

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$$m_a = h_{a+1}s_a \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}, \quad X_{a+1} = b_a X_a - m_a, \quad X_a = \sum_{j \geq a} \frac{m_j}{b_a b_{a+1} \cdots b_j}. \quad (16)$$

*Proof.* Every exponent of 3 or 5 in the  $a$ th shell is at most  $a$ , and for each such pair Lemma 3.5 leaves at most one exponent of 2 placing the point in  $[2^a, 2^{a+1})$ . Each height is at least  $2^a$  and the shell contains  $2^a$ , so  $0 < s_a \leq (a+1)^2 2^{-a}$ . The majorant is summable, which justifies every tail splitting below, and unique prime factorisation identifies  $\sum_a s_a$  with the original repeated series.

Write the internal jumps as  $t_\ell = p_\ell^{e_\ell}$ ,  $1 \leq \ell \leq v$ , and set  $t_0 = 2^a$ ,  $t_{v+1} = 2^{a+1}$  and  $n_\ell = \mathcal{N}(t_\ell)$ . On  $[t_\ell, t_{\ell+1})$  the height is  $P_a \prod_{u \leq \ell} p_u$ , and the terminal jump has factor two, so

$$h_{a+1}s_a = \sum_{\ell=0}^v (n_{\ell+1} - n_\ell) \prod_{u > \ell} p_u = n_{v+1} - n_0 + \sum_{\ell=1}^v (p_\ell - 1) \left( \prod_{u > \ell} p_u \right) (n_\ell - n_0).$$

The second equality is finite summation by parts and is exactly (15). The count itself is finite: for  $p = 2, 3, 5$ , with  $q, r$  the other primes, counting by the exponent of  $p$  gives

$$\mathcal{N}(p^e) = \sum_{u=1}^e \#\{(i, j) \in \mathbb{N}^2 : q^i r^j < p^u\}.$$

At  $a = 0$  the shell is the single point 1, giving  $m_0 = 1$ . Positivity follows from  $s_a > 0$ . Splitting  $T_a = s_a + T_{a+1}$  and multiplying by  $h_a$  gives the recurrence, and  $b_a \cdots b_j = P_{j+1}/P_a$  with  $m_j = h_{j+1}s_j$  gives  $m_j/(b_a \cdots b_j) = h_a s_j$ , whose summation is the last identity.  $\square$

For estimates, it is useful to count by the odd part  $3^j 5^k$  instead. Each such part below  $2^{a+1}$  has exactly one power-of-two multiple in  $[2^a, 2^{a+1})$ . This turns the same numerator into a two-dimensional count, with weights determined by the remaining odd-prime jumps.

**Lemma 8.3** (the shell numerator as a weighted lattice count). *Put  $\lambda_3 = \log_2 3$ ,  $\lambda_5 = \log_2 5$  and  $\theta_p = 1/\lambda_p$  for  $p = 3, 5$ . For  $j, k \geq 0$  write  $w_{j,k} = j\lambda_3 + k\lambda_5$  and  $t_{j,k} = \{w_{j,k}\}$ . The shell numerator is*

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$$m_a = \sum_{\substack{j,k \geq 0 \\ w_{j,k} < a+1}} 3^{\lfloor (a+1)\theta_3 \rfloor - \lfloor (a+t_{j,k})\theta_3 \rfloor} 5^{\lfloor (a+1)\theta_5 \rfloor - \lfloor (a+t_{j,k})\theta_5 \rfloor}.$$

Every summand is in  $\{1, 3, 5, 15\}$ . In particular, for  $a \geq 0$ ,

$$(\lfloor a/(2\lambda_3) \rfloor + 1)(\lfloor a/(2\lambda_5) \rfloor + 1) \leq m_a \leq 15(a+1)^2.$$

Thus  $m_a = \Theta((a+1)^2)$  and the numerator sequence is unbounded. These are integer numerators, not positional digits restricted to  $\{0, \dots, b_a - 1\}$ .

*Proof.* For each pair with  $w_{j,k} < a + 1$ , exactly one exponent  $i = a - \lfloor w_{j,k} \rfloor \geq 0$  puts  $2^i 3^j 5^k = 2^{a+\lfloor w_{j,k} \rfloor}$  in  $[2^a, 2^{a+1})$ . This pairs each point of the triangle with exactly one smooth integer in the shell. Substituting in  $P_{a+1}/(2H(2^i 3^j 5^k))$  cancels the power of 2 and gives the displayed weight. Each remaining floor increment is zero or one since  $0 < \theta_p < 1$ . Finally  $\lambda_3, \lambda_5 > 1$  implies  $j, k \leq a$  for every summation pair, proving the upper bound. For the lower bound, restrict to  $0 \leq j \leq \lfloor a/(2\lambda_3) \rfloor$  and  $0 \leq k \leq \lfloor a/(2\lambda_5) \rfloor$ . Then  $w_{j,k} \leq a$  and each weight is at least one.  $\square$

The formula shows two sources of variation in  $m_a$ : points enter the triangle as  $a$  increases, and their weights depend on two floors. Quadratic growth does not make this count a quadratic polynomial.

The recurrence also restricts how persistently a nonintegral tail can approach the integers. The following alternative uses only the integer coefficients and the bounds  $2 \leq b_a \leq 30$ .

**Proposition 8.4** (integer tails or repeated separation from the integers). *For every integer  $B \geq 1$ , either  $BX_a \in \mathbb{Z}$  for some  $a \geq 0$  and every later  $a$ , or for every  $a_0$  there is  $a \geq a_0$  with  $|BX_a - z| \geq 1/31$  for every  $z \in \mathbb{Z}$ .*

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*Proof.* If the second alternative fails, there are  $A$  and integers  $z_a$  such that  $e_a = BX_a - z_a$  satisfies  $|e_a| < 1/31$  for all  $a \geq A$ . The recurrence gives  $z_{a+1} - b_a z_a + Bm_a = b_a e_a - e_{a+1}$ . Since  $Bm_a$  is integral, the left side is an integer; the right side has absolute value less than  $(30 + 1)/31 = 1$ . Both sides therefore vanish, so  $e_{a+1} = b_a e_a$ . Hence  $|e_{A+k}| \geq 2^k |e_A|$  for every  $k$ , whereas  $|e_{A+k}| < 1/31$ . Thus  $e_A = 0$ , and the integer recurrence propagates integrality from  $BX_A$  to every later  $BX_a$ .  $\square$

The proposition does not determine which alternative holds for the tails of  $S$ . For comparison, Erdős–Taylor [21, Theorem 1, p. 600] prove a countability statement for increasing integer sequences with bounded successive ratios; Fan [22, Lemma 3.1, arXiv v1] allows an unbounded, not necessarily increasing sequence, still with a uniform upper bound on successive ratios. For our divisibility chain the same error argument identifies the entire exceptional set, not just its cardinality. For each fixed integer  $B \geq 1$ ,

$$\{\tilde{\zeta} \in \mathbb{R} : \text{dist}(Bh_a \tilde{\zeta}, \mathbb{Z}) \rightarrow 0\} = \frac{1}{B} \mathbb{Z}[1/30], \quad \mathbb{Z}[1/30] = \{m/30^t : m \in \mathbb{Z}, t \in \mathbb{N}\}.$$

Indeed, apply the proof above to  $Bh_a \tilde{\zeta}$ , whose successive terms are related by multiplication by  $b_a$ . Convergence of the distances forces  $Bh_A \tilde{\zeta} \in \mathbb{Z}$  for some  $A \geq 1$ . Since  $h_A$  has no prime factors outside 2, 3, 5, this gives membership in the right-hand side. Conversely, every fixed product of powers of 2, 3, 5 eventually divides  $h_a$ , so every member of the right-hand side gives integral values for all large  $a$ .

Separation from the integers for one multiplier does not prove irrationality. For example,  $\tilde{\zeta} = 1/7$  satisfies  $\text{dist}(h_a \tilde{\zeta}, \mathbb{Z}) \geq 1/7$  for every  $a \geq 1$ , because  $7 \nmid h_a$ ; with  $B = 7$  the values  $Bh_a \tilde{\zeta}$  are all integers. For  $S$ , the denominator clearing in Theorem 9.3 below shows which multipliers matter: the integral alternative for the actual tails must be excluded for every  $B \geq 1$  coprime to 30, not merely for  $B = 1$ .

## 9 Bounding the tails and clearing a rational denominator

We sharpen the quadratic estimate by counting points of equal height. As the cutoff increases, one height exponent increases at each jump, so the sum of the exponents indexes the nonempty cells. At  $2^a$  it is

$$n_a = a + \lfloor \log_3(2^a) \rfloor + \lfloor \log_5(2^a) \rfloor.$$

Counting the points in each cell and summing their geometric weights gives the polynomial

$$Q(n) = \frac{n^2 + 8n + 18}{9}.$$

**Theorem 9.1** (a quadratic upper bound). *For every  $a \geq 0$ ,  $0 < X_a \leq Q(n_a)$ .*

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*Proof.* Partition the smooth integers  $x \geq 2^a$  by their height vector

$$(A, B, C) = (\lfloor \log_2 x \rfloor, \lfloor \log_3 x \rfloor, \lfloor \log_5 x \rfloor).$$

The cell of a vector is the interval  $[\lambda, \eta)$ , where

$$\lambda = \max(2^A, 3^B, 5^C), \quad \eta = \min(2^{A+1}, 3^{B+1}, 5^{C+1}).$$

Thus  $\eta \leq 2^{A+1} \leq 2\lambda$ . By Lemma 3.5, fixing the exponents of 3 and 5 leaves at most one exponent of 2. Since  $A \geq B \geq C$ , the cell contains at most

$$(B+1)(C+1) \leq \frac{(A+B+C+3)^2}{9}$$

smooth points: writing  $u = B+1 \geq v = C+1$  and using  $A+1 \geq u$ , the difference  $(2u+v)^2 - 9uv = (u-v)(4u-v)$  is nonnegative. Unique factorisation identifies these exponent triples with distinct smooth integers.

As the cutoff increases all three height exponents are nondecreasing, so two nonempty cells with the same exponent sum are the same cell, and there is at most one nonempty cell with each exponent sum. Every cell above  $2^a$  has exponent sum at least  $n_a$ , and a cell with sum  $n_a + k$  has height at least  $P_a 2^k$ , since each of the  $k$  extra prime factors is at least 2. Nonnegative summation over exponent sums, allowing empty cells, gives

$$X_a \leq \frac{1}{18} \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{(n_a + k + 3)^2}{2^k} = \frac{n_a^2 + 8n_a + 18}{9},$$

the evaluation using the geometric moments  $\sum 2^{-k} = 2$ ,  $\sum k 2^{-k} = 2$  and  $\sum k^2 2^{-k} = 6$ . Positivity follows from the shell at  $2^a$ .  $\square$

Increasing the exponent sum by one costs a factor of at least two in the denominator, whereas the number of points in a cell grows at most quadratically. Summing those geometric contributions gives the bound. The argument uses unique factorisation and the projection count, not an asymptotic estimate for smooth numbers or a Hecke–Mahler theorem.

The quadratic order is also necessary. The positive next tail and the recurrence give

$$X_a = \frac{m_a + X_{a+1}}{b_a} > \frac{m_a}{b_a} \geq \frac{m_a}{30}.$$

The lower bound of Lemma 8.3, together with  $n_a \leq 3a$ , therefore gives  $X_a = \Theta((a+1)^2)$ . In particular, the normalised tails are not uniformly bounded. This order estimate does not assert an asymptotic constant or optimality of  $Q$ .

The bound is used at the endpoint of a window, where the natural index is the positive prime-power jump count strictly below the cutoff. Put

$$j_a = \#\{p^e < 2^a : p \in \{2, 3, 5\}, e \geq 1\} = n_a - 1 \quad (a \geq 1), \quad (17)$$

the equality holding for  $a \geq 1$  because the powers of 2 below  $2^a$  number  $a - 1$  while the powers of 3 and of 5 below  $2^a$  number  $\lfloor \log_3 2^a \rfloor$  and  $\lfloor \log_5 2^a \rfloor$ ; at  $a = 0$  the count is  $j_0 = 0$  and  $n_0 - 1 = -1$ . Substituting  $n_a = j_a + 1$  into  $Q$  gives the integer bound used throughout the rest of the note:

$$K(B, a) = \lfloor BQ(n_a) \rfloor, \quad K(B, a) = \left\lfloor \frac{B(j_a^2 + 10j_a + 27)}{9} \right\rfloor \quad (a \geq 1). \quad (18)$$

The cutoff in (17) is  $2^a$  and it is strict. The symbol  $K(B, a)$  bounds an *integral* quantity  $BX_a$ : from  $BX_a \leq BQ(n_a)$  one may take the floor only after integrality has been established. We do not assert  $BX_a \leq K(B, a)$  for arbitrary real tails. The short paper uses the coarser bound  $K_{\text{short}}(B, a) = 90B(a+1)^2$ . In this record  $K$  always denotes the sharper bound in (18); the residue theorem below allows either choice.

**Lemma 9.2** (finite denominator clearing). *For all integers  $0 \leq u \leq b$  the window mass  $h_b \sum_{a=u}^{b-1} s_a$  is a natural number. If  $S = N/D$  with  $N \in \mathbb{Z}$  and  $D \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ , then  $DX_a \in \mathbb{Z}$  for every  $a \geq 1$ , and there are indices  $1 \leq i < j \leq D+1$  for which  $X_i - X_j \in \mathbb{Z}$ .*

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*Proof.* An empty window has mass zero. Otherwise  $b \geq 1$ , and every integer  $x < 2^b$  has 2-height exponent at most  $b-1$  while its other height exponents are at most those at  $2^b$ , so  $H(x) \mid P_b/2 = h_b$  and every term of the finite window clears at  $h_b$ . Since  $h_a \sum_{u < a} s_u$  is an integer,

$$DX_a = h_a N - D h_a \sum_{u < a} s_u \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

Among  $D+1$  of these integers two share a residue modulo  $D$ , and the corresponding states differ by an integer.  $\square$

The strict upper endpoint is what permits division by two. A cutoff including  $2^b$  would not clear its term at the normaliser  $h_b = P_b/2$ .

**Theorem 9.3** (rationality gives positive integer tails). *Suppose  $S = N/D$  with  $N \in \mathbb{Z}$ ,  $D \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ , and write*

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$$D = 2^u 3^v 5^w B, \quad u, v, w \in \mathbb{N}, \quad B \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}, \quad \gcd(B, 30) = 1, \quad a_D = u + 1 + 2v + 3w.$$

*Then for every  $a \geq a_D$  the number  $d_a = BX_a$  is a positive integer and*

$$d_{a+1} = b_a d_a - B m_a, \quad 1 \leq d_a \leq K(B, a) \leq 90B(a+1)^2.$$

*Proof.* Let  $M = 2^u 3^v 5^w$ . For  $a \geq a_D$  we have  $2^a \geq 2^{u+1}$ ,  $2^a \geq 3^v$  and  $2^a \geq 5^w$ , using  $3 < 2^2$  and  $5 < 2^3$ ; hence  $M \mid h_a$ . By Lemma 9.2,  $X_a$  differs from  $h_a N/D$  by an integer. Since  $M \mid h_a$  and  $D = MB$ , multiplying by  $B$  shows that  $BX_a$  is an integer. Positivity and the recurrence come from (16), and the upper bound is Theorem 9.1 with the floor taken, since  $d_a$  is an integer at most  $BQ(n_a)$ . Finally  $n_a \leq 3a$ , so  $Q(n_a) \leq a^2 + \frac{8}{3}a + 2 \leq 90(a+1)^2$ .  $\square$

Every positive denominator admits the stated factorisation: remove all powers of 2, 3 and 5, leaving  $B$  coprime to 30. Thus the theorem does not impose an extra restriction on a hypothetical rational  $S$ . The removed factor  $2^u 3^v 5^w$  controls how far out the integer tails begin; their bound depends on  $B$ . The displayed  $a_D$  is sufficient, but need not be the first such index. The next proposition gives the first index when the fraction is reduced. Write  $\text{den}(x)$  for the positive denominator of a rational number  $x$  in lowest terms.

**Proposition 9.4** (exact denominators and minimal clearing). *Suppose  $S = N/(MB)$  is in lowest terms, with  $M = 2^u 3^v 5^w$  and  $\gcd(B, 30) = 1$ . For every  $a \geq 1$ ,*

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$$\text{den}(X_a) = \frac{MB}{\gcd(M, h_a)}, \quad \text{den}(BX_a) = \frac{M}{\gcd(M, h_a)}.$$

Hence the first integral reduced tail occurs at

$$a_* = \min\{a \geq 1 : 2^a \geq \max(2^{u+1}, 3^v, 5^w)\} \leq a_D,$$

and  $BX_a$  is integral exactly for  $a \geq a_*$ . This onset is computable by integer powers; it is not an estimate obtained by rounding logarithms.

*Proof.* The finite prefix clears at  $h_a$ , so Lemma 9.2 gives  $X_a - h_a N/(MB) \in \mathbb{Z}$ . Since  $\gcd(N, MB) = 1$  and every prime factor of  $h_a$  is in  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ , cancellation removes exactly  $\gcd(M, h_a)$  from the denominator. Multiplication by  $B$  gives the second formula. Now  $M \mid h_a$  means  $a - 1 \geq u$ ,  $\lfloor \log_3 2^a \rfloor \geq v$  and  $\lfloor \log_5 2^a \rfloor \geq w$ , precisely the three integer inequalities. All three persist when  $a$  increases, giving the first and every later integral reduced tail. The earlier bounds  $3 < 4$  and  $5 < 8$  give  $a_* \leq a_D$ .  $\square$

For example, a hypothetical reduced denominator  $2^3 3^2 5 \cdot 7$  would require  $2^a \geq \max(16, 9, 5)$ , so  $a_* = 4$  rather than the sufficient  $a_D = 11$ . Lowest terms matter for this exact answer: unreduced factors could cancel against the numerator sooner.

The recurrence preserves integrality forward. Its homogeneous equation also determines how fast two distinct solutions separate.

**Proposition 9.5** (propagation of integrality and uniqueness of a small solution). *For every  $a$ ,  $X_a = (m_a + X_{a+1})/b_a > 0$ , and if  $X_a \in \mathbb{Z}$  then  $X_n \in \mathbb{Z}$  for every  $n \geq a$ . Moreover, fix  $A$ , a positive width function  $w$  with  $w(A+k)/8^k \rightarrow 0$ , and a real sequence  $(y_n)_{n \geq A}$  satisfying  $y_{n+1} = b_n y_n - m_n$ . If  $y_n$  and  $X_n$  both lie in  $(m_n/b_n, m_n/b_n + w(n)]$  for every  $n \geq A$ , then  $y_A = X_A$ .*

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*Proof.* The identity is the recurrence solved for  $X_a$ , and positivity holds because every shell contains its dyadic left endpoint. Integer coefficients preserve integrality at every

later step. For the last assertion,  $y_{A+k} - X_{A+k} = (P_{A+k}/P_A)(y_A - X_A)$ . The dyadic height bounds from Section 8 give  $P_{A+k}/P_A > 8^k/15$ , whereas the common interval bounds the absolute difference by  $w(A+k)$ . Thus  $|y_A - X_A| < 15w(A+k)/8^k \rightarrow 0$ .  $\square$

The width condition allows every positive polynomial width and widths  $\rho^n$  with  $1 < \rho < 8$ , but not  $8^n$  itself. Both solutions must lie in the stated intervals; the recurrence alone does not supply that condition. More generally, fix an integer  $B \geq 1$ . Every real solution of  $y_{a+1} = b_a y_a - B m_a$  starting at an index  $A$  satisfies

$$y_a = B X_a + \frac{P_a}{P_A} (y_A - B X_A) \quad (a \geq A).$$

Subtracting the recurrence for  $B X_a$  proves the identity. Since  $X_a = O((a+1)^2)$  and  $P_a = \Theta(8^a)$ , the unique solution with  $y_a = o(8^a)$  is  $y_a = B X_a$ ; every other solution has  $|y_a| = \Theta(8^a)$ . This classifies growth; integrality of  $B X_a$  remains a separate question. The same formula explains a numerical precaution: a starting error  $\varepsilon$  is multiplied by  $P_a/P_A$  under forward iteration. A decimal approximation propagated forwards is therefore not a certificate of the tail floors. The digit calculation in Section 12 uses rational intervals with an explicit infinite-tail bound instead.

### 9.1 A bound using the order of the jumps

The bound in Theorem 9.1 uses only the fact that every new prime factor is at least 2. Successive powers of 2 cannot continue indefinitely without a power of 3 between them. Incorporating that restriction improves the geometric majorant.

**Proposition 9.6** (a smaller quadratic bound). *For every  $a \geq 0$ ,*

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$$0 < X_a \leq \tilde{Q}(n_a) < Q(n_a), \quad \tilde{Q}(n) = \frac{1210n^2 + 9130n + 18847}{11979}.$$

*Proof.* For a point  $x \geq 2^a$ , let  $d_p$  be the increase in its  $p$ -height exponent from the boundary  $2^a$ , and put  $k = d_2 + d_3 + d_5$ . The definition of  $d_3$  gives  $x < 3^{\lfloor \log_3 2^a \rfloor + d_3 + 1} \leq 2^a 3^{d_3 + 1} < 2^{a+2d_3+2}$ , hence  $d_2 \leq 2d_3 + 1$ . It follows that  $k \leq 3(d_3 + d_5) + 1$ , so at least  $j = \lfloor (k+1)/3 \rfloor$  of the  $k$  new prime factors are odd. Each of these contributes at least 3, and each remaining factor at least 2. Hence

$$\frac{H(x)}{P_a} \geq 2^{k-j} 3^j =: d(k).$$

There is at most one height cell with each exponent sum, with at most  $(n_a + k + 3)^2/9$  supported points by the earlier projection bound. Consequently

$$X_a \leq \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{(n_a + k + 3)^2}{18d(k)}.$$

Now  $d(3m) = 12^m$ ,  $d(3m+1) = 2 \cdot 12^m$  and  $d(3m+2) = 6 \cdot 12^m$ . Grouping in threes and summing the quadratic geometric series gives  $\tilde{Q}(n_a)$ . Finally  $11979(Q(n) - \tilde{Q}(n)) = 121n^2 + 1518n + 5111 > 0$  for  $n \geq 0$ .  $\square$

The estimate uses the original shell multiplicities and the order of the prime-power jumps. It is not a bound for an arbitrary recurrence with the same bases. For an integral  $BX_a$ , the bound can be rounded down to  $\lfloor B\tilde{Q}(n_a) \rfloor$ . This improves the bound available in a rationality contradiction. Theorem 10.2 and the recorded finite tests use  $K$ , not this smaller bound. No optimality claim is made for either quadratic bound.

Section 10 explains how the smaller bound can also replace  $K$  in the residue argument.

**Relation to Cantor-series criteria.** Since  $h_0 = 1/2$ , the value  $S/2 = X_0$  is the Cantor series  $\sum_{a \geq 0} m_a/P_{a+1}$ , with  $P_0 = 1$  and  $P_{a+1} = b_a P_a$ . Its normalised tails  $X_a$  are the usual objects in the rationality criteria for Cantor series. Under a small-numerator hypothesis, Erdős and Straus characterise rationality by the existence of a positive integer  $B$  and integers  $c_a$  satisfying, eventually,

$$Bm_a = b_a c_a - c_{a+1}, \quad |c_{a+1}| < b_a/2$$

[18, Theorem 2.1 and (2.4), pp. 85–86]. The second condition is part of the criterion, not a consequence of the recurrence alone. Their proof already chooses nearest integers. Hančl and Tijdeman make that choice part of the criterion: they prescribe  $c_a$  as a nearest integer to  $Bm_a/b_a$  and require the recurrence [19, §§2–3 and Theorem 3.1, pp. 372–375]. Koutsoukou-Argyraki and Li formalised the Erdős–Straus criteria in Isabelle/HOL [20].

Both cited criteria require  $m_a/(b_{a-1}b_a) \rightarrow 0$  in our notation. Here the weighted-triangle count gives  $m_a = \Theta((a+1)^2)$ , and

$$\frac{m_a}{900} \leq \frac{m_a}{b_{a-1}b_a} \leq \frac{m_a}{4} \quad (a \geq 1).$$

The ratio therefore has quadratic order and tends to infinity. There is also a direct lower count that does not use the real-logarithm triangle estimate. For  $a \geq 1$ , each pair  $0 \leq j, k \leq \lfloor a/5 \rfloor$  has  $3^j 5^k < 2^a$ , since  $15 < 2^5$ , and hence a unique power-of-two multiple in  $[2^a, 2^{a+1})$ . Each such point contributes at least one to  $m_a$ . Thus  $m_a \geq (\lfloor a/5 \rfloor + 1)^2$ , an elementary lower bound sufficient to see directly that the small-numerator condition fails.

The actual scaled tails also satisfy

$$BX_a - \frac{Bm_a}{b_a} = \frac{BX_{a+1}}{b_a} = \Theta((a+1)^2)$$

for each fixed  $B \geq 1$ , by the recurrence, the quadratic tail bounds and  $2 \leq b_a \leq 30$ . Thus any eventual integer tails supplied by a hypothetical rational value could not be the prescribed nearest integers. In fact, those prescribed integers fail the recurrence at every sufficiently large index, regardless of how ties are resolved. If  $c_a$  is a nearest integer to  $Bm_a/b_a$ , then

$$|b_a c_a - Bm_a| \leq 15, \quad c_{a+1} \geq \frac{Bm_{a+1}}{30} - \frac{1}{2} \rightarrow \infty.$$

Consequently  $c_{a+1} = b_a c_a - Bm_a$  is impossible for all sufficiently large  $a$ . This is a failure of the proposed carry construction, not an irrationality contradiction: the criterion's small-numerator hypothesis also fails.

The denominator clearing itself is standard; the calculations specific to this series retain its multiplicities, use the strict endpoint to divide the normaliser by two, and bound the resulting positive tails.

For polynomial Cantor data, Hančl–Tijdeman [25, Theorems 2.2 and 3.1] give a polynomial cancellation criterion and a division mechanism. Their nonconstant polynomial radix is not our bounded  $(b_a)$ . Their separate Theorem 4.2 uses a finite-product rearrangement. We do not use an unrestricted infinite reindexing from that argument: for the integer decompositions considered here, the terminal terms must be checked separately. In the first-order case  $m_a = b_a c_a - c_{a+1}$ , finite summation gives

$$\sum_{a=0}^{N-1} \frac{m_a}{P_{a+1}} = c_0 - \frac{c_N}{P_N}.$$

Every integer  $c_0$  generates an integer solution recursively. Hence  $c_N/P_N \rightarrow c_0 - S/2$ ; the existence of an integer solution gives no rationality information.

For these actual numerators the terminal term cannot vanish for *any* integer  $c_0$ . Indeed,  $P_3 = 120$ ,  $n_3 = 5$  and  $(m_0, m_1, m_2) = (1, 4, 7)$ , so the tail bound gives

$$0 < \frac{S}{2} = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{4}{12} + \frac{7}{120} + \frac{X_3}{120} \leq \frac{107}{120} + \frac{83}{1080} = \frac{523}{540} < 1.$$

Thus  $c_0 - S/2 \neq 0$  for every integer  $c_0$ . Since  $8^N/15 < P_N \leq 8^N$ , every such unscaled integer solution satisfies  $|c_N| = \Theta(8^N)$ . This is a concrete reason that quadratic growth of  $m_a$  does not imply polynomial growth of recursively defined carries. The starting index is essential: this does not exclude the actual tails becoming integral at a later index. After replacing  $m_a$  by  $Dm_a$  for an integer  $D \geq 1$ , however, a vanishing terminal term would require  $DS/2 = c_0$ . Excluding that possibility for every  $D$  would require irrationality itself; the unscaled calculation does not do so.

In the cited rearrangement the transformed integer numerator must be  $o(b_a)$ , which for bounded radices means eventual zero. Only after the terminal terms have been controlled does this cancellation determine the infinite sum. A polynomial bound on each individual decomposition coefficient would suffice for a fixed number of shifts: the corresponding series are absolutely convergent, since their denominators are products of at least 2 at each step. A polynomial bound on the combined numerators is not a substitute, as the exponentially growing carries above demonstrate. Nor does quadratic growth force a carry to be a polynomial in the floor coordinates.

## 10 A residue criterion and the bounds it allows

Two iterations already show how the recurrence determines an endpoint residue:

$$X_2 = 6X_1 - 4, \quad X_3 = 10X_2 - 7 = 60X_1 - 47.$$

Whenever  $BX_1$  is integral,  $BX_3 \equiv -47B \pmod{60}$ . We obtain a lower bound on any positive integral tail by taking the least positive representative of this class. Comparing it with the quadratic upper bound gives a contradiction whenever the two bounds are

incompatible. To test every possible denominator, we need windows starting beyond an arbitrary prescribed index.

A window starts at  $\ell \geq 0$  and consists of  $h \geq 0$  steps. Its product of bases and accumulated numerator are integers, even when the tails are not. Set

$$W_{\ell,0} = 1, \quad F_{\ell,0} = 0, \quad W_{\ell,h+1} = b_{\ell+h} W_{\ell,h}, \quad F_{\ell,h+1} = b_{\ell+h} F_{\ell,h} + m_{\ell+h}.$$

Induction gives

$$X_{\ell+h} = W_{\ell,h} X_{\ell} - F_{\ell,h}, \quad d_{\ell+h} = W_{\ell,h} d_{\ell} - B F_{\ell,h} \quad (19)$$

for any sequence satisfying  $d_{n+1} = b_n d_n - B m_n$ . Since  $b_a = P_{a+1}/P_a$ , the product telescopes to  $W_{\ell,h} = P_{\ell+h}/P_{\ell}$ . The previously proved bounds  $8^a/15 < P_a \leq 8^a$  therefore give  $W_{\ell,h} > 8^h/15$ . For a positive integer  $C$  and an integer  $N$ , use  $\text{lpr}_C(N) = 1 + ((N-1) \bmod C) \in \{1, \dots, C\}$ . In particular  $\text{lpr}_C(0) = C$ . Positivity of this representative is what allows comparison with a positive integral carry.

**Proposition 10.1** (least positive residues). *Let  $C > 0$  and let  $c$  be an integer with  $0 < c$  and  $|c| \leq K$ . If  $c \equiv N \pmod{C}$  and  $K < \text{lpr}_C(N)$ , then the hypotheses are contradictory.*

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*Proof.* Every positive integer congruent to  $N$  is at least  $\text{lpr}_C(N)$ . Thus  $\text{lpr}_C(N) \leq c = |c| \leq K$ , contrary to the strict inequality.  $\square$

For a bound  $G : \mathbb{N}_{>0} \times \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$  let  $E(G)$  be the statement

$$\begin{aligned} &\text{for every } B \geq 1 \text{ with } \gcd(B, 30) = 1 \text{ and every } a_0 \geq 1, \\ &\text{there are } \ell \geq a_0 \text{ and } h \geq 1 \text{ with } \text{lpr}_{W_{\ell,h}}(-B F_{\ell,h}) > G(B, \ell + h). \end{aligned} \quad (20)$$

The window may depend on both  $B$  and  $a_0$ . All quantities in the inequality are finite integers. The quantifiers over denominators and prescribed onsets are nevertheless unbounded; a search over a finite rectangle of  $(B, \ell)$  does not verify them. Every  $b_a > 0$ , so  $W_{\ell,h} > 0$  is automatic.

The two hypotheses on  $G$  in the next theorem serve different purposes. Domination of  $K$  lets a residue above  $G$  exclude a positive integer tail. The limit  $G(B, a)/8^a \rightarrow 0$  lets every sufficiently long window from a fixed nonintegral start overtake  $G$ . It is a sufficient growth condition, not a necessary one: if only existence of a window is required, a subsequence of small endpoint bounds can suffice, as we prove below. The stated theorem already covers every polynomial upper bound that dominates  $K$ , and also  $\max\{K(B, a), \lceil B \rho^a \rceil\}$  for  $1 < \rho < 8$ . The zero bound fails to control the possible integer tail.

**Theorem 10.2** (a residue criterion for every dominating bound of size  $o(8^a)$ ). *Let  $G : \mathbb{N}_{>0} \times \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$  satisfy  $K(B, a) \leq G(B, a)$  for all  $B$  and  $a$ , and  $G(B, a)/8^a \rightarrow 0$  as  $a \rightarrow \infty$  for each fixed  $B$ . Then*

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$$E(G) \iff S \notin \mathbb{Q}.$$

Both  $K$  of (18) and  $K_0(B, a) = 90B(a+1)^2$  satisfy these hypotheses, so  $E(K)$ ,  $E(K_0)$  and irrationality of  $S$  are mutually equivalent. By contrast,  $E(0)$  holds automatically, since every least positive residue is at least 1; its truth alone therefore provides no contradiction to an integral tail.

*Proof.* Suppose  $E(G)$  and suppose  $S = N/D$  were rational. Theorem 9.3 supplies  $B \geq 1$  coprime to 30, an onset  $a_D$ , and positive integers  $d_a = BX_a \leq K(B, a) \leq G(B, a)$  for  $a \geq a_D$  satisfying the cleared recurrence. Apply (20) with  $a_0 = a_D$  to obtain a window  $(\ell, h)$  with  $\ell \geq a_D$ . By (19),  $d_{\ell+h} \equiv -BF_{\ell,h}$  modulo  $W_{\ell,h}$ , while  $0 < d_{\ell+h} \leq G(B, \ell+h) < \text{lpr}_{W_{\ell,h}}(-BF_{\ell,h})$ . Proposition 10.1 is the contradiction, so  $S$  is irrational.

Conversely suppose  $S \notin \mathbb{Q}$ , and fix  $B \geq 1$  coprime to 30 and  $a_0 \geq 1$ . Set  $\ell = a_0$  and  $\delta = \lceil BX_\ell \rceil - BX_\ell \in (0, 1)$ ; the prefix identity makes  $BX_\ell$  irrational. For all sufficiently large  $h$ ,  $0 < \delta + BX_{\ell+h}/W_{\ell,h} < 1$ , because  $X_{\ell+h} = O((\ell+h+1)^2)$  and  $W_{\ell,h} > 8^h/15$  as shown above. The integer  $\lceil BX_\ell \rceil W_{\ell,h} - BF_{\ell,h}$  is therefore exactly

$$\text{lpr}_{W_{\ell,h}}(-BF_{\ell,h}) = \delta W_{\ell,h} + BX_{\ell+h}.$$

Its first term eventually exceeds  $G(B, \ell+h)$ , since  $G(B, a) = o(8^a)$ . Thus every sufficiently long window from this fixed start escapes, which is stronger than the required existence.

For the two stated bounds,  $n_a \leq 3a$  gives  $K(B, a) \leq BQ(3a) \leq 90B(a+1)^2 = K_0(B, a)$ . Both are  $O((a+1)^2)$  for fixed  $B$ , so both satisfy the required limit. Finally,  $\text{lpr}_C(N) \geq 1 > 0$  always, independently of whether any tail is integral; a residue greater than zero cannot exclude a positive integer.  $\square$

The domination assumption is sufficient, not asserted to be necessary for equivalence. In particular, Proposition 9.6 already supplies the smaller valid bound  $\lfloor B\widetilde{Q}(n_a) \rfloor$ . Replacing  $K$  by that bound in the forward implication leaves the argument unchanged; the converse uses only  $G(B, a) = o(8^a)$ . The zero-bound example explains why a size comparison with the possible integer tail is needed in the contradiction, not why this particular  $K$  is indispensable.

The reverse implication gives more than existence: at any fixed start with  $BX_\ell$  non-integral, the least positive residue eventually occupies a fixed positive fraction of the whole modulus. The next proposition states this without assuming that  $S$  is irrational.

**Proposition 10.3** (the fixed-start residue limit). *For fixed integers  $B, \ell \geq 1$ , write*

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$$R_h = \text{lpr}_{W_{\ell,h}}(-BF_{\ell,h}).$$

*For all sufficiently large  $h$ ,*

$$R_h = (\lceil BX_\ell \rceil - BX_\ell)W_{\ell,h} + BX_{\ell+h},$$

*and consequently*

$$\lim_{h \rightarrow \infty} \frac{R_h}{W_{\ell,h}} = \lceil BX_\ell \rceil - BX_\ell.$$

*In particular, if  $BX_\ell$  is integral, then  $R_h = BX_{\ell+h}$  for all sufficiently large  $h$ .*

*Proof.* The least positive residue is the modulus times the gap to the next strictly larger integer. Division with remainder gives

$$\frac{R_h}{W_{\ell,h}} = \left\lfloor \frac{BF_{\ell,h}}{W_{\ell,h}} \right\rfloor + 1 - \frac{BF_{\ell,h}}{W_{\ell,h}}.$$

By the window identity,  $BF_{\ell,h}/W_{\ell,h} = BX_\ell - BX_{\ell+h}/W_{\ell,h}$ . These finite sums approach  $BX_\ell$  strictly from below, since  $BX_{\ell+h} > 0$  and  $BX_{\ell+h}/W_{\ell,h} \rightarrow 0$ . Their floors therefore eventually equal  $\lceil BX_\ell \rceil - 1$ , including when  $BX_\ell$  is an integer. Substitution proves both claims. The strict approach from below matters at an integer limit; the residue convention alone would assign a zero congruence class the value  $W_{\ell,h}$ , not zero.  $\square$

Thus a nonintegral  $BX_\ell$ , even for a rational  $S$ , gives arbitrarily long successful windows against any bound  $G(B,a) = o(8^a)$  for that fixed  $B$ . The rationality contradiction instead uses the denominator's specific multiplier and a start beyond its clearing onset. Success for one pair  $(B, \ell)$  does not replace either quantifier.

**The exact growth restriction on a dominating bound.** A bound need not be small at every late endpoint. For example, set

$$G(B,a) = \begin{cases} K(B,a), & a \text{ even}, \\ K(B,a) + 8^a, & a \text{ odd}. \end{cases}$$

At an odd endpoint  $a = \ell + h$ , no window with  $\ell \geq 1$  can pass: its residue is at most  $W_{\ell,h} = P_a/P_\ell \leq 8^a/2 < G(B,a)$ . At even endpoints the test is unchanged. If  $S$  is irrational, the proof above therefore supplies successful windows ending at every sufficiently large even index, from each fixed start. Thus  $G(B,a)/8^a \rightarrow 0$  is not necessary for the equivalence.

More precisely, for every integer-valued  $G \geq K$ ,

$$E(G) \iff \begin{cases} S \notin \mathbb{Q}, \\ \liminf_{a \rightarrow \infty} \frac{G(B,a)}{8^a} = 0 \text{ for every } B \geq 1 \text{ with } \gcd(B,30) = 1. \end{cases}$$

Suppose first that  $E(G)$  holds. The earlier rationality contradiction uses only  $G \geq K$ . For a successful window starting at  $\ell \geq a_0$ , put  $a = \ell + h$ . Since a least positive residue is at most its modulus,

$$0 \leq \frac{G(B,a)}{8^a} < \frac{P_a}{P_\ell 8^a} \leq \frac{1}{P_\ell} \leq \frac{1}{P_{a_0}}.$$

Such endpoints satisfy  $a > a_0$ , and  $P_{a_0} \rightarrow \infty$ ; hence the lower limit is zero. Conversely, suppose  $S$  is irrational and these lower limits vanish. Fix  $B$  and  $\ell \geq 1$ . By the fixed-start residue limit, with  $\delta = \lceil BX_\ell \rceil - BX_\ell > 0$ ,

$$\frac{\text{lpr}_{W_{\ell,h}}(-BF_{\ell,h})}{P_{\ell+h}} \rightarrow \frac{\delta}{P_\ell} > 0.$$

The bounds  $8^a/15 < P_a \leq 8^a$  imply  $\liminf_a G(B,a)/P_a = 0$ . Along a sufficiently late subsequence of endpoints the residue therefore exceeds  $G$ . This gives arbitrarily long successful windows from each fixed start, but need not give success at every sufficiently large length, as the parity example shows.

In particular,  $G(B,a) = K(B,a) + 8^a$  allows no window at all. More generally, an eventual lower bound  $G(B,a) \geq c8^a$ , for one eligible  $B$  and some  $c > 0$ , excludes every sufficiently late start: choose  $P_\ell \geq 1/c$  and compare the bound with  $W_{\ell,h} \leq 8^{\ell+h}/P_\ell$ .

These are restrictions on the test bound, not additional assumptions about the series. The original quadratic bounds satisfy the lower-limit condition, so the remaining problem is still the existence of the windows. Equivalence alone says nothing about the relative difficulty of the formulations; a useful arithmetic proof must exploit further information about the numerators  $m_a$ .

A fixed window can have a lower bound greater than 1. Write  $W$  and  $F$  for its product and accumulated numerator. Every prime factor of  $W$  lies in  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ , so an eligible multiplier  $B$  is a unit modulo  $W$ . Congruence then gives

$$\gcd(\text{lpr}_W(-BF), W) = \gcd(F, W).$$

For  $(W, F) = (6, 4)$ , the possible residues are 2 and 4, attained at  $B = 1$  and 11; thus 2 is a lower bound for this window, and the residues are not units. For  $(W, F) = (60, 47)$ , however,  $\text{lpr}_{60}(-37 \cdot 47) = 1$ , with 37 coprime to 30. Thus no lower bound greater than 1 works for all windows and eligible multipliers, although a particular window may have one.

### 10.1 How fast the window base grows

We can enlarge the class of admissible bounds by using the height formula in the converse argument. The elementary estimate  $W_{\ell,h} \geq 2^h$  allows  $G(B, a) = o(2^a)$  for each fixed  $B$ , whereas the height formula gives  $W_{\ell,h} \asymp 8^h$  uniformly in  $\ell$  and allows  $G(B, a) = o(8^a)$ . For an irrational  $S$ , the preceding lower-limit condition characterises all dominating bounds that suffice, including bounds outside these two classes.

**Proposition 10.4** (growth of the window product). *Put  $\theta_3 = \log_3 2$  and  $\theta_5 = \log_5 2$ . For all  $\ell \geq 0$  and  $h \geq 1$ ,*

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$$W_{\ell,h} = 2^h 3^{\lfloor (\ell+h)\theta_3 \rfloor - \lfloor \ell\theta_3 \rfloor} 5^{\lfloor (\ell+h)\theta_5 \rfloor - \lfloor \ell\theta_5 \rfloor}, \quad \frac{8^h}{15} < W_{\ell,h} < 15 \cdot 8^h.$$

*Proof.* Telescoping (14) gives  $W_{\ell,h} = P_{\ell+h}/P_\ell$ , and the displayed formula is that quotient written out. Each floor difference differs from  $h\theta_p$  by less than one, and  $3^{\theta_3} = 5^{\theta_5} = 2$ , so the 3-factor lies strictly between  $2^h/3$  and  $3 \cdot 2^h$  and the 5-factor strictly between  $2^h/5$  and  $5 \cdot 2^h$ . Multiplying the three ranges gives the bounds.  $\square$

**Corollary 10.5** (a fixed maximum length cannot cover arbitrarily late starts). *Fix  $B \geq 1$  coprime to 30 and  $H \geq 1$ . Only finitely many starts  $\ell$  admit an escaping window of length at most  $H$  against the bound  $K$ .*

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*Proof.* A least positive residue never exceeds its modulus, so escape at  $(\ell, h)$  requires  $K(B, \ell + h) < W_{\ell,h} < 15 \cdot 8^h \leq 15 \cdot 8^H$ . On the other hand  $j_a \geq a - 1$ , since the powers  $2, \dots, 2^{a-1}$  already lie below  $2^a$ , so  $K(B, \ell + h) \geq \lfloor B((\ell - 1)^2 + 10(\ell - 1) + 27)/9 \rfloor$ , which tends to infinity with  $\ell$ .  $\square$

Corollary 10.5 is the exact reason a finite scan cannot approach the cofinal quantifier by widening its denominator range alone. For  $\ell \geq 1$ , the inequality  $K(B, \ell + h) > B\ell^2/9$  shows that an escaping window must satisfy

$$3h > \log_2 K(B, \ell + h) - \log_2 15 > \log_2 B + 2 \log_2 \ell - \log_2 135.$$

This is only a necessary lower bound, not an asymptotic formula or an upper bound for the first successful length. An explicit eventual escape threshold can be obtained from a positive lower bound for  $\delta = \lceil BX_\ell \rceil - BX_\ell$  and for  $1 - \delta$ , together with the displayed tail and window estimates. No such uniform information about the tails of  $S$  is proved here.

## 11 Finite computations and their limits

The following windows illustrate the residue calculation with the actual shell coefficients. A twelve-shell enclosure then gives a lower bound on a possible rational denominator. We distinguish these finite arguments from the saved larger computations that follow. The [large-computation directory](#) contains the programs and saved outputs for the larger scan and the two larger denominator exclusions. These computations establish the stated finite cases. The criterion still requires every denominator and every starting threshold, which no finite scan supplies.

### 11.1 Checking individual windows

We calculate each row using the integer-only [dyadic-window checker](#). For shell  $a$ , enumerate the pairs with  $3^i 5^k < 2^{a+1}$ , choose the unique  $i \geq 0$  for which  $2^i 3^j 5^k \in [2^a, 2^{a+1})$ , and sum  $P_{a+1}/(2H(2^i 3^j 5^k))$ . The recursions for  $W$  and  $F$  then give the residue in each row. Powers and comparisons are integral throughout. The columns give the denominator  $B$ , the start  $\ell$ , the length  $h$ , the endpoint jump index  $j_{\ell+h}$ , the product  $W$  of the bases, the accumulated numerator  $F$ , the residue  $R = \text{lpr}_W(-BF)$  and the bound  $K$  of (18).

| $B$ | $\ell$ | $h$ | $j_{\ell+h}$ | $W$   | $F$  | $R$ | $K$ |
|-----|--------|-----|--------------|-------|------|-----|-----|
| 1   | 1      | 2   | 4            | 60    | 47   | 13  | 9   |
| 7   | 1      | 3   | 6            | 360   | 289  | 137 | 95  |
| 16  | 1      | 4   | 9            | 10800 | 8735 | 640 | 352 |

The first row reads as follows. The window starts at  $\ell = 1$  and has length 2, so  $W = b_1 b_2 = 6 \cdot 10 = 60$ ; the accumulated numerator is  $F = 47$ ; and  $\text{lpr}_{60}(-47) = 13$ , since  $-47 + 60 = 13$ , which exceeds  $K(1, 3) = \lfloor (16 + 40 + 27)/9 \rfloor = 9$ . The third row lies outside the domain of (20), since  $\gcd(16, 30) = 2$ , and is displayed to illustrate the window arithmetic at greater depth.

The larger scan covers  $B \leq 5000$  coprime to 30 and  $100 \leq \ell \leq 3000$ : all 3,869,934 pairs escape, with first escape length at most 18 in a search to length 24 ([saved run](#)). Its histogram in Section 13.4 is a finite observation that the window-growth bound does not predict. The accompanying integer-only check reconstructs the shells and tests all 2496 pairs with  $1 \leq B \leq 97$ ,  $\gcd(B, 30) = 1$  and  $1 \leq \ell \leq 96$ . Every pair escapes; the first successful lengths range from 1 to 10, with a search limit of 24. This check uses the enumeration and window recursions above, without floating-point logarithms. Neither computation proves escape for unbounded  $B$  or arbitrarily late starts; Corollary 10.5 rules out covering the latter quantifier with any fixed maximum length.

## 11.2 Finite denominator bounds

**A denominator bound from twelve shells.** We obtain a denominator bound by enclosing  $X_1 = S - 1$  between two rational numbers. Here  $h_1 = 1$ , and summation through shell 11, followed by the bound  $Q(n_{12}) = Q(24) = 262/3$  with  $P_{12} = 27993600000$ , gives

$$X_1 = 2 \sum_{a=1}^{11} \frac{m_a}{P_{a+1}} + \frac{2X_{12}}{P_{12}},$$

$$\frac{11327881097}{13996800000} < X_1 \leq \frac{33983643553}{41990400000}.$$

The enclosure is strictly inside the interval  $(11498/14207, 6409/7919)$ , as integer cross-multiplication verifies. The endpoint determinant is  $14207 \cdot 6409 - 11498 \cdot 7919 = 1$ . For any rational  $u/v$  strictly between them, with  $v > 0$ , both integers  $14207u - 11498v$  and  $6409v - 7919u$  are positive. Consequently

$$v = 7919(14207u - 11498v) + 14207(6409v - 7919u) \geq 22126.$$

Thus, if  $S$  is rational, its reduced denominator is at least 22126. This is the elementary denominator bound between two fractions with cross-determinant one, often expressed using Farey neighbours. It is also the best lower bound on a possible denominator obtainable from this enclosure alone: the mediant

$$\frac{11498 + 6409}{14207 + 7919} = \frac{17907}{22126}$$

is in lowest terms and lies strictly inside the certified enclosure. Thus the interval alone remains compatible with denominator 22126; we have neither identified  $X_1$  with this mediant nor determined a denominator for  $S$ .

The certificate uses the actual shell coefficients and proved tail bound. A narrower certified enclosure excludes further denominators; the continued-fraction exclusion below uses one built from 15,500 shells.

**Window-128 lattice exclusion.** A finite lattice computation, outside the theorem inputs, excludes the following denominators. Using windows of length 128 and 64 starting indices, the first 10005, no rational value of the  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  running-LCM series has reduced denominator  $MB$  with  $M$  a divisor supported on  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  of  $2^{10005}3^{6312}5^{4308}$ ,  $\gcd(B, 30) = 1$  and  $1 < B \leq B_{\max}$ , where  $B_{\max}$  is the 106-digit integer

$$B_{\max} = 1134599670999687767349520845707093359257353022286558739363600235$$

$$016103207564063373270305324172145281971729,$$

so that  $\log_2 B_{\max} = 348.9846 \dots$

The exponent triple  $(10005, 6312, 4308)$  is that of  $H(2^{10005})$ . The normalisation therefore uses the full height at its first start, whereas Lemma 9.2 uses the half height  $h_{10005}$ . This family of smooth denominators is the larger one.

The [certificate](#) and its exact [checker](#) are published. Its starts  $a_1 < \dots < a_{64}$  are the first  $a \geq 10005$  with  $W_{a,128} = W_{10005,128} = W = 2^{128}3^{81}5^{56}$ , so  $\log_2 W = 386.40993 \dots$ ;

put  $m_0 = W/2$ ,  $F_j = F_{a_j,128}$  and  $w_j = (a_j + 128)^2 + 6(a_j + 128) + 11$ . The certificate lists an integer matrix  $C = (c_{ij})$  with  $\sum_j c_{ij}F_j \equiv 0 \pmod{m_0}$  and  $\sum_j |c_{ij}|w_j \leq 184,560,461,211$  for every row  $i$ , an integer matrix  $E$  with  $CE = EC = m_0I$ , and  $B_{\max} = \lfloor (W - 1)/184,560,461,211 \rfloor$ . If  $B \leq B_{\max}$  and integers  $f_j = Ws_j - 2BF_j$  satisfy  $0 < f_j \leq Bw_j$ , each  $\sum_j c_{ij}f_j$  is a multiple of  $W$  of absolute value less than  $W$ , hence zero, and invertibility of  $C$  forces every  $f_j$  to vanish, a contradiction. The weights bound the tails: since  $n_b \leq 2.07b$ , Theorem 9.1 gives  $2X_b \leq 2Q(n_b) \leq b^2 + 6b + 11$  for every  $b \geq 0$ . The reduction from a rational value  $N/(MB)$  to the 64 window inequalities, with  $s_j = 2BX_{a_j}$  and  $f_j = 2BX_{a_j+128}$ , uses the window identity at full height and is not machine-checked.

**Continued-fraction exclusion.** A finite computation, outside the theorem inputs, shows that neither  $X_1$  nor  $S$  is a fraction with reduced denominator at most  $2^{22482}$ , about  $10^{6768}$ . Let  $W$  and  $F$  be the window base and accumulated numerator of shells 1 to 15,500. The tail bound used for the twelve-shell certificate, at  $Q(n_{15501}) = Q(31956) = 340480534/3$ , gives  $F/W < X_1 \leq (F + Q)/W$ . Every shell is built with integers, and shells 1 to 30 are also checked against a direct enumeration of the smooth numbers. The two endpoints share their first 13,540 partial quotients, and the numbers with a given prefix of partial quotients form an interval [24, Lemma 10.1.2, p. 106]. The first 13,109 digits,  $a_0 = 0$  included, define a cylinder whose endpoints have cross-determinant 1 and strictly contain the enclosure, so every fraction in the enclosure has denominator at least the sum of the two endpoint denominators, a 22,483-bit integer. The [enclosure](#), the [common digits](#), the [regeneration program](#) and the exact [checker](#) are published. A separate continued-fraction probe ([saved run](#)) certifies 13,109 partial quotients after  $a_0$  and records a largest denominator of 22,483 bits, a largest partial quotient of 129,114, a mean partial quotient of 23.4133, observed Gauss–Kuzmin frequencies 0.4208, 0.1665, 0.0917, 0.0575, 0.0391 against the predicted 0.4150, 0.1699, 0.0931, 0.0589, 0.0406, and a Lévy constant of 1.18869 against  $\pi^2/(12 \log 2) = 1.18657$ . The predicted values are the almost-everywhere frequencies of Gauss’s law and Lévy’s almost-everywhere constant [23, pp. 288–289 and footnote 5]. These statistics describe a finite prefix and do not bear on whether  $X_1$  is a Liouville number, algebraic, or rational with a larger denominator.

The two exclusions concern different finite families: one uses a lattice at a fixed starting index and fixed smooth part, the other a continued-fraction enclosure at  $a = 1$ . Both have published witnesses and exact checkers. Each excludes only its stated denominator range, and neither settles an instance of the problem.

## 12 The remaining arithmetic questions

The residue criterion leaves an existence question for the actual coefficients. We examine the weighted shifts and carry arguments that might address it, retaining the boundary terms that prevent the proposed finite-difference cancellation. We also state the missing input for a function-theoretic approach. The irrationality of  $S$  remains open here.

## 12.1 An exact weighted-shift identity for the repeated series

Set  $\alpha = S/2$  and retain the boundary heights  $P_a$ . We combine shifted tails after subtracting their finite rational corrections. Since the denominators change under a shift, the resulting identity has weights as well as shifted numerators. It concerns the repeated sum  $S$  only. In this subsection and the next,  $r$  is a positive integer shift; the prime-generator notation is no longer in use.

**Lemma 12.1** (weighted shifts preserve the actual value). *Fix integers  $c_0, \dots, c_\sigma$ , not all zero, independently of the positive integer shift  $r$ . Put*

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$$\gamma_{a,t} = \frac{P_t P_{a+1}}{P_{a+t+1}}, \quad D_{r,a} = 15 \sum_{j=0}^{\sigma} c_j \gamma_{a,jr} m_{a+jr}.$$

Then  $\gamma_{a,t} \in \{1, 1/3, 1/5, 1/15\}$  and  $D_{r,a} \in \mathbb{Z}$ . Furthermore, with

$$A_r = 15 \sum_{j=0}^{\sigma} c_j P_{jr}, \quad Z_r = 15 \sum_{j=0}^{\sigma} c_j P_{jr} \sum_{k < jr} \frac{m_k}{P_{k+1}} \in \mathbb{Z},$$

we have the absolutely convergent identity

$$A_r \alpha - Z_r = \sum_{a \geq 0} \frac{D_{r,a}}{P_{a+1}}. \quad (21)$$

One may take  $C = 225 \sum_{j=0}^{\sigma} |c_j| \max(1, j)^2$  in  $|D_{r,a}| \leq C(a + r + 1)^2$ . If  $J$  is the largest index with  $c_J \neq 0$ , then  $A_r \neq 0$  whenever  $\sum_{j < J} |c_j| 2^{-(J-j)r} < |c_J|$ ; an empty sum is zero.

*Proof.* The exponent of 2 in  $\gamma_{a,t}$  is  $t + (a + 1) - (a + t + 1) = 0$ . For  $p = 3, 5$ , the exponent is  $\lfloor t\theta_p \rfloor + \lfloor (a + 1)\theta_p \rfloor - \lfloor (a + t + 1)\theta_p \rfloor$ , which is 0 or  $-1$  by floor addition. Thus the only possible denominator factors are one 3 and one 5; the prefactor 15 in  $D_{r,a}$  clears both. For  $k < jr$ ,  $P_{k+1}$  divides  $P_{jr}$ , so  $Z_r$  is an integer. For each  $t$ , absolute convergence gives

$$\sum_{a \geq 0} \frac{\gamma_{a,t} m_{a+t}}{P_{a+1}} = P_t \sum_{k \geq t} \frac{m_k}{P_{k+1}} = P_t \left( \alpha - \sum_{k < t} \frac{m_k}{P_{k+1}} \right).$$

The finite linear combination proves the identity. Lemma 8.3,  $0 < \gamma \leq 1$  and  $a + jr + 1 \leq \max(1, j)(a + r + 1)$  give the stated constant. For  $j < J$ ,  $P_{jr}/P_{jr} \leq 2^{-(J-j)r}$ . Dividing  $A_r$  by  $15P_{jr}$  and bounding the remaining terms proves the nonvanishing condition, which holds for all sufficiently large  $r$ .  $\square$

For any fixed nonzero coefficient vector, including  $(1, -3, 3, -1)$ , the nonvanishing condition is automatic for sufficiently large  $r$ : each term on its left tends to zero. No arithmetic assumption on  $S$  is needed. The identity still represents  $S/2$ , but gives no sparsity or cancellation of  $D_{r,a}$ .

## 12.2 Boundary terms in weighted finite differences

A finite difference of weighted triangle counts has contributions from both the common interior and the newly added strips. With coefficients  $(1, -3, 3, -1)$ , an interior point of unchanged weight cancels. A point entering in the last three, last two or last triangle has coefficient  $-1, 2$  or  $-1$ . We separate these strip contributions from changes of weight at floor crossings. Absence of a floor crossing alone will not force the whole difference to vanish.

Recall that  $w_{j,k} = j \log_2 3 + k \log_2 5$ ,  $t_{j,k} = \{w_{j,k}\}$  and  $\theta_p = 1/\log_2 p$  for  $p = 3, 5$ . To distinguish the shared points from the new ones, let  $\mathcal{T}_a = \{(j, k) \in \mathbb{N}^2 : w_{j,k} < a + 1\}$  and, for  $0 \leq t < 1$ , set

$$\omega_a(t) = \prod_{p \in \{3, 5\}} p^{\lfloor (a+1)\theta_p \rfloor - \lfloor (a+t)\theta_p \rfloor}.$$

This weight is defined even for pairs outside  $\mathcal{T}_a$ . For  $v \geq 0$ , put

$$\begin{aligned} \kappa_p(a, t, vr) &= \lfloor (a + t + vr)\theta_p \rfloor - \lfloor (a + t)\theta_p \rfloor - \lfloor vr\theta_p \rfloor, \\ \chi_v(a, t) &= 3^{-\kappa_3(a, t, vr)} 5^{-\kappa_5(a, t, vr)}. \end{aligned}$$

Each  $\kappa_p$  is 0 or 1. A value  $\kappa_p = 1$  records a floor-addition carry. This is different from a new lattice point entering  $\mathcal{T}_a$  as  $a$  increases.

**Proposition 12.2** (an exact interior-and-strip decomposition). *For a fixed operator  $c_0, \dots, c_\sigma$  and  $r \geq 1$ , let  $E_0 = \mathcal{T}_a$  and  $E_s = \mathcal{T}_{a+sr} \setminus \mathcal{T}_{a+(s-1)r}$  for  $1 \leq s \leq \sigma$ . Then*

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$$\frac{D_{r,a}}{15} = \sum_{s=0}^{\sigma} \sum_{(j,k) \in E_s} \omega_a(t_{j,k}) \sum_{v=s}^{\sigma} c_v \chi_v(a, t_{j,k}).$$

For the cubic operator  $(1, -3, 3, -1)$ , if all these crossing bits vanish, then

$$\frac{D_{r,a}}{15} = -M_0 + 2M_1 - M_2, \quad M_s = \sum_{(j,k) \in \mathcal{T}_{a+(s+1)r} \setminus \mathcal{T}_{a+sr}} \omega_a(t_{j,k}).$$

Thus absence of floor crossings cancels the common interior, but not necessarily the three boundary strips.

*Proof.* For each  $p = 3, 5$ , the exponent of  $p$  on either side of

$$\gamma_{a,vr} \omega_{a+vr}(t) = \omega_a(t) \chi_v(a, t)$$

is

$$\lfloor (a+1)\theta_p \rfloor + \lfloor vr\theta_p \rfloor - \lfloor (a+t+vr)\theta_p \rfloor.$$

On the left the upper-boundary exponents cancel; on the right the  $\lfloor (a+t)\theta_p \rfloor$  terms cancel. This proves the pointwise identity. Insert the triangle formula for each  $m_{a+vr}$  and group by the first triangle containing a pair. A pair in  $E_s$  occurs exactly in the terms  $v \geq s$ , proving the first formula. Under the no-crossing hypothesis,  $\chi_v = 1$ . The full cubic sum is zero, while its three successive suffix sums are  $-1, 2, -1$ , proving the second formula.  $\square$

**Example 12.3** (cubic cancellation can fail with no floor crossings). Take  $a = 0$ ,  $r = 35$  and  $(c_0, c_1, c_2, c_3) = (1, -3, 3, -1)$ . Exact integer comparisons give

| $u$                                                           | 0 | 35  | 70  | 105  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|---|-----|-----|------|
| $\lfloor \log_3 2^u \rfloor = \lfloor \log_3 2^{u+1} \rfloor$ | 0 | 22  | 44  | 66   |
| $\lfloor \log_5 2^u \rfloor = \lfloor \log_5 2^{u+1} \rfloor$ | 0 | 15  | 30  | 45   |
| $m_u$                                                         | 1 | 195 | 723 | 1582 |

The first two rows imply  $b_u = 2$  and  $\lfloor (u+t)\theta_p \rfloor = \lfloor u\theta_p \rfloor$  for every  $0 \leq t < 1$ ,  $p = 3, 5$ . Hence every relevant  $\kappa_p(0, t, u)$  vanishes,  $\gamma_{0,u} = 1$ , and all triangle weights at these four indices are 1. The last row is therefore the count of pairs satisfying  $3^j 5^k < 2^{u+1}$ , not a floating-point estimate. The strips have sizes 194, 528, 859, so

$$D_{35,0} = 15(-194 + 2 \cdot 528 - 859) = 45 \neq 0.$$

Exact enumeration reproduces all four counts and checks the endpoint power inequalities using integers. This example disproves the claim that avoiding floor crossings alone forces the third difference to vanish. It does not exclude a different fixed operator, different shifts, a boundary correction or a sparse-defect statement restricted to a suitable infinite subsequence.

**What the Hecke–Mahler comparison does and does not supply.** In the published Luca–Ouaknine–Worrell article [26, Definition 5 and Theorem 6], the same fixed integer coefficients are applied to shifts of one integer sequence. The resulting nonzero terms must have expanding gaps and uniform polynomial variation; the original sequence must also have polynomial growth. Theorem 6 then gives a fixed-base value criterion. Theorem 8 verifies that condition for  $f(\lfloor m\vartheta + \rho \rfloor)$  when  $f \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$  is nonconstant,  $\vartheta, \rho \in (0, 1)$  and  $\vartheta$  is irrational. These interval restrictions belong to that normalised combinatorial statement. Their main value theorem, Theorem 1, allows every real  $\rho$  and every irrational real  $\vartheta$ , with any algebraic base  $\beta$  satisfying  $|\beta| > 1$ . Claim 10 uses a finite difference of order  $\deg f + 1$ , which vanishes when no floor crossing occurs. This is a polynomial evaluated at a floor, not merely an integer sequence of polynomial growth. Our  $m_a$  is instead a weighted lattice count. Proposition 12.2 separates floor crossings from its moving boundary, and Example 12.3 shows that the latter can survive a cubic difference even with no crossings.

There is a second distinction. In our displayed shift identity the coefficient of  $m_{a+jr}$  is  $15c_j\gamma_{a,jr}$ , which can depend on  $a$ . For example,  $P_1 = 2$ ,  $P_2 = 12$  and  $P_3 = 120$  give  $\gamma_{0,1} = 1/3$  but  $\gamma_{1,1} = 1/5$ . These factors are required by the denominator chain. A support estimate for  $D_{r,a}$  is therefore not by itself a verification of Definition 5 for the sequence  $(m_a)$ . No fixed-coefficient representation to which that theorem applies has been established here.

For a variable-denominator analogue, a useful hypothesis would be a fixed choice of coefficients and shifts  $r_n \rightarrow \infty$  for which  $\Delta_n = \{a \geq 0 : D_{r_n,a} \neq 0\}$  is infinite and distinct members are at least  $\eta r_n$  apart, for a fixed  $\eta > 0$ . Even this would leave the uniform polynomial-variation requirement, for example

$$|D_{r_n,a'}| \leq C((a' - a)^d + |D_{r_n,a}|) \quad (a < a', a, a' \in \Delta_n),$$

with  $C, d$  independent of  $n, a$  and  $a'$ . This is a condition on the gaps between nonzero terms, not merely on their density: even a set of density zero can contain adjacent pairs. It also requires infinitely many nonzero terms for each selected shift. A small but nonzero term at every index would fail it, and an identically zero difference would also fail the infinitude requirement. The cited paper constructs suitable shifts for the polynomial-floor sequences just described; no such result is proved for our weighted counts. The bound  $O((a + r + 1)^2)$  controls absolute size: it depends on the location  $a$  itself. The variation condition instead bounds a later nonzero term by the gap from an earlier one and the size of that earlier term, with constants uniform in the shift. The absolute-size bound alone gives no such comparison. The denominator chain itself is not a fixed-base power sequence. The next proposition shows what is lost in two direct fixed-base recodings. A value criterion for the original chain would need a separate proof, including non-cancellation and the height estimates in any Subspace-Theorem argument. Here height means Diophantine height, which controls the numerators and denominators of the approximating algebraic quantities, not the running-LCM height  $H$ . The finite set of prime divisors alone does not provide those estimates.

**Why a finite alphabet of bases is not enough.** Kebis, Luca, Ouaknine, Scoones and Worrell [27, Definition 3, Theorem 6 and Claim 7] work with fixed-base series whose coefficients lie in a finite algebraic alphabet. Their echoing condition requires long near-repetitions, separated intervals containing the mismatches, and nonzero weighted mismatch sums on at least two of those intervals. Claim 7 supplies the non-cancellation step in the proof of the value theorem. Merely having finitely many letters does not give these properties. The four-letter radix sequence is not the numerator sequence: the actual  $m_a$  is unbounded. A recoding would have to preserve the scalar value, identify its coefficient alphabet and verify the echoing conditions. No fixed-base recoding with verified echoing properties is proved here.

Two natural bases expose the tradeoff. The least integer base whose powers clear every  $P_n$  is 30, while base 8 matches the growth of  $P_n = H(2^n)$ . The former keeps integrality; the latter keeps polynomial size.

**Proposition 12.4** (what direct fixed-base recoding preserves). *The following identities converge absolutely:*

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$$\alpha = \sum_{a \geq 0} \frac{e_a}{30^{a+1}} = \sum_{a \geq 0} \frac{v_a}{8^{a+1}}, \quad e_a = \frac{m_a 30^{a+1}}{P_{a+1}}, \quad v_a = \frac{m_a 8^{a+1}}{P_{a+1}}.$$

Here  $e_a \in \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$  and  $e_a \geq (15/4)^{a+1}$ , whereas  $v_a \in \mathbb{Z}[1/15]$  and  $0 < v_a < 225(a+1)^2$ . For an integer  $q \geq 2$ , the termwise divisibility  $P_n \mid q^n$  for every  $n \geq 1$  holds exactly when  $30 \mid q$ ; that direct recoding then has coefficients at least  $(q/8)^{a+1}$ .

*Proof.* Each exponent in  $P_n$  is at most  $n$ , so  $P_n \mid 30^n$ . The estimate  $8^n/15 < P_n \leq 8^n$  was proved in Section 8. These facts,  $m_a \geq 1$  and  $m_a \leq 15(a+1)^2$ , give all the coefficient bounds and identities. Necessity of  $30 \mid q$  follows because each of 2, 3, 5 divides some  $P_n$ ; sufficiency follows from  $P_n \mid 30^n$ . The general lower bound follows again from  $P_n \leq 8^n$ .  $\square$

The base-30 coefficients are integral but grow exponentially, so the cited polynomial-growth criterion does not apply. The base-8 coefficients have polynomial size but are not all integral: already  $v_1 = 4 \cdot 8^2/12 = 64/3$ . In fact, their reduced denominators grow exponentially even after cancellation. Since  $P_{a+1}/2^{a+1}$  is odd, the expression

$$v_a = \frac{m_a 4^{a+1}}{P_{a+1}/2^{a+1}}$$

can cancel an odd factor only through  $m_a$ . Consequently,

$$\text{den}(v_a) \geq \frac{P_{a+1}}{2^{a+1}m_a} > \frac{4^{a+1}}{225(a+1)^2}.$$

The last inequality uses  $P_{a+1} > 8^{a+1}/15$  and  $m_a \leq 15(a+1)^2$ . Thus the bound on absolute value does not control Diophantine height even for these particular coefficients; fixed denominator-prime support is not enough.

More generally, no fixed integer base gives this termwise recoding both eventually integral coefficients and polynomial growth. If  $30 \mid q$ , the proposition gives exponential growth. Otherwise choose  $p \in \{2, 3, 5\}$  not dividing  $q$ . Cancellation by  $m_a$  removes at most a factor  $m_a$ , so

$$\text{den}\left(\frac{m_a q^{a+1}}{P_{a+1}}\right) \geq \frac{p^{\lfloor (a+1) \log_p 2 \rfloor}}{m_a} > \frac{2^{a+1}}{15p(a+1)^2}.$$

This denominator tends to infinity. The argument concerns only the displayed termwise rescaling, not regrouping or carrying.

Carrying can in fact make the coefficients into digits, while leaving the radices variable. To see exactly what changes, set

$$\delta_a = m_a + \lfloor X_{a+1} \rfloor - b_a \lfloor X_a \rfloor = \lfloor b_a \{X_a\} \rfloor.$$

The equality follows from the tail recurrence and  $m_a \in \mathbb{Z}$ . Thus  $0 \leq \delta_a < b_a$  and  $\{X_a\} = (\delta_a + \{X_{a+1}\})/b_a$ . Iterating gives the finite identity

$$\{X_0\} = \sum_{a=0}^{N-1} \frac{\delta_a}{P_{a+1}} + \frac{\{X_N\}}{P_N}.$$

The last term is nonnegative, is less than  $1/P_N \leq 2^{-N}$ , and tends to zero. This is the greedy mixed-radix expansion of the fractional part of  $X_0 = S/2$ , with digits in  $\{0, \dots, 29\}$ . For the actual series its first eight digits are

$$(\delta_0, \dots, \delta_7) = (1, 4, 8, 3, 10, 1, 8, 5).$$

To certify them, use the twelve-shell enclosure from Section 11, either propagated by the recurrence or evaluated directly as

$$P_a \sum_{j=a}^{11} \frac{m_j}{P_{j+1}} < X_a \leq P_a \sum_{j=a}^{11} \frac{m_j}{P_{j+1}} + \frac{P_a}{P_{12}} Q(n_{12}) \quad (0 \leq a < 12).$$

Both descriptions give the same rational endpoints. At indices 0 through 8 the whole interval lies strictly between consecutive integers, which certifies the floor; a small interval width alone would not suffice if the interval crossed an integer. For example,  $\lfloor X_4 \rfloor = 2$  and  $\lfloor X_5 \rfloor = 5$ , giving  $\delta_4 = 65 + 5 - 30 \cdot 2 = 10$ , not the uncarried numerator  $m_4 = 65$ . This finite calculation makes no claim about the later digit complexity.

A rational number need not have eventually periodic digits when the radices vary. For example, take radix 5 at the indices 1, 2, 4, 8, ... and radix 3 elsewhere. The constant tail fraction  $1/2$  gives digit 2 at those indices and 1 elsewhere. These digits are not eventually periodic, but their mixed-radix expansion sums to  $1/2$ . This example uses different radices from our four possible bases; it shows why fixed-base eventual periodicity cannot be transferred to a variable-radix expansion. Our digits also depend on the actual tail fractions, not just on the four-letter radix sequence. The construction supplies neither a fixed-base expansion with verified echoing properties nor a bound on its digit complexity.

Adamczewski–Bugeaud’s complexity theorem [30, Theorem 1] concerns the actual digits of an integer-base expansion: for an algebraic irrational their length- $n$  block complexity divided by  $n$  tends to infinity. Neither  $(b_a)$  nor the uncarried  $(e_a)$  is such a digit expansion of  $\alpha$ .

**Problem 12.5** (the repeated three-prime target). Prove irrationality of  $S = \mathcal{R}_{\{2,3,5\}}$ . Equivalent forms are  $E(K)$  and

$$BX_a \notin \mathbb{Z} \quad \text{for every } B \geq 1 \text{ with } \gcd(B, 30) = 1 \text{ and every } a \geq 1. \quad (22)$$

The residue formulation uses finite integer computations, but asks for a success for every eligible denominator and beyond every prescribed start. The tail formulation requires that no positive integer multiplier coprime to 30 make any  $X_a$ ,  $a \geq 1$ , integral. These are reformulations of the same irrationality assertion, not extra assumptions on the series, and neither follows from the rank obstruction. The next proposition proves the tail reformulation, complementing Theorem 10.2.

**Proposition 12.6** (irrationality is equivalent to nonintegrality of every reduced tail). *Statement (22), quantified over every  $B \geq 1$  coprime to 30 and every  $a \geq 1$ , is equivalent to irrationality of  $S$ .*

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*Proof.* If  $BX_a \in \mathbb{Z}$  for some such  $B$  and  $a$ , then  $X_a \in \mathbb{Q}$ , and since  $S = \sum_{j < a} s_j + X_a/h_a$  with  $h_a$  a positive rational and the prefix a finite sum of rationals,  $S \in \mathbb{Q}$ . Conversely if  $S \in \mathbb{Q}$ , then Theorem 9.3 produces  $B$  coprime to 30 with  $BX_a \in \mathbb{Z}$  for every  $a \geq a_D$ .  $\square$

Integrality at one index propagates forwards, but nonintegrality at one early index does not propagate forever: a rational denominator can clear later. Proposition 9.4 describes that onset exactly. The dichotomy in Proposition 8.4 also permits integral tails, so it does not settle this question.

### 12.3 Function-theoretic representations

The elementary proof of irrationality of  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$  gives no transcendence conclusion. Recall that

$$\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}} = 1 + \sum_{t \in \{2^n, 3^n, 5^n; n \geq 1\}} \frac{1}{2^{\lfloor \log_2 t \rfloor} 3^{\lfloor \log_3 t \rfloor} 5^{\lfloor \log_5 t \rfloor}}.$$

Each height is counted once at its first jump, unlike the repeated sum. The bases in (14) come from these same jumps. For two primes a representation by one Hecke–Mahler value proves transcendence (Section 4). A corresponding three-prime representation has not been constructed here.

**Problem 12.7** (an exact function representing the distinct-height sum). Transcendence of  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$  is not proved here. For a functional approach to it, first specify the function, its coefficient field and convergence domain, then prove an exact identity for  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$ , and only then apply a stated value theorem. A conditional theorem must display the extra nondegeneracy assumption; a no-representation theorem must specify the class it excludes.

For  $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$ , the two slopes in the rank proof are  $\log_5 2 = \theta_5$  and  $\log_5 3 = \theta_5/\theta_3$ , not  $\theta_3$  and  $\theta_5$ . Each is irrational: a rational value would equate a positive power of 5 with a positive power of 2 or 3. The proof chooses the row and column indices independently. It therefore needs no rational independence of  $1, \theta_3, \theta_5$  and no density assertion for the singly indexed orbit  $(\{n\theta_3\}, \{n\theta_5\})$ . Any functional approach that needs such a stronger hypothesis must establish it separately.

A finite-dimensional encoding must preserve equality of the functions it is meant to represent. If two encodings agree but their functions do not, the encoding cannot justify a conclusion about those functions. The Lean sources express this condition as a factorisation through a finite-dimensional space and prove that the resulting space of functions is then finite-dimensional ([identity for the carry, map to functions, finite-dimensional conclusion](#)). They also bound the carry residue and its digit in their stated intervals ([residue bound, digit bound](#)). These conditional linear-algebra statements neither construct a function representing  $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$  nor show that a corresponding function space must be infinite-dimensional.

**The cited value theorems and their hypotheses.** Pellarin’s rank-one theorem concerns quadratic irrational slopes and algebraic evaluation points in the convergence domain [31, Theorem 1.1 and Remark 1.2, pp. 330–332]. The prime-logarithm slopes used here are not quadratic: each  $\log_r p$  is irrational by unique factorisation, and the Gelfond–Schneider theorem then makes it transcendental, since  $r^{\log_r p} = p$  is algebraic.<sup>1</sup> This rules out direct substitution of those slopes into Pellarin’s quadratic-slope theorem. It does not rule out a different representation of the scalar sum, and it does not affect the two-prime argument above, which uses a theorem for general irrational slopes.

<sup>1</sup>For this logarithmic form of the Gelfond–Schneider theorem, see Keith Conrad, *Transcendence of  $e$* , p. 1, footnote 1, <https://kconrad.math.uconn.edu/blurbs/analysis/transcendence-e.pdf> (accessed 18 September 2026).

In Pellarin’s reduced-slope normalisation, the rank-one condition says that the evaluation points arise from a common point by the quadratic order’s monomial action, up to multiplication by torsion points. For a single evaluation point it is automatic: use that point itself and the identity action. For several points it is a condition to check, not a consequence of having two lattice coordinates. Under it, algebraic independence of the values is equivalent to  $\mathbb{Q}$ -linear independence of the specified auxiliary formal Laurent series; the rank-one condition alone does not imply independence. This module rank is not the rank of our reciprocal kernel. No exact representation suitable for this theorem has been constructed here, but infinite kernel rank alone does not preclude one.

For one variable, Adamczewski and Faverjon’s proofs of Nishioka’s theorem and the lifting theorem are regular-point results [32, Theorems 1 and 2]. Regularity means that the system matrix stays defined and invertible along the evaluation orbit. Their multivariate lifting theorem [33, Theorem 3.3] additionally assumes an admissible transformation–point pair. Its growth, decay and nonvanishing conditions are specified in Definition 5.1; none follows merely from writing a double sum. Lifting transfers a relation among values to one among functions; a transcendence application must exclude the latter. A Mahler system alone cannot do this, as the constant function 1 illustrates.

Regularity of a preselected system is not, however, a universal prerequisite for Mahler’s method. The same paper’s Theorem 1.1 treats univariate Mahler functions at algebraic points in the punctured unit disc where their values are defined, without that regularity hypothesis. The hypotheses must therefore be matched to the particular theorem being invoked. No exact Mahler representation or suitable evaluation data for this distinct-height sum are constructed here. The locators for this paper refer to its 68-page author manuscript, not the older 52-page arXiv version.

## 12.4 Hypotheses for auxiliary carry arguments

For ordered primes  $p_1 < \dots < p_s$ , the interval  $(p_1^a, p_1^{a+1})$  contains at most one power of each  $p_i > p_1$ . The radix including the final  $p_1$ -jump consequently belongs to

$$\left\{ p_1 \prod_{i=2}^s p_i^{\varepsilon_i} : \varepsilon_i \in \{0, 1\} \right\}.$$

This finite alphabet determines neither the frequency of the radices nor the error terms in the weighted shell counts. Estimates for those quantities, or for specified shifted kernels, would be additional arithmetic inputs. The conditional carry statements below keep such inputs explicit.

Some auxiliary results explain why bounded integer approximations alone are insufficient. Here are their hypotheses in explicit form.

Let  $j(n) \in \{2, 3, 5\}$  label a sequence of jumps, and suppose each label occurs. A perturbation  $\varepsilon_n$  in an additive abelian group has sum zero on every interval  $[a, b)$  whose endpoints have the same label exactly when

$$\varepsilon_n = u(j(n+1)) - u(j(n))$$

for three potential values  $u(2), u(3), u(5)$ . One direction follows by telescoping. Conversely, the zero-sum assumption makes  $\sum_{k < n} \varepsilon_k$  the same at any two indices with the

same label. Assign that common value to  $u(j(n))$ ; every label occurs, so all three values are defined. Consecutive partial sums then give the displayed identity. In the usual terminology, the perturbation is a coboundary of the function  $u$  on the labels: it is the difference of successive potential values. This is a telescoping condition, not a bound on the size of the perturbation. It does not by itself force the perturbation to vanish: unequal potential values give nonzero differences when the label changes. If the perturbation also vanishes on a genuine  $2 \rightarrow 3$  transition and on a genuine  $2 \rightarrow 5$  transition, all three potential values agree, so every perturbation is zero.

For an integer carry satisfying  $c_{n+1} = b_n c_n - D m_n$ , compare it with an integer sequence  $z_n$ . Define the error  $e_n = D z_n - c_n$  and the perturbation  $\varepsilon_n = b_n z_n - z_{n+1} - m_n$ . Then

$$e_{n+1} = b_n e_n - D \varepsilon_n.$$

Under the preceding zero-sum and transition hypotheses,  $\varepsilon_n = 0$  and hence  $e_N = (\prod_{n < N} b_n) e_0$ . If every  $b_n \geq 2$  and the integer  $e_0$  is nonzero, then  $|e_N| \geq 2^N$ . This contradicts even one bound  $|e_N| < 2^N$ , and therefore also excludes a uniform bound for all  $N$ . The nonzero initial error is essential: the identically zero error causes no contradiction.

A calculation on four states gives a related obstruction. If  $0 < T_i < 1$ ,  $z_i \in \mathbb{Z}$  and  $|z_i - T_i| < 1$ , then  $z_i$  is 0 or 1. For bases 2, 3, 2, 5, the equalities  $2z_0 - z_1 - 1 = 0$  and  $2z_2 - z_3 - 1 = 0$  force all four integers to be 1. The sum of the first two perturbations is then

$$(2z_0 - z_1 - 1) + (3z_1 - z_2 - 1) = 1,$$

not zero. Thus unit accuracy, the two exact equalities and a zero sum on that block cannot all hold. Unit accuracy alone does not give either exact equality.

No integer approximation to the tails of  $S$  is constructed here that satisfies all these conditions. Rationality supplies integer carries of at most quadratic growth, but not the additional zero-sum and transition identities. The carries obtained from  $S$  satisfy a weighted block identity instead. Applying the auxiliary results would require that identity to imply their hypotheses, or would require a different construction of the integer approximations.

There is also a conditional criterion for a sum supported on the powers of 2. Its elementary ingredients can be stated without introducing another formal vocabulary. From  $y' = by - 1$  with  $b > 0$  and  $0 < y' < 1$  one gets  $1/b < y < 2/b$ . For integers  $a > 0$  and  $p \geq 3$ , if  $u > 1/a$  and  $v < 2/(pa)$ , then  $u - v > 1/(3a)$ . Finally, a real number  $x$  is irrational if, for every positive integer  $d$ , there are integers  $n, k$  with  $0 < |nx - k| < 1/d$ .

To use these observations for a series, the conditional result requires exact identities  $y_M = H_M x - z_M$ , with  $H_M, z_M \in \mathbb{Z}$ , and, for every positive  $d$ , two indices with different  $H_M$ , different  $y_M$ , and  $|y_M - y_{M'}| < 1/d$ . Their difference gives the required nonzero linear form. Equal states would give zero and would not suffice; a merely bounded gap would not suffice either. Indeed, for a rational  $x$  of denominator  $d$ , every nonzero difference of this form has size at least  $1/d$ . No concrete series in this record is shown to satisfy all these clearing and arbitrarily small nonzero-gap conditions.

## 12.5 The unresolved repeated-sum question

Theorem 1.1 settles the distinct-height sum for  $\{2, 3, 5\}$ . The ordinary arguments in Remarks 5.1 and 5.10 treat all finite prime supports and the prime-power subseries, respectively, pending formalisation. Remark 5.8 records the finite-state calculations; the collision in the admissible automaton language for  $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$  limits that decoder only. For  $\mathcal{R}_{\{2,3,5\}}$  we have the exact coefficients and recurrence, quadratic tail bounds and denominator-clearing formula. The remaining question is whether all eventual integral reduced tails can be excluded. Equivalently, the required residue windows must exist for every admissible  $B$  beyond every prescribed starting index. The fixed-start formula explains the necessity of these quantifiers, and the strip identity shows why a no-crossing argument alone does not prove the required cancellation.

The rank and uniform-norm results concern the kernel, not the arithmetic of its sum. Finite tests, countability, radix recoding and denominator support do not close the remaining argument. The settled two-prime case uses Fan’s earlier reduction to the cited Hecke–Mahler value theorem.

### Proof sources and declarations

**Proof sources.** The margin marks retain the supplied formal-source links. A Lean mark identifies the declaration or declarations associated with a statement; a Comparator mark opens its recorded comparison. These are records of earlier checks, not fresh runs for this revision. The [evidence record](#) gives the versions and individual associations. A missing mark makes no claim of a Lean proof of the whole statement. The checks concern the propositions linked there, without establishing novelty or resolving the repeated-sum problem.

The general distinct-height assertion and its four word-and-torus arguments are stated as remarks with complete ordinary proofs in Section 5.1; they have no Lean proofs. The source record reports that the general and prime-power subseries arguments were found on 26 September 2026 and checked by a second AI agent, whose corrections were incorporated. It records no human review; the present revision does not constitute a new independent review. No separate literature search for the prime-power subseries theorem at  $|P| \geq 3$  is recorded, and no priority claim is made for it. The subseries identities also have ordinary proofs. The program `two_tail.py` checks their finite instances in exact arithmetic.

For  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  the separate distinct-height theorem has a [Lean proof](#); its source record says that Comparator had not been run on it. The general affine-block calculation, decoding criterion and finite-set application are also remarks with ordinary proofs; the last additionally uses exact computation. Their formal coverage is restricted to the  $\{2, 3, 5\}$  case with one block and the interval of Section 2. The independent-clock and Smith-factor results likewise have the ordinary proofs printed here; no additional formal coverage is inferred for them.

The two-prime deduction is credited to Fan [17]. Its formal proof assumes the cited Hecke–Mahler value theorem, as specified in Section 14; its algebraic identities are unconditional. The weighted-triangle and shift identities, denominator formula, scaled dichotomy, uniqueness argument, residue limit, strip decomposition and recoding also

have written proofs here. Their individual formal associations are retained, without a blanket assertion that every result in the record is formalised. Kernel acceptance uses the standard axioms allowed by the linked checks and is not an independent review of the paper-to-statement correspondence.

The twelve-shell enclosure, denominator bound and eight mixed-radix digits have finite exact proofs. The two large exclusions have saved witnesses and exact checkers, and the larger scan has a saved run. None of these finite computations proves the residue inequalities beyond every starting index. No Comparator replay is claimed for the general or subseries arguments.

**Artefact and data availability.** The links in the source inventory and to the dyadic-window checker open a [fixed revision](#) of the repository. The witnesses and exact checkers for the two large numerical exclusions and the saved larger scan are in the [large-computation directory](#). The [distinct-height programs](#) recompute the constants of Theorem 1.1 and the certificates of Remark 5.8 in exact rational arithmetic, with two independent computations of the tail intervals, and store their outputs; a fast test checks them against the stored receipts. The same directory checks the finite illustrations of Section 5.1 and the block identity for  $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$ .

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### 13 Further examples, conditional lemmas and source references

We collect the historical statements and then separate the carry lemmas from their three-prime application. Their explicit divisibility and window hypotheses specify what another recurrence must supply. Finite examples and the declaration inventory complete the record.

### 13.1 The historical and catalogue record

For a singleton  $P = \{p\}$ , we have  $a_n = p^{n-1}$  and  $[a_1, \dots, a_n] = p^{n-1}$ , so both sums equal  $p/(p-1)$ . Erdős's 1988 account calls the infinite-prime case a simple exercise and presents irrationality for a finite number of primes greater than one as a probable extension [2, p. 106]. Bloom's catalogue records an open problem at the access date of 28 July 2026 [4]. These are dated source statements, not a fresh determination of the catalogue's present status.

In the letter written on 1 January 1973 and published in 1974, Erdős calls the irrationality of  $\mathcal{R}_P$  a conjecture that he cannot prove, and says that he can show the sum over the distinct values of  $[a_1, \dots, a_k]$  to be irrational [3, p. 335]. That sum is  $\mathcal{D}_P$ . The letter introduces its primes as  $p_1, \dots, p_s$ , later writing  $p_r$ , without restricting their number, so the singleton calculation forces the qualification  $|P| \geq 2$ . It prints no argument. The catalogue has cited the letter for Problem #269 since 28 December 2025, after the letter was quoted in the site's discussion of missing problems [5], and its page records Erdős's statement about the distinct values. The catalogue page says that Erdős proved the statement; the letter asserts it and prints no argument. Remark 5.1 proves it for every finite  $P$  with  $|P| \geq 2$ . For  $|P| = 2$  it was already a consequence of the Hecke–Mahler transcendence theorem of Loxton and van der Poorten [16, Theorem 8, p. 40] and Bugeaud and Laurent [15, Theorem 1.1], through the affine identity of Section 4, by the route Fan used for  $\mathcal{R}_{\{p,q\}}$ . We do not know what argument Erdős had in mind.

We have not found a proof of the assertion in print. Erdős and Graham state only the question for  $\mathcal{R}_P$ : the sum is irrational for infinite  $P$ , and they ask what happens for finite  $P$  with more than one element [1, p. 65]; the distinct-height sum does not appear there. Erdős's survey of 1975 on the irrationality of series [8] does not mention the running least common multiple of the  $P$ -smooth integers, his survey of 1980 on combinatorial number theory [6] does not discuss irrationality, and his survey of 1988 states only the question for  $\mathcal{R}_P$  [2, p. 106]. Every Hecke–Mahler transcendence theorem we found, including those of Loxton and van der Poorten, Bugeaud and Laurent, and Luca–Ouaknine–Worrell [26], has a single slope, and so reaches  $\mathcal{D}_P$  only for  $|P| = 2$ . The rationality criterion of Diananda and Oppenheim [7], which condenses a Cantor series into blocks of consecutive terms, has the form of the dyadic argument of Section 2; it restates rationality and does not decide  $\mathcal{D}_P$ . The discussion thread of Problem #269 contains no argument for  $\mathcal{D}_P$  with  $|P| \geq 3$ , and the *Formal Conjectures* statement [9] concerns  $\mathcal{R}_P$  only. The Cantor-series criteria of Erdős–Straus [18, Theorem 2.1] and Hančl–Tijdeman [19, Theorem 3.1] do not apply to  $\mathcal{D}_P$ , as explained in Section 2. The search did not reach the sections on irrational series in Guy's *Unsolved Problems in Number Theory*, or MathSciNet reviews. The unresolved target of this record is the repeated series  $\mathcal{R}_P$ ; a transcendence statement for  $\mathcal{D}_P$  with  $|P| \geq 3$  is a separate question (Problem 12.7).

On 26 June 2026 Steve Fan posted the two-prime factorisation, the Hecke–Mahler reduction and the transcendence conclusion in the discussion thread of the problem's page [17]; the comment itself notes that the argument does not seem to generalise immediately to  $|P| \geq 3$ , and a reply there observes that it applies to arbitrary coprime pairs. The first public version of this note is dated 22 July 2026, after Fan's post. We retain the calculation as exposition and make no priority claim for it.

The statement of the problem has been formalised as a conjecture with an unfilled proof in the *Formal Conjectures* collection [9]. In the cited source, the rational, irrational and infinite-prime assertions end in sorry. Its Nat-indexed series includes the empty-prefix least-common-multiple term, so its value differs from the conventional one by a rational constant; transporting a theorem across that boundary needs an explicit series-identification lemma, which is not supplied here.

### 13.2 The abstract carry lemmas in their general form

Consider an arbitrary integer recurrence with positive integer radices. Divisibility and the existence of escaping windows must now be supplied as hypotheses. For the actual three-prime radices, the criterion below shows that each integral carry eventually acquires the smooth part of a denominator. It still leaves the escaping-window hypothesis to be proved. The comparison with Cantor-series criteria is in Section 9.

Let  $D$  and  $B$  be positive integers with  $D = D_{\text{sm}}B$ , where  $D_{\text{sm}} = 2^u 3^v 5^w$ ,  $u, v, w \in \mathbb{N}$  and  $\gcd(B, 30) = 1$ . Let  $(c_n)$  be an integer sequence satisfying  $c_{n+1} = b_n c_n - D m_n$  for integer sequences  $(b_n)$  and  $(m_n)$ . For these general sequences, form  $W$  and  $F$  by the recursions in Section 10; an escaping window must have  $W \neq 0$ , and its modulus is  $|W|$ . In the factorisation below the quotients  $d_n$  are required to be integers; writing  $c_n = D_{\text{sm}}d_n$  asserts divisibility, not just an identity in  $\mathbb{Q}$ .

**Proposition 13.1** (conditional denominator reduction). *If  $c_n = D_{\text{sm}}d_n$  for every  $n$ , with  $D_{\text{sm}} > 0$ , then the recurrence and window identity for  $(d_n)$  have multiplier  $B$  in place of  $D$ . Moreover, for every  $n$  and every real  $t$ ,*

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$$0 < c_n \leq Dt \iff 0 < d_n \leq Bt.$$

*Proof.* Substitute  $c_n = D_{\text{sm}}d_n$  and  $D = D_{\text{sm}}B$  in the recurrence and divide by  $D_{\text{sm}}$ . Dividing  $0 < c_n \leq D_{\text{sm}}Bt$  by this positive factor gives the stated bound equivalence. Dividing the window identity  $c_{\ell+h} = W_{\ell,h}c_\ell - DF_{\ell,h}$  likewise gives  $d_{\ell+h} = W_{\ell,h}d_\ell - BF_{\ell,h}$ .  $\square$

For a general bound  $c_n \leq G(D, n)$ , division and integrality give only

$$d_n \leq \left\lfloor \frac{G(D, n)}{D_{\text{sm}}} \right\rfloor,$$

not automatically  $d_n \leq G(B, n)$ . The bounds used for the actual tails are linear in the multiplier before rounding. For any real  $t$ ,

$$\left\lfloor \frac{\lfloor Dt \rfloor}{D_{\text{sm}}} \right\rfloor = \lfloor Bt \rfloor.$$

Indeed, an integer  $z$  satisfies  $D_{\text{sm}}z \leq \lfloor Dt \rfloor$  exactly when  $D_{\text{sm}}z \leq Dt$ , or  $z \leq Bt$ . Thus rounding does not change the reduced bound in this case.

Growth of the radix product is not enough:  $b_n = 3$ ,  $m_n = 1$ ,  $D = 2$  and  $c_n = 1$  satisfy the recurrence, but 2 never divides  $c_n$ . The precise condition follows by reducing the

recurrence modulo  $D_{\text{sm}}$ . For any starting index  $A$  and every  $n \geq A$ ,

$$c_n \equiv \left( \prod_{j=A}^{n-1} b_j \right) c_A \pmod{D_{\text{sm}}},$$

$$D_{\text{sm}} \mid c_n \iff \frac{D_{\text{sm}}}{\gcd(D_{\text{sm}}, c_A)} \mid \prod_{j=A}^{n-1} b_j.$$

The congruence is an induction, since  $D_{\text{sm}} \mid D$ . For the equivalence, cancel the positive greatest common divisor; the remaining factor of  $c_A$  is coprime to the remaining modulus. Thus it is growth of the required prime valuations, not growth of the product as a real number, that ensures divisibility.

For the actual radices the product is  $P_n/P_A$ . Its valuations at 2, 3, 5 all tend to infinity, so every fixed  $D_{\text{sm}}$  eventually divides  $c_n$ , for any integral initial carry  $c_A$ . Under rationality  $S = N/D$  in lowest terms, one may start at  $A = 1$ :  $c_1 = DX_1 = N - D$  is integral and coprime to  $D_{\text{sm}}$ . Since  $P_1 = 2$ , the criterion becomes  $D_{\text{sm}} \mid P_n/2 = h_n$ , exactly the onset already obtained from the finite-prefix identity in Proposition 9.4. This is an alternative proof of the divisibility step, not an additional arithmetic hypothesis left to verify for  $S$ . The finite-prefix proof in Theorem 9.3 remains valid.

**Proposition 13.2** (escaping windows exclude a positive bounded integer solution). *Let  $(b_n)$  and  $(m_n)$  be sequences of nonnegative integers, let  $G : \mathbb{N}_{>0} \times \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ , and assume the residue condition (20) for these sequences and  $G$ , using  $|W_{\ell,h}| > 0$  as the modulus. Fix  $B > 0$  coprime to 30. There is no integral sequence  $(d_n)$  satisfying simultaneously  $d_{n+1} = b_n d_n - B m_n$ ,  $d_n > 0$  and  $|d_n| \leq G(B, n)$  for every  $n \geq 0$ .*

Lean  
Comparator

*Proof.* Choose one escaping window  $(\ell, h)$ . The window identity gives  $d_{\ell+h} \equiv -BF_{\ell,h}$  modulo  $|W_{\ell,h}|$ . The endpoint state is positive and at most  $G(B, \ell + h)$ , whereas the least positive residue of the right-hand side exceeds that bound, so Proposition 10.1 applies.  $\square$

The escape hypothesis is the substantial arithmetic assumption. It requires a residue above the bound, not just a rapidly growing product of bases. For example, the constant data  $b_n = 2$ ,  $m_n = 1$  have the positive solution  $d_n = B$ . For any bound  $G(B, n) \geq B$ , every window has  $W = 2^h$ ,  $F = 2^h - 1$  and least positive residue at most  $B$ , so the hypothesis fails. For the actual three-prime coefficients and  $G = K$ , Theorem 10.2 makes the escape hypothesis equivalent to irrationality of  $S$ . That equivalence does not hold for an arbitrary choice of  $G$ .

Coprimality with 30 selects the denominators covered by the hypothesis; once a window is fixed, the finite contradiction does not use it. The conventions cover the edge cases: a zero window base is excluded, a zero residue is represented by the full modulus, and positivity prevents the endpoint carry from vanishing. The version stated with a nonzero smooth factor assumes the exact factorisation  $c_n = D_{\text{sm}} d_n$ , the corresponding recurrence for  $(c_n)$  and the positive upper bound for  $(d_n)$ , and gives the same contradiction.

Even retaining the actual radix sequence and quadratic growth does not force irrationality if the numerators are changed. For the same  $b_a$ , prescribe the positive integer

carries  $(a + 3)^2$  and set

$$\widehat{m}_a = b_a(a + 3)^2 - (a + 4)^2.$$

The shift by three ensures positivity even at  $a = 0$ : since  $b_a \geq 2$ ,

$$\widehat{m}_a \geq 2(a + 3)^2 - (a + 4)^2 = a^2 + 4a + 2 > 0.$$

Both these integer coefficients and the prescribed carries have quadratic order, because  $2 \leq b_a \leq 30$ . Nevertheless, finite telescoping gives

$$\sum_{a=0}^{N-1} \frac{\widehat{m}_a}{P_{a+1}} = 9 - \frac{(N + 3)^2}{P_N} \rightarrow 9.$$

This example keeps the exact radices, not the actual shell multiplicities or their numerical upper bound  $Q$ . It shows why the arithmetic of the specific  $m_a$ , rather than the radix alphabet and growth orders alone, must enter a proof for  $S$ .

### 13.3 Worked finite examples

At the first ten integer cutoffs, the running LCM changes by a factor 2 at 2, 4, 8, by 3 at 3, 9, and by 5 at 5. The table in Section 3 also shows constant values on  $\{5, 6, 7\}$  and  $\{9, 10\}$ , as in Proposition 3.2. In particular,  $L(10) = 8 \cdot 9 \cdot 5 = 360$  is the LCM of 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9, 10, the supported integers at most 10.

For Proposition 3.4 take  $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$  and the box  $\mathcal{B}(1, 1, 1)$ , whose eight points carry the smooth values 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 10, 15, 30 and the heights

| $p^i q^j r^k$ | 1 | 2 | 3 | 5  | 6  | 10  | 15  | 30    |
|---------------|---|---|---|----|----|-----|-----|-------|
| H             | 1 | 2 | 6 | 60 | 60 | 360 | 360 | 10800 |

Six heights occur, two of them twice: the points 5 and 6 share the height 60, and 10 and 15 share the height 360. The identity reads

$$1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{60} + \frac{1}{60} + \frac{1}{360} + \frac{1}{360} + \frac{1}{10800} = 1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{6} + \frac{2}{60} + \frac{2}{360} + \frac{1}{10800} = \frac{18421}{10800},$$

and the two coefficients 2 carry the whole content of the regrouping on this box. Where the heights are pairwise distinct the identity is a relabelling.

Multiplying block radices along a run of blocks gives the product of the prime multipliers at the jumps in that run: for instance  $b_1 b_2 = 60$  is the product of the four multipliers at 3, 4, 5, 8. Block 4 is the only one among the first six containing an internal power of each odd prime, whereas block 5 contains neither, so its radix falls back to the terminal factor alone.

### 13.4 The finite-scan histogram

For completeness we reproduce the first-success counts from the larger scan in Section 11. It tested  $B \leq 5000$  coprime to 30 and  $100 \leq \ell \leq 3000$ , stopping each search at depth 24. The saved output ([scan-5000-100-3000.json](#)) gives 3,869,934 pairs, an escape in every case, and the following first-success histogram:

| $h$ | 4 | 5   | 6   | 7    | 8     | 9      | 10     | 11      | 12      | 13     | 14    | 15   | 16  | 17 | 18 |
|-----|---|-----|-----|------|-------|--------|--------|---------|---------|--------|-------|------|-----|----|----|
| #   | 1 | 104 | 812 | 5437 | 51409 | 237423 | 735450 | 1431226 | 1132756 | 236752 | 34910 | 3076 | 521 | 49 | 8  |

The first case attaining the maximal observed length 18 has  $B = 917$  and  $\ell = 2980$ . The smaller run ([scan-1000-100-500.json](#)) over  $B \leq 1000$  coprime to 30 and  $100 \leq \ell \leq 500$  gives 106,666 pairs and maximal first successful length 14, first attained at  $B = 359$  and  $\ell = 291$ . The two cases have the following data.

|                        | Larger scan             | Smaller scan      |
|------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------|
| Denominator $B$        | 917                     | 359               |
| Start $\ell$           | 2980                    | 291               |
| Length $h$             | 18                      | 14                |
| Endpoint jump index    | 6179                    | 627               |
| Window base            | 18139852800000000       | 5038848000000     |
| Accumulated numerator  | 13196471407660025821045 | 25864575212865807 |
| Least positive residue | 76322101735             | 213175287         |
| Upper bound            | 3896420420              | 15932659          |

These histograms concern a bounded region. The window-growth law gives a necessary lower bound on a possible escape length, not a distribution law for residues or first successful lengths. No generic-residue model is used as evidence for cofinal escape.

### 13.5 Source inventory

The table gives declaration locations at their recorded revisions. Section 12.5 explains the assumptions attached to each kind of association. Before using the table, two conventions require attention: integer division at the initial index and removal of the first shell. The Lean version of the half-height  $h_a$  is a natural number computed by integer division: its value at 0 is 0, whereas  $h_0 = 1/2$ . It agrees with  $h_a$  for  $a \geq 1$ , as the half-height identity assumes. The Lean version of the tail  $X_a$  divides after casting to  $\mathbb{R}$ , so agrees with  $X_a = h_a T_a$  at every index.

The denominator-clearing and reduced-carry lemmas assume  $T_1$  rational. The first shell consists of 1 alone, so  $T_1 = S - 1$ ; thus  $S = N/D$  supplies

$$T_1 = \frac{N - D}{D}, \quad \gcd(N - D, D) = \gcd(N, D).$$

Lean proves this translation, which preserves the denominator, its smooth factor and the clearing onset.

|                                           |                                         |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| informal statement                        | linked Lean source                      |
| integer represented by an exponent triple | <a href="#">smooth3 val</a>             |
| pure-power height                         | <a href="#">three prime height</a>      |
| lattice kernel                            | <a href="#">three prime kernel q</a>    |
| exponent triples below the cut-off        | <a href="#">smooth prefix exponents</a> |

| informal statement                  | linked Lean source                                        |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| running least common multiple       | <a href="#">smooth prefix lcm</a>                         |
| prefix value divides the height     | <a href="#">smooth3 val dvd three prime height of mem</a> |
| divisibility into the height        | <a href="#">smooth prefix lcm dvd three prime height</a>  |
| first pure-power membership         | <a href="#">pure first mem smooth prefix exponents</a>    |
| second pure-power membership        | <a href="#">pure second mem smooth prefix exponents</a>   |
| third pure-power membership         | <a href="#">pure third mem smooth prefix exponents</a>    |
| running-lcm identity                | <a href="#">smooth prefix lcm eq three prime height</a>   |
| cell relation                       | <a href="#">same three prime log cell</a>                 |
| cell constancy of the height        | <a href="#">three prime height eq of same log cell</a>    |
| cell constancy of the running value | <a href="#">smooth prefix lcm eq of same log cell</a>     |
| cell constancy of the kernel        | <a href="#">three prime kernel q eq of same log cell</a>  |
| positive power sets                 | <a href="#">positive prime powers</a>                     |
| counting positive prime powers      | <a href="#">positive prime powers card</a>                |
| exclusion of the origin             | <a href="#">one not mem positive prime powers</a>         |
| disjoint positive prime powers      | <a href="#">positive prime powers disjoint</a>            |
| union of positive prime powers      | <a href="#">three prime positive jump set</a>             |
| positive jump count                 | <a href="#">three prime positive jump set card</a>        |
| jump set with the origin            | <a href="#">three prime jump set with origin</a>          |
| jump count with the origin          | <a href="#">three prime jump set with origin card</a>     |
| first height step                   | <a href="#">three prime height first log step</a>         |
| second height step                  | <a href="#">three prime height second log step</a>        |
| third height step                   | <a href="#">three prime height third log step</a>         |
| first coordinate step               | <a href="#">smooth prefix lcm first log step</a>          |
| second coordinate step              | <a href="#">smooth prefix lcm second log step</a>         |
| third coordinate step               | <a href="#">smooth prefix lcm third log step</a>          |
| exponent box                        | <a href="#">smooth exponent box</a>                       |
| point height                        | <a href="#">smooth point height</a>                       |
| height fibre                        | <a href="#">smooth height fiber</a>                       |
| fibre sum                           | <a href="#">smooth height fiber kernel sum</a>            |

| informal statement                          | linked Lean source                                                           |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| grouping equal denominators in a finite sum | <a href="#">finite smooth kernel sum grouped by height</a>                   |
| upper bound by the cube of the cutoff       | <a href="#">three prime height le cube</a>                                   |
| origin value                                | <a href="#">kernel 235 origin</a>                                            |
| value at two                                | <a href="#">kernel 235 two</a>                                               |
| value at three                              | <a href="#">kernel 235 three</a>                                             |
| value at six                                | <a href="#">kernel 235 six</a>                                               |
| example excluding a product of two factors  | <a href="#">kernel 235 not rank one</a>                                      |
| variable-base tail step                     | <a href="#">tail state step</a>                                              |
| expanded tail step                          | <a href="#">tail state step eq</a>                                           |
| smooth exponent shell                       | <a href="#">smooth exponent shell</a>                                        |
| short-interval uniqueness                   | <a href="#">exponent unique in short interval</a>                            |
| first-coordinate projection                 | <a href="#">smooth exponent shell card le drop first</a>                     |
| third-coordinate projection                 | <a href="#">smooth exponent shell card le drop third</a>                     |
| sorted quadratic estimate                   | <a href="#">sorted pair quadratic</a>                                        |
| quadratic shell bound                       | <a href="#">smooth exponent shell card quadratic</a>                         |
| dyadic internal power                       | <a href="#">dyadic internal power</a>                                        |
| internal-power uniqueness                   | <a href="#">dyadic internal power exponent unique</a>                        |
| dyadic block base                           | <a href="#">dyadic block base235</a>                                         |
| exact dyadic radix alphabet                 | <a href="#">dyadic block base235 cases</a>                                   |
| bounded-radix consequence                   | <a href="#">dyadic block base235 mem interval</a>                            |
| a nonzero $2 \times 2$ determinant          | <a href="#">kernel 235 minor eq neg one fifteen</a>                          |
| no integer rotation orbit                   | <a href="#">no integer orbit logb of prime</a>                               |
| height factorisation                        | <a href="#">three prime height factorisation</a>                             |
| kernel factorisation                        | <a href="#">three prime kernel q factorisation</a>                           |
| two-prime outer product                     | <a href="#">two prime kernel q eq outer product</a>                          |
| two-prime vanishing minors                  | <a href="#">two prime kernel q minor two eq zero</a>                         |
| uniform minors, general form                | <a href="#">exists uniform nonsingular three prime kernel minor</a>          |
| uniform minors for primes                   | <a href="#">exists uniform nonsingular three prime kernel minor of prime</a> |
| no finite separation                        | <a href="#">not finite separable three prime kernel</a>                      |

| informal statement                            | linked Lean source                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| second-order minor                            | <a href="#">kernel 235 minor2 eq neg one fifteen</a>                    |
| third-order minor                             | <a href="#">kernel 235 minor3 eq one over 81000</a>                     |
| misleading proportional row                   | <a href="#">kernel 235 row three eq smul row zero</a>                   |
| failure of that proportionality               | <a href="#">kernel 235 row three ne smul row zero at four</a>           |
| integer numerator for one dyadic shell        | <a href="#">dyadic ordered block digit235</a>                           |
| normalised state step                         | <a href="#">dyadic normalized tail state r235 succ</a>                  |
| shell summability                             | <a href="#">summable dyadic shell mass r235</a>                         |
| infinite tail recurrence                      | <a href="#">dyadic normalized shell tsum tail r235 succ</a>             |
| integer tails or separation from the integers | <a href="#">dyadic shell tsum tail integer or cofinal far</a>           |
| boundary divisibility                         | <a href="#">smooth height mul prime dvd boundary height</a>             |
| half-height identity for $a \geq 1$           | <a href="#">two mul height normalizer235</a>                            |
| window clearing identity                      | <a href="#">height normalizer235 mul window mass eq int</a>             |
| clearing a rational $T_1$ at $a \geq 1$       | <a href="#">qsmul normalized tail state eq int of value eq rat</a>      |
| normalised-state collision                    | <a href="#">exists normalized tail state collision of value eq rat</a>  |
| least positive residue                        | <a href="#">least positive residue</a>                                  |
| positive representative range                 | <a href="#">least positive residue pos le</a>                           |
| representative congruence                     | <a href="#">least positive residue mod eq</a>                           |
| escape condition                              | <a href="#">residue escapes window</a>                                  |
| excluding a bounded positive natural number   | <a href="#">no bounded positive state of residue escape</a>             |
| contrapositive form                           | <a href="#">residue le bound of bounded positive state</a>              |
| excluding a bounded positive integer          | <a href="#">no bounded positive int state of least positive residue</a> |
| identifying the least positive representative | <a href="#">least positive residue eq nat abs of pos le mod eq</a>      |
| window base                                   | <a href="#">window base</a>                                             |
| accumulated numerator in a window             | <a href="#">window forcing</a>                                          |
| affine window identity                        | <a href="#">affine recurrence window</a>                                |
| scaling the accumulated numerator             | <a href="#">window forcing const mul</a>                                |
| integral carry window                         | <a href="#">integral carry window</a>                                   |

|                                                    |                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| informal statement                                 | linked Lean source                                        |
| endpoint residue identification                    | least positive residue window forcing eq carry            |
| divisibility by the smooth part of the denominator | smooth3 val dvd three prime height of le                  |
| common-factor cancellation                         | integral carry cancel common factor                       |
| bound after dividing out the common factor         | reduced carry pos le of common factor                     |
| window identity after division                     | reduced integral carry window                             |
| cofinal window hypothesis                          | cofinal local window escape                               |
| escape excludes a reduced positive integer carry   | no positive reduced carry of cofinal local window escape  |
| the same contradiction with a common factor        | no positive absorbed carry of cofinal local window escape |
| real window identity                               | true normalized state window                              |
| escape from irrationality, general bound           | cofinal local window escape of irrational of beaten       |
| escape from irrationality, quadratic family        | cofinal local window escape of irrational of quadratic    |
| escape from irrationality, actual bound            | cofinal local window escape of irrational                 |
| residue criterion equivalent to an irrational tail | actual cofinal local window escape iff                    |
| residue criterion equivalent to an irrational sum  | actual cofinal local window escape iff irrational value   |
| rational $T_1$ gives eventual integer carries      | exists reduced carry of value eq rat                      |
| residue condition for the actual series            | actual cofinal local window escape                        |
| irrationality from the residue condition           | irrational value of cofinal local window escape           |
| bounded-radix alternative                          | bounded radix zero or cofinal far                         |
| rational value from an integral scaled tail        | rational of scaled tail integer                           |
| zero block sums as differences of potentials       | channel block null iff channel potential                  |
| a nonzero error exceeds the bound at one index     | no carry lift of error bound below two pow                |

| informal statement                                                              | linked Lean source                                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| a nonzero error cannot stay uniformly bounded                                   | <a href="#">no bounded carry lift of block null two anchors</a>                 |
| first-block sum                                                                 | <a href="#">binary lift two anchors force first block sum one</a>               |
| four states cannot meet all three conditions                                    | <a href="#">no unit accurate lift with two anchors and first two block null</a> |
| carry as a residue plus a potential difference                                  | <a href="#">carry eq residue digit add coboundary</a>                           |
| carry interval                                                                  | <a href="#">carry residue mem interval</a>                                      |
| digit interval                                                                  | <a href="#">residue digit mem interval</a>                                      |
| map from formal expressions to functions                                        | <a href="#">cartier realisation</a>                                             |
| finite-dimensional span of the resulting functions                              | <a href="#">finite realised span of factorisation</a>                           |
| interval containing a Cantor-series tail                                        | <a href="#">state mem ioo</a>                                                   |
| state gap bound                                                                 | <a href="#">state gap lower bound</a>                                           |
| small-form criterion                                                            | <a href="#">irrational of small nonzero forms</a>                               |
| irrationality from clearing and small nonzero gaps                              | <a href="#">irrational of clearing and small gaps</a>                           |
| indices giving the threshold staircase                                          | <a href="#">staircase indices</a>                                               |
| finite threshold-column rank, including the extreme-column defect               | <a href="#">finite cut rank</a>                                                 |
| uniform admissible modular minors, with indices chosen before modulus and layer | <a href="#">uniform modular minors</a>                                          |

## 14 Dependencies and remaining questions

The table separates the established special cases from the ordinary generalisations awaiting formalisation and the unresolved repeated-sum condition. Exact kernel rank concerns separation of a function; the residue criterion concerns a scalar sum and still needs arithmetic existence for its windows.

| Result                          | Dependency and limit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Height and cells                | Prime-power divisibility and unique factorisation. Their geometry alone gives no irrationality statement.                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Two-prime values                | Earlier factorisation plus the cited external Hecke–Mahler value theorem. The reduction to that theorem is checked in Lean; the theorem itself is a cited input (Section 14).                                                                                                                                                   |
| Distinct-height sums, every $P$ | Integrality of the scaled tails, rearranged chains at a return of the logarithmic flow, Kronecker’s theorem and an Euler characteristic count on a two-dimensional subtorus. Ordinary proof checked by a second agent; no Lean proof. It stops for the repeated sums because their scaled tails are unbounded.                  |
| Single-prime sub-sums           | The same two-tail comparison with the carry $f_p$ and a chain chosen near the origin of the torus; no two-wall lemma. Ordinary proof checked by a second agent; no Lean proof. Says nothing about the whole repeated sum.                                                                                                       |
| Distinct-height sums, dyadic    | Dyadic blocks, finitely many affine maps with disjoint images, integrality of the scaled tails and the irrationality of $\log p / \log q$ . The theorem for $\{2, 3, 5\}$ is checked in Lean; the general criterion has an ordinary proof, and Remark 5.8 adds exact finite computations. No statement about the repeated sums. |
| Arbitrary-order rank            | Diagonal rescaling, separate one-dimensional densities and a staircase determinant; checked in Lean.                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Tail recurrence                 | Counting the original multiplicities, normalising by half the boundary height, and convergence; an abstract recurrence would not identify the sum.                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Denominator reduction           | A finite prefix with cleared denominators and an upper bound for positive integer tails. The first valid index is determined exactly (Proposition 9.4); checked in Lean.                                                                                                                                                        |
| Residue criterion               | The actual recurrence, a dominating bound and window products comparable to $8^h$ ; escape at arbitrarily late starts remains unproved.                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Weighted differences            | Exact reindexing and the contributions of the new boundary strips; integer enumeration checks the displayed counterexample to third-difference cancellation.                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Finite computations             | Direct checks settle only their individual windows. The two large exclusions have published witnesses and exact checkers, and the larger scan a published saved run; none is a theorem input.                                                                                                                                   |

None of these results proves irrationality of the repeated sum  $\mathcal{R}_p$  for three or more primes.

### The formal two-prime reduction

The source note in Section 12.5 distinguishes ordinary proofs from individual formal associations. For Theorem 1.2, the Lean development verifies the reduction of that theorem to the transcendence of the Hecke–Mahler boundary sum at an irrational  $\theta \in (0, 1)$  and nonzero algebraic  $\beta, \alpha$  with  $|\beta| < 1$  and  $|\beta||\alpha|^\theta < 1$ , which is Theorem 1.1 of Bugeaud and Laurent [15] in the case  $\rho = 0$ , due to Loxton and van der Poorten [16, Theorem 8, p. 40]. Lean does not prove that input; the Lean theorem assumes it. The formal development checks the following parts of the reduction: the running least-common-multiple identity, the selection of the single power of  $q$  between consecutive powers of  $p$ , the factorisation of the repeated sum, the identification of the distinct running values, the telescoping identity, the boundary identity (6) expressing  $A$  through the Hecke–Mahler sum, the irrationality of  $\log p / \log q$ , and each side condition verified before the value theorem is applied. The two identities expressing  $\mathcal{D}_{\{p,q\}}$  and  $\mathcal{R}_{\{p,q\}}$  as polynomials in  $A$  are unconditional and carry no additional input.

A theorem whose own statement is conditional is formalised exactly as stated. Theorem 1.2 is asserted unconditionally in this record, and its Lean counterpart carries the additional named input described here.

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